till our lonely limbs collide

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31843960.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra)

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by driluth

Summary

There’s not a body. It would be unnerving, if Glimmer weren’t already used to mourning somebody without a grave. The closest thing they have now is an ice sculpture Frosta made for She-Ra, standing in the garden, tall and preserved. A princess, a story, a legend.

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"She-Ra is gone," should have been a statement that ended the war. It should have been a victory. For bitter months, there was nothing Catra had wanted more than to get rid of She-Ra for good, she just wanted Adora to come back home. Adora herself wasn't supposed to disappear in the process.

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A canon divergent AU where Adora chooses to stay in the portal and Angella lets her.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Who hasn't ever wondered: am I a monster or is this what it means to be a person?"

— Clarice Lispector

PROLOGUE

The first time Catra went into the Whispering Woods, the world ended, only Catra didn't know it yet. She couldn't have foreseen the sword and the fractures it would create. She couldn't have imagined something calling to Adora in the middle of the night, old magic and destiny—something Catra now knows is synonymous with ruin. She just knew that Adora wanted to cheer her up, because Adora was kind that way. And it worked, speeding away on the skiff was the longest Catra had gone without her smile vanishing. It was the furthest from Shadow Weaver she'd ever been.

This time, the world ends in a literal way. It makes sense that Adora dragged Catra back to the woods against her will. It's the same place where Adora first disappeared, where it all went wrong.

Everything shakes—the ground, Catra's stomach—nothing is steady, not even Adora's voice. Uncharacteristically afraid and unsure, Adora's lips tremble as she says, "I won't leave you behind again."

Deep down, Catra wants to believe in Adora's sincerity, but it's too late for them now. Adora had left her behind in their first world without a second thought, and she's going to leave her behind in this one, too.

“Why can’t you just stay?” Catra asks, anyway. That’s what she really wants, she would confess it to Adora if she thought it would make a difference. “We have everything we ever wanted.”

Adora replies by telling her it isn’t real, as if Catra wasn’t already *aware* of that. A world where Adora stays with her is a kinder world than Catra deserves. But Adora doesn't know these rules, so she reaches for Catra as if she could heal her splintered heart by touch alone. Catra shoves Adora off. She’s easier to push as Adora than She-Ra. Adora might be stronger than she was in the Horde, even without She-Ra, but Catra’s stronger now, too. Without Adora holding her back, she’s stronger than she’s ever been.

Adora, the fool, runs after her. “Why did you do it?” she asks.

Catra denies the truth, even though it’s no use; the world is collapsing. Denial won’t buy them time. The ground shakes violently, unrelenting, as if it’s been holding a grudge against the woods. Adora says they have to leave, but Catra doesn’t hear it, she holds her arms close and shuts her eyes. One of Catra’s earliest memories is of Adora at five, with a gap in her front teeth, making a promise she’ll eventually break. Fifteen years later, Adora stands behind her, repeating those same words, as if she could remedy the first promise she broke.

Something in Catra has been gnawing at itself, but now it cracks. She laughs. She laughs with everything she has. Adora doesn’t get to see her cry, not now, not ever again. Catra isn’t a little kid who needs someone to look out for her anymore. She sees the way Adora’s face falls, eyes wet, hurt, betrayed. Catra’s all too familiar with what betrayal looks like, she hopes Adora likes the taste of her own medicine.

“You’re going to destroy everything!” Adora says, as if Catra’s whole world hasn’t been destroyed, twice now, by Adora’s hand.

“I don’t care. I won’t let you win; I’d rather see the whole world end than let that happen,” Catra says. She means it with every cell of her body.

The earth opens up. As the world floods with white and purple light, Catra realizes this is *it*, a childhood prophecy, *"Together at the end of the world,"* Adora had once said. Turns out Adora is capable of keeping one of her promises after all. Granted, these aren't the circumstances Catra imagined: it should have been the two of them together, wearing Force Captain badges. They should have been older, too—with graying hair and skin marked with battle scars. They shouldn't have been on opposite sides of the crossfire.

Catra pulls Adora closer. And then there's a rift—an actual, physical rift—between them. Catra falls. There's some irony, Catra thinks, as she's the one barely hanging on to the ledge before her. The earth under her palm is damp, difficult to hold on to.

And it's almost laughable, the way Adora still reaches out for her, as if Catra could grab her hand without dragging Adora down with her in the process. Catra hates Adora for the gesture. She hates that even after everything, Adora is still playing the hero, reaching for Catra as if saving her will make everything better.

Catra doesn't want to be saved. She doesn't want to be saved by Adora especially. So she narrows her eyes at Adora, and lets herself fall.

*

Catra's sitting on the floor of Hordak's sanctum. She blinks. That's not right—she was just fifteen feet away, right by the switch. No, she was in Adora's bedroom, waking her up—but Adora never had her own bedroom in the Fright Zone, she always slept in the bunk below Catra's. No, Catra was in the Whispering Woods with Adora—what were they doing there?

Her cheek is sore and Catra rubs it, tenderly, trying to recall the source of its pain.

A vortex bright and blue and menacing opens out of thin air. It has to be the portal. Catra *did* pull the switch, she remembers now.

(She remembers Adora sticking up for her, begging Shadow Weaver to let her bring Catra to Thaymor, she remembers blue eyes shining with pride because they took down Thaymor together, she remembers Adora's arm around her in the hallway, and in the locker room, their hands together, fingers entwined, their spot on the roof—Adora seemed scared but Adora never looks scared, and they were in the woods, again, Adora saying the word promise and not meaning it.)

There's a magical chiming sound, and the light only gets brighter. Catra braces herself for Adora to step out, Adora the hero, the savior, the one who fixes things.

A figure does emerge into view, but she's far too tall to be Adora, even as She-Ra. She has wings.

It's the queen. Catra's fairly certain her name has something to do with angels, Entrapta tried to explain the mythology behind it once. But her appearance doesn't make any sense. The queen didn't come to the Horde to rescue Adora with the others. The queen has never left her castle for as long as Catra's been fighting.

So why is she here now?

Catra stands up, scans around. There are all the princesses, and Arrow Boy, accompanied by Shadow Weaver. (Catra briefly remembers acceptance, the warmth of her touch—before remembering that it wasn't real.) Catra feels like she's going to be sick. Catra looks around again, back to where Adora was tied up. The bindings are still there on the columns, unbroken. The cloth that covered her mouth is on the floor. Catra frowns.

It doesn't make any sense. Adora was *there*, Catra made sure of it. She didn't take her eyes off of her when she pulled the switch.

"I didn't make you pull the switch," Adora's voice says, an echo, far away. But Catra can't recall when Adora ever said that to her. Catra closes her eyes, trying to picture the way Adora looked when—her eyes flash open. The lab is *shaking*, Hordak's portal machine is falling apart, and everything else looks like it's about to shatter. Catra doesn't have time to look for Adora, she shouldn't waste her energy wondering where she is in the first place. It's not like Adora would give her the same courtesy.

"Where's Adora?" someone asks. Catra thinks it's the sparkly one.

"There's no time to explain," the queen answers. "We have to get out of here, now!"

The princesses are retreating, that gives Catra some relief—she doesn't think she has the strength to fight right now. But before she exits the room, she does another quick sweep: Adora's not here, the queen is right. It's more disappointing than anything. Catra won this round, and Adora doesn't even have the decency to let Catra gloat. That's all it is.

It's not concern at all.

ONE MONTH LATER

Adora's sword is heavy, Glimmer doesn't know how Adora carried it with one hand as if it weighed nothing. Maybe it was lighter for her, for She-Ra, or perhaps Adora was just that strong. But Glimmer carries it solemnly without complaining. If Swift Wind notices that she's struggling, he doesn't say anything. He hasn't been his usual playful self; he hasn't sung once since Adora stayed behind.

"Are you sure this is a good idea?" Swift Wind asks. "It hasn't worked before."

“That doesn’t mean we should stop trying,” Glimmer replies, her patience wearing thin. It’s still strange to walk alongside Swift Wind without Adora around. Glimmer would prefer to teleport to the Crystal Castle on her own, but she’ll need every bit of magic she can use once the mechanical spiders get summoned. They're getting easier to fight now.

“I know but, I was She-Ra’s steed, you’re a princess who has She-Ra’s sword, and Light Hope is still ignoring us.”

For an entity whose purpose is to serve She-Ra, Light Hope doesn’t seem to care that Adora is missing. If she does, she hasn't indicated so. Light Hope hasn't revealed herself to Glimmer this entire time, Glimmer's only encountered the spiders.

“Light Hope can’t keep ignoring us forever,” Glimmer huffs. “Not if she wants to bring She-Ra back.” It’s easier to call her She-Ra than Adora. Adora was her friend, a dear one, and now she's lost. She-Ra was the heart of the Rebellion. Glimmer knows there's really no distinction, but she has to separate them in her mind to process. She tried explaining it to Bow once, but he didn't understand. She thinks she accidentally offended him.

But Swift Wind doesn't try to correct her.

“Have you still not been able to sense her anywhere?” Glimmer asks. She had hoped that since She-Ra and Swift Wind have a sacred bond, he would be able to find where she is. But unsurprisingly, the bond doesn't seem to transcend realities. He wasn’t even sentient when the portal took over.

Swift Wind sighs. “Sometimes I think I can pick up a trace, but it disappears before I can pinpoint it. I—I don’t think it’s really her, though. I just want it to be.”

Glimmer nods. “I understand, it doesn’t feel like she’s really gone. Sometimes it feels like I’m going to find her sneaking around in the kitchen or goofing around in the courtyard.”

Swift Wind laughs. “That sounds like Adora,” he says. “I miss her.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer says sadly, “me, too.”

There’s not a body. It would be unnerving, if Glimmer weren’t already used to mourning somebody without a grave. The closest thing they have now is an ice sculpture Frosta made for She-Ra, standing in the garden, tall and preserved. A princess, a story, a legend. Glimmer grew up on tales of bravery, princesses with their trials, princesses in other wars. The princesses rarely died, in the stories. And none of them were as brave as Adora.

But the problem is, Adora isn’t dead, she’s stuck between two worlds: one functional, one broken. Glimmer’s not going to spend any more time mourning her when there’s a chance they can still find her and bring her back home.

At first, Glimmer had been clinging to the hope that Entrapta was mistaken—that once reality was restored, Adora would appear, somewhere. But she hasn’t. A month has passed and they’re not any closer to finding her, and as skilled as Bow is with tech, he can’t make a portal. But Glimmer’s certain that if they have the sword, they might not need to rely on science alone. The sword itself is magic and it's connected to Adora. If they can find a way to access its magic, they might be able to use it to pull her through to this plane. But Glimmer won’t know if this is remotely possible without Light Hope’s help.

The woods are starting to look familiar to Glimmer, now.

“We’re almost there,” Swift Wind says nervously.

Glimmer braces herself. She's lost count of the number of times she and Swift Wind have tried to contact Light Hope, but each time, an unseen holographic voice calls her an intruder, and sends forth mechanical spiders. It doesn’t matter that Glimmer has said the correct keywords, that she has brought the sword, that she has shouted the news of Adora’s disappearance over and over until her voice went hoarse. The Crystal Castle has dismissed her.

“Are you ready to face those spiders again?” Glimmer asks.

Swift Wind groans in response. He opens the door, and they enter.

The usual holographic woman isn’t there to greet them, and thankfully, there are no spiders in sight either. Even without them, the place is creepy, Glimmer can’t comprehend how Adora was so willing to train here every week. The castle is colorful with its vibrant reds and blues, but at the same time it’s an ancient and hollow place, a shell of what the First Ones had created. Glimmer grinds her molars. This place had remained untouched for a thousand years, waiting for She-Ra. Now She-Ra is gone, and there isn’t a single sign that the castle or its inhabitants know.

"You go first," Glimmer says.

Swift Wind clears his throat. “It is I, Swift Wind, She-Ra’s noble steed, and I demand that you show yourself, so we can bring She-Ra back!” There's the sound of Swift Wind's words echoing through every chamber, but as it fades, they're only met with silence. There's not even the faintest metallic footstep from a spider. "You try," Swift Wind says, hiding his face with one of his wings.

“Light Hope!” Glimmer calls loudly. “Please,” she says, quieter this time. “I’ve tried to tell you before but Adora—she’s stuck in the portal Catra made.” There's nothing. Glimmer drops the sword, letting it clammer on the ground. “Don’t you care? She-Ra is gone! Etheria needs you to help us bring her back!"

The only thing Glimmer hears is the sound of Swift Wind breathing. She summons magic and releases it across the room, shimmery and hopeless.

"Well, at least there aren't any spiders this time," Swift Wind says cheerfully.

Glimmer sighs. "At least when there were spiders, it meant Light Hope was acknowledging our presence. The silence is a bad sign."

Swift Wind walks in place, his hooves clacking on the ground. "What should we do now?"

Glimmer crosses her arms. "We'll wait, for a bit. Light Hope has to be in here somewhere, right?"

"I don't think she can leave the castle," Swift Wind answers. "At least, I haven't seen her leave the castle. So, who knows!" he says exasperatedly. "Who knows," he says again, softly. “She’s probably in the system somewhere, waiting for us to leave.”

“Well, she’s not going to get rid of us that easily,” Glimmer says. She picks up the sword from the floor and sets it down on a flatter piece of crystal. She takes a seat next to it, and fiddles with her thumbs.

“We’re going to miss the alliance meeting if we stay here much longer,” Swift Wind points out. Glimmer remains silent, and Swift Wind hums as he senses her lack of concern. “You planned on skipping the meeting today, didn’t you.”

“There’s nothing new to talk about,” Glimmer says curtly. “The Horde isn’t even actively fighting us right now. I think they can hold the meeting without me."

Glimmer doesn't even know if Catra's aware that She-Ra's gone, she hasn't encountered her since they had to flee the Fright Zone. But her attacks have ceased with Adora’s absence. The entirety of the Horde seems to be in suspense, there hasn't been a single bot attack. Glimmer’s not sure why. Surely if the Horde knows that She-Ra’s gone, they would have tried to strike them down, now that their most powerful opponent is out of the way.

Alternatively, it’s possible Catra is grieving Adora’s own loss in her own way, but Glimmer’s skeptical. She was there in the lab, a witness to Catra’s spite as she pulled the switch. Catra was going to do whatever it took, and she did. Glimmer will never forgive her for it. It's this thought that makes her want to cry.

“I was attuned to Adora’s emotions, you know,” Swift Wind says pointedly.

“You’re not attuned to mine,” she replies.

“No, but I can tell you’re upset,” he says. “Adora made the same face when she was thinking about Catra.”

Glimmer blinks. “How did you—”

“I’m a magical being,” Swift Wind says, pleased with himself. “I know things. Like how you’ve been avoiding Bow and Queen Angella.”

Glimmer flinches when he mentions her mother. She hasn’t looked her in the eye since she delivered Adora’s final words.

“I don’t understand,” Glimmer says, once all of them are back in Bright Moon. “Where’s Adora?”

“Adora said she had to be the one to close the portal,” Angella says gently. Weepy and anguished, she adds, “She wanted me to pass on all her love, she said she was sorry that she had to stay behind.”

Glimmer pushes herself out of Angella’s embrace.

“You just let her stay there?” Glimmer asks.

“Glimmer, my darling—”

“I don’t want to hear it!” Glimmer says. It doesn’t matter that reality is back. Glimmer feels like she’s going to be sick. She had her dad back, briefly, and lost him. Glimmer could accept that, then, she had lost him once before. She can’t accept that Adora’s gone.

“I’m not avoiding Bow on purpose,” Glimmer says. “It’s complicated.” It wasn't always. Sure, Glimmer has sometimes felt that the two of them have been skirting around something that

might be more than platonic, but she doesn't let herself think about him like that these days. They're both guilty. Back in the portal, they had listened as Entrapta explained that someone would have to stay in the portal and close it.

When Bow and Glimmer dissolved with the light, they thought they were making it easier for Adora. The portal was following her, and she was trying to protect them, they thought they were unburdening her. But the key to the portal was the sword, and the sword belonged—belongs—to Adora. Of course Adora would find the sword and stay behind. Who else would have made that choice willingly?

She has a hard time looking at Bow without being reminded of their shared guilt. It's been a month, and they still haven't talked about it. Glimmer doesn't think she can tell Swift Wind, or anyone else the truth until she and Bow address what happened. But she’s not ready yet.

“Well, I’m here to listen,” Swift Wind says. “I’ll skip the meeting too, in protest. Do you believe that after everything, I still don't have my own chair at the table?"

Glimmer laughs. “I’ll make sure you get your chair,” she says.

*

Glimmer ends up teleporting them back to the garden with She-Ra's ice sculpture. She doesn't have to bother re-charging this time, thanks to the absence of spiders.

“Care to go snack on some apples with me?” Swift Wind asks.

Glimmer shakes her head. “Maybe a different time,” she says.

“Suit yourself,” Swift Wind says, taking off into the air.

Glimmer laughs. "Some things never change," Glimmer tells the She-Ra sculpture. *I hope you're okay, wherever you are,* she thinks. The sculpture doesn't answer. The flowers surrounding it sway delicately with a breeze, and birds sing. They don't know that Adora's gone. It's strange how the rest of the world can move on so easily.

Glimmer finds herself holding her breath as there's a sudden stillness in the garden—covered with shadow, the flowers stop swaying, and the birds stop singing.

"I take it that the First Ones' artifacts refused to see you," a voice says from behind her. It's a false concern, Glimmer can recognize that now. Shadow Weaver's deception is smooth, subtle.

"It's none of your business," Glimmer says. She turns to face her. Shadow Weaver is alone, which happens sometimes—to Angella's dismay. "Where are your guards?"

Shadow Weaver smiles slightly, and that's enough for Glimmer to recognize danger. But she has questions. Angella's information on the First Ones is limited, and even though Bow has gone back to his fathers' library, they haven't been able to find anything useful. But the First Ones had a better understanding of magic, and Shadow Weaver is a sorceress, or at least, she used to be one. "What do you know about the First Ones?" she asks.

"I know that the holograms they've left behind are... outdated. You won't find much use for them."

"They're not completely useless," Glimmer argues. "One of them was training Adora before—"

"Before she sacrificed herself. Yes, princess, I am aware. What are you going to do when the Horde defeats us because you've wasted too much time trying to get a hologram's attention? It will be of no use to you. What you need is to strengthen your magic. I can help you do that."

Glimmer frowns. “What I need is the First Ones' understanding of magic. Even at your strongest, you don't have what it takes to reach Adora—wherever she is."

Shadow Weaver hums. "I was able to siphon magic from a runestone once before," she reminds her. She points to the sword. "The sword is no different."

Glimmer hugs the sword closer to her. "I'm not going to let you steal magic from Adora's sword."

"I could teach you how to take it for yourself, princess," Shadow Weaver says. "Surely Adora wouldn't mind, not if it was you."

Glimmer winces. The last time Shadow Weaver "taught" her anything, she took too much magic from her. The transporting, the shadow magic, the waves of electricity—Glimmer had felt sorry for Catra, at the time.

“Guards!” Glimmer calls.

Glimmer gives Shadow Weaver her best glare and stands as tall as she can, watching the guards escort Shadow Weaver back to her quarters.

*

When Glimmer retires to her own quarters, they're already occupied. Thankfully, said occupier is Bow, not her mother.

He's sitting on her alcove, tinkering with an arrow. His eyes stay pointedly focused on the arrow as he says, “You went back to the Crystal Castle, didn’t you,” he says.

“I had to try again,” Glimmer replies. “I’m sorry for not telling you, I—”

“I wouldn’t have stopped you, but I would have liked to know,” Bow glances at her warily. “With Adora gone—I don’t want to have to worry about where you are, too.”

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer says again.

“It’s okay,” Bow says. Glimmer doesn’t think it really is okay, but suspects Bow wants to move forward, for now. “Did anything interesting happen this time?"

Glimmer shakes her head and sits down next to him. “There weren’t even any spiders. It was completely empty.”

“That doesn’t sound good,” Bow says.

“I know,” Glimmer says. “I just don’t understand why Light Hope won’t even try to help us.”

“It doesn’t make any sense to me either,” Bow says, frowning. "Why wouldn't she want to help Adora? She has to know she's missing, right?"

"Trust me, I've made the message clear," Glimmer says. She sighs. If they can’t reach Light Hope, she doesn’t know what the Rebellion’s next move should be. "Did I miss anything important from the meeting today?"

Bow shakes his head. "There still aren't any bots. Mermista thinks we should use this time to be on the offensive, but Perfuma thinks we should wait till the Horde actually starts attacking us again,” Bow pauses, and looks at Glimmer cautiously. “And... Angella was worried about you.”

Glimmer avoids his eyes and sighs. “I still don’t get why she’s able to call meetings in the first place, considering she’s the reason we lost She-Ra.”

“Adora—” Bow says, as if he’s correcting her, but then he stops himself. “She wouldn’t want you to ignore your mom. It’s not her fault Adora—”

“Maybe I’m not ready to forgive her yet,” Glimmer says, hating the way her bottom lip quivers. She doesn’t blame her mom for all of it, she blames herself and Bow for thinking Adora could handle this on her own, she blames Adora for choosing to stay behind at all, and she blames Catra for setting off the portal in the first place.

“Okay,” Bow concedes. “You don’t have to forgive her but, I think you should talk to her, Glimmer. It might help.”

“Help what, exactly?” Glimmer waves her hand up. “It’s not like she can go back and—”

“And what, take Adora’s place in the portal instead?”

“What?” Glimmer blinks. She had never thought about that alternative. “No, I don’t want anyone to stay trapped there. I just want Adora back!” She can’t hold back her tears anymore, she lets them fall, warm and angry.

Bow hugs her, and she cries harder. “I want her back, too,” he says. “Maybe… maybe if we can convince Entrapta to be our ally again, she could figure out—”

“Entrapta’s portal is what got us stuck here in the first place," Glimmer says, wiping at her eyes. "And something was wrong with it, it was imbalanced—that's why someone had to stay behind. If science can make a faulty portal, I don't see why magic couldn't make a better one."

“I thought you couldn’t reach Light Hope in the Crystal Castle,” Bow says.

“I’m not done trying. The First Ones… they *knew* how to control magic. They connected it to the sword, and the sword’s connected to Adora, through She-Ra. If Light Hope can’t bring her back—” Glimmer looks around. She knows Shadow Weaver’s powers are limited now, not gone, but Glimmer wouldn’t be surprised if she was still using her spies to listen to them. “Shadow Weaver might —”

“Please stop that train of thought,” Bow says.

“I know,” Glimmer says. “I still have my grievances with her too. But if Light Hope can’t help us, maybe Shadow Weaver will. Otherwise—” well, it’s not looking good for Etheria’s future. “I don’t know if we can win this war without She-Ra, she brought—” hope, laughter, life, love.

“She brought the rebellion together,” Bow agrees. “If we can’t—if we can’t get her soon, we have to prioritize defeating the Horde. When Adora does come back, it’d be nice to welcome her back to a more peaceful world. It’s what she deserves.”

"We owe her, Bow," she says quietly.

Bow shifts in his seat. “I should get going, I guess.”

“Wait!” Glimmer says. “You can stay, if you wanted.” They haven’t had a sleepover since Adora left. Glimmer can’t remember the last time she and Bow spent the night together, alone.

“Are you sure?” Bow asks. There’s still so much left unsaid, Glimmer doesn’t know how much longer they can avoid it.

“I’m sure,” Glimmer says. She wants to say she misses him, but it would sound strange, they still see each other almost every day.

“Okay,” Bow says. “I’ll stay.”

She pulled your tail once when you were children, out of curiosity. She was only five or six, but you were also that age, so you got her back: you tugged her ponytail, fine and fair. She never pulled it again, after that, if any other kid looked at your tail for too long she would get defensive, because she knew it hurt. Likewise, you

glared at anyone if they looked like they wanted to mess with her hair.

But you're not kids anymore, and Adora thinks she's drowning.

Nothing here in this portal is real, you're not sure you're even real, you're just aching memories—some aren't even yours, you think—and anger. But you don't suppose Adora knows these rules, and she thinks she's drowning. She was never the best swimmer, neither were you. But you lift her head up above the fake water, pulling her hair in its somehow still intact ponytail. Really you're doing her a favor, but she won't see it. Since she's no longer a child either, she doesn't try to pull your tail in retaliation.

She gasps for air, and you tilt your head. This girl used to be the only reason you were still alive, that's what Shadow Weaver used to say, anyway. Perhaps right now, you're the only two left alive, if you even count, that is.

"You took everything *from me," you say to her. She doesn't look like she believes you, and she doesn't understand. She is—was—everything to you, once. You still know all her weaknesses, she used to know yours. If she still knew yours, she would have defeated you already. She might have been able to convince you to switch sides.*

You continue to taunt her. You've always been full of anger. This is nothing new. You've tried to swallow it back, but anger festers, a fever, a burn. (When you were young and burned your tail on the incinerator, she tended it, bandaged it, and stole supplies to do so.) It's easier to blame her than accept your part in this. But you're not entirely lying. If she never came through the portal, she would never have broken your heart, and you wouldn't be in this predicament now.

And what a predicament it is. You've always wanted her attention, and now you have it.

And she hits you, as Adora. Adora never fought you, not as herself, only as She-Ra. But She-Ra's not around. "I didn't make you pull the switch," she says. She always was infuriating that way, thinking that she was in the right. She still thinks she's right.

And you burn. Have you ever not? Was there ever a time those blue eyes looked at you and you weren't warm all over?

You hate her, you think.

*

Catra has been a force captain for nearly two years now, and she's still not used to being the only one in her room. When Catra first moved into her private quarters, sometimes she would still wake up convinced she was in the barracks with everyone else, expecting to hear Adora's snores below her. It took her a while to get used to the silence, not that the Fright Zone is ever completely silent, there is permanent whirring and humming from its machinery.

She knows better than to wake up thinking she's near Adora, but for a few, short-lasting seconds, Catra forgets that Adora is gone. That *she's* the reason she's gone. The sinking feeling in her chest is what reminds her.

"She-Ra is gone," should have been a statement that ended the war. It should have been a victory. For bitter months, there was nothing Catra had wanted more than to get rid of She-Ra for good, she just wanted Adora to come back home. Adora herself wasn't supposed to disappear in the process.

But when Scorpia had said those words joyously and reluctantly, Catra couldn't share her joy, couldn't celebrate the Horde's inevitable win.

"What do you mean she's gone?" she had asked, teeth clenched. She didn't believe it, at first. She thought it was a ploy, a trick. She thought the Rebellion was lying, with the intention of luring out the Horde in order for She-Ra to appear out of nowhere and smite them all.

So they held back for two weeks. And when Catra realized it wasn't a lie, that She-Ra really was gone, she lost all motivation. Hordak didn't seem inspired either, so they've all been sitting, waiting for the next move.

Catra doesn't know what her last words to Adora were. Or rather, she doesn't know which one counts. She remembers her anger in the portal, but she doesn't remember saying what she said. It only comes back to her in shadowed nightmares. It's the icy guilt that prevents her from falling back asleep. She tells it to fuck off, she shouldn't care. Nothing is going to stop the Horde from winning, with She-Ra gone.

Catra crawls out of bed, brushes and straightens her hair. That's a thing she makes time for, now. Her hair tufts are gone, so is her innocence, she supposes. So is Adora.

She read somewhere once that people wear black when they're in mourning. That has nothing to do with the almost entirely black outfit she wears now. It had started with the sleeve, for her arm, which burned for weeks after the incident with the portal. Ointment didn't help, and neither did ice packs. Then, the heat died, leaving her arm a permanent deep, icy cold she hasn't felt since the Northern Reach. So, she donned a black sleeve, and eventually got everything else to match. Her arm isn't as icy as it was a week ago, but sometimes she still shivers.

Scorpia was the only one to acknowledge the outfit change, she asked, *"New look?"* and Catra only growled in response. But she doesn't feel the need to growl anymore, she doesn't feel the need to feel anything anymore, aside from the taste of victory. If Adora's gone, she's going to finish what she started. She might as well go all out. She can't let Adora's absence go to waste.

She avoids the cafeteria, she thinks she finally lost the appetite for ration bars, anyway. She'll eat something from contraband later, if she remembers.

Hordak's lab is the same wreck it was when the princesses were here. It's full of broken machinery and tools Catra doesn't know the names of. Entrapta knows—Entrapta would know. She still haunts this place. The whole Fright Zone is filled with ghosts and judging by the way Hordak is sulking in his corner, she's not the only one who sees them.

Catra shakes her head, she can't think about ghosts and lost princesses and shadows. She needs to talk some sense into Hordak. Their troops are growing restless, and that makes them dangerous. It's the longest they've been bound to the Fright Zone.

"Our troops aren't doing any good just sitting around," she tells Hordak.

"We shouldn't waste any more of our resources," he says, gesturing to the shattered equipment in front of him. "Not after you depleted so many when the portal failed."

"Failed?" Catra asks. She crosses her arms. "I don't know what you're talking about. She-Ra is gone. The Rebellion will crumble without her." Catra could point out that Hordak was stuck in the same place for *decades* before She-Ra was even a threat to the Horde. But she's feeling generous today, and she doesn't think the little ego he has left could survive that. "Now is the best time for us to strike," she says.

Hordak only grunts in response—great with words, as always. Imp flits around behind him, and Catra's eyes narrow.

"What am I supposed to do with this place?" he asks.

"It's been a month since the portal," she says coolly. "Get. Over. It. Get a cleaning squad in here and start from scratch. You've done it before, you can do it again."

"I need more resources to start building new weapons again."

"I know where to get more First Ones' tech," she says. "I'll get a team to retrieve it."

She leaves him there. He really isn't much help.

Nothing is much help to her now.

*

Catra goes to a roof. Not the same one she spent countless hours with Adora—it's forbidden to her now. She doesn't think she's allowed. There's not a single sign Adora had ever been there at all, in the portal world or otherwise. Catra has no proof, and she doesn't count memory, not when Shadow Weaver probably took some of hers as well, or altered them.

The sky is a deep, bruising purple. She missed the moonset. That might be for the best, she hasn't watched one since—

"Is that what you really want? To rule the world?" Adora asks her. Ruling the world seems to have a weight to it now, greater than the dream of two child soldiers who wanted to be in control of their future.

Catra wants to say "No, dummy, I just want to be with you," but there's a reason she can't be with Adora, even though she's right there, next to her. But she still feels far away. "Yeah," she answers instead. "Obviously. Isn't that what you want too?" They talked about it before, once. Catra doesn't know why their plans should be different now.

But Adora doesn't seem thrilled with that answer.

Catra isn't thrilled with it either.

Catra shivers. Does that conversation even count? She doesn't know. It was all fake—the world where Adora never left. If Shadow Weaver's kindness towards her wasn't real, does that mean Adora's kindness towards her was fake, too? The Adora she knows—knew—wouldn't laugh like that with her anymore, but it felt like it used to. As if Adora had never left. Adora used to laugh loudly, used to tease her fondly. She was always like that: playful, witty, bright. Those pale blue eyes always met hers as if Catra was something that could be adored.

"I won't leave you behind again," Adora had promised her, back in the portal. Catra knew it was a lie when she said it, but this time, Adora didn't just leave her, she left everyone behind.

Catra doesn't know if it makes it better or worse that it was Adora's choice. That's what the spies say, that someone had to stay behind to close the portal, and Adora volunteered. The hero, the savior. *Is that what you really wanted?* Catra wonders.

"How's it going, Wild Cat?" Scorpia asks, disrupting her thoughts.

"Don't ever ask me that again," Catra says.

"Sorry, it's just, you seem a little on edge," she says, which is perhaps the biggest understatement of the century. "And I know you've been dealing with—"

"I'm dealing with moving forward," Catra says. "We've been lying low for too long, but that's going to change. Tomorrow we're going back to the Crimson Waste, and we're bringing that First Ones' ship back with us. Hordak needs the tech. Help me get a team together, we're moving first thing in the morning."

"Well, as excited as I am to be… doing something again… isn't that a little last minute?"

"It's plenty of notice. Don't you want to go back to the waste? I thought you liked it there. Good for your exoskeleton or whatever."

Scorpia’s expression changes for a second, before returning neutral. Catra hasn’t forgotten what happened between them. Maybe they could have been happy, there in the waste, if Adora was never in the picture. It was a fleeting thought, and Catra—she couldn’t forget Adora then, she certainly couldn’t forget Adora now.

“You got it boss,” Scorpia says understandably, and thankfully has the sense to leave her alone.

Catra stares at the moons. She wonders if Adora can see them, wherever she is. She can’t stand the thought of Adora being surrounded by nothing but burning bright purple light.

She doesn't linger for much longer after that.

The good news is that Shadow Weaver isn’t here, lurking behind corners and spying on her. Well, Catra hopes that Shadow Weaver isn’t strong enough to spy on her anymore. She still gets a chill sometimes, as if one misstep will get her in trouble. She wonders if that will ever go away.

She walks back to her quarters slowly. She stills as she passes the door leading to the shortcut to the locker room.

It had disappeared when they were in the portal—Catra forgot about its existence. Tentatively, Catra presses her hand against the door. It’s cool to the touch, just like everything else here: cold and hard and devoid of anything good. How many times had she and Adora taken this shortcut, laughing at one of their jokes, or silent and sullen after a rough day of training? Catra swipes at the door, leaving her claw marks. It’s stupid that the door has returned, but Adora hasn’t. Catra can only wonder if Adora exists in that doorless void now, if she’s still alive at all.

Catra made her choice and she is living with it, like Adora had said.

She’s not living with it well.

Chapter End Notes

around a year ago tumblr user mazoomlec sent me an ask asking how catra would handle it if adora stayed in the portal instead of angella and i said that was too depressing for me to think about... and here i am LMAO thank you for encouraging me to write this <33

i wrote the bulk of this fic in april for a nano challenge so it's mostly just editing at this point... i am hoping to update more frequently. we shall see

the song title comes from pvris' "you and i"

you can find me on tumblr

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Your worst sin is that you have destroyed and betrayed yourself for nothing."

— Fyodor Dostoevsky

"[She] is my memory. And I am hers."

— Addy Hanlon (*Dare Me*)

They're eight when Octavia tells them tales of a desert so bloodstained, they call it the Crimson Waste. It's a place so cruel and unforgiving that even the sand will gladly swallow you whole. Catra doesn't buy it, the adults of the Horde love to frighten them, it keeps them in line. Most often, it's Octavia who scares them. Sometimes Shadow Weaver will make a rare appearance and use her shadow powers for theatrics, sipping on something sour smelling that Catra knows is no good. Even rarer, Commander Cobalt gets the job, probably assigned babysitting duty as punishment, unhappily warning them about the princesses' magic, speaking robotically as if they're still in the classroom.

The lights in the cafeteria are all shut off, the only source is the flashlight Octavia speaks into. As she prattles on about the horrors of the desert at night, Adora gasps.

"She's making it up," Catra whispers, trying to comfort her. But she's only eight and hasn't mastered whispering yet, that's how Shadow Weaver ended up finding her secret stash of ration bars the other day.

Octavia shines her flashlight directly into Catra's eyes and she winces. "I'm not making this up," Octavia says. "I'm not making any of this up."

Catra doesn't let the blinding light stop her. She sits up straight and crosses her arms; if she's in the spotlight, she might as well make the most of it. "You've never even been out of the Fright Zone, *Cadet*." Catra knows that's a sore spot, Octavia is older and expecting to be promoted to Force Captain soon, but "soon" has taken months. Catra overheard Octavia complaining to a fellow soldier about it. Like almost everyone Catra knows, Octavia hasn't had the chance to see any action yet.

"Mind your tone, Catra," Octavia warns.

"Or what?" Catra asks. "I'm starting to get *bored*. Do you want to lose your other eye?" Adora laughs next to her and it's all worth it. Octavia growls at her, a warning. Catra growls right back.

Deciding it's probably a bad idea to fight an eight-year-old and knowing it's quite plausible she could lose her second eye, Octavia sends them off to bed.

In the barracks, Adora stops Catra from climbing up to her bunk. "Stay with me," she pleads.

"Don't tell me you're still scared from earlier," Catra teases. "Octavia was making it all up. She just likes to feel important, but she's not. That's why she hasn't been promoted yet."

Adora giggles and pokes at her stomach. "Are you telling me you're not even a little bit scared? What if some of it was true?"

Catra sits on the lower end of Adora's bed and crosses her legs. Adora mirrors her. "What's there to be afraid of?" Catra asks. "It's just a bunch of sand."

"But there's so much of it," Adora says worriedly. "And there's no life out there."

“Hey, neither of us are ever going to go there, okay?”

“Okay,” Adora replies. She smiles. "If we ever do get out there, we'll make it better."

"Sure, Adora," Catra says, smiling back. They'll rule the world one day, and the Crimson Waste is part of it. Maybe Catra will learn how to make sand disappear.

Adora crawls under her covers. She's the first to fall asleep, but it’s not restful. It never is.

*

Catra glares at the First Ones’ ship, it's the shiniest thing in the Waste, reflective and jarring. It's a bitter reminder of everything she's lost.

Maybe staying here wouldn’t be the worst thing in the world, now that Catra knows it’s not named “Crimson,” after blood, it’s named after the fiery red sky during moonset. Catra's never seen it so vibrant, the Fright Zone's pollution made everything hazier. But out here, the moonset doesn't last long, the temperature drops, leaving the sky a deep somber blue. Catra’s used to the stagnant controlled air from Fright Zone vents, but she could adjust. She can adjust to anything.

Catra shivers and rubs her exposed left arm, wishing she still had that leather jacket she stole.

She glances over towards Scorpia, setting down a crate full of materials to be loaded. Her cheeks are tinted pink thanks to the cool air or exertion, but it's possible Catra has caught her staring again. She would probably stay here if Catra asked, it's not too late. They could settle down out here and Catra would never have to see a single princess ever again. If anyone uttered the name

She-Ra in her presence she could simply slit their throat and be done with it.

Catra would still send all the ship's materials back to Hordak, of course. A retirement gift, he'd have no chance of defeating the princesses otherwise. *"I'm done with the Horde,"* she'd send in a message, probably via Kyle, so he'd be the one to deal with Hordak's imminent outrage. *"I'm done with it all."*

She would even go so far as to keep the First Ones' ship, too, once it's fully scrapped for parts. It wouldn't be an uncovered relic, it would be her own Crystal Castle, nestled in the Valley of the Lost. Maybe she could even learn to control it, make it fly. But it probably needs magic to do that. It probably needs She-Ra.

She has to bury her next few thoughts, how Adora would still be here if Catra could have just listened to her. How the Rebellion would have won, but it wouldn't make a difference to Catra, not here, where the strong make the rules and Catra is the strongest. She extends her claws and retracts them again. Currently, her soldiers are getting all the necessary supplies and loading them onto their transports. Catra had been worried that the actual ship would be too big to bring to the Fright Zone completely intact, but she's been assured that it will make it.

Next to her, Scorpia does the closest motion she can to putting her claws on her hips and sighs loudly. "Doesn't this remind of you of the good old times?"

Catra half-laughs. "What good times?"

"You know," Scorpia says, eyebrows raised, hopeful. "The two of us out on a mission together, enjoying each other's company, having fun in here in the Waste?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, gesturing to the work that's being done around them. "That's exactly what we're doing. Having fun." Scorpia frowns, and Catra swears she can hear Scorpia thinking

about what cheerful things she could say that would better their predicament. "Don't you think it's weird?" Catra asks quickly.

“Uh, think what is weird?" Scorpia asks.

“Usually when we’re looking for tech, the princesses interfere. They're always after the same things we are. But we’ve been here in the Waste all day and they haven’t made an appearance. That doesn't bother you? It shouldn’t be this easy.”

“Well, now that they don’t have—” Scorpia falters as Catra shoots her a warning glance, telling her to drop it, and she clears her throat “—now that they’re short a princess, maybe they don’t care about the tech as much?”

Catra shakes her head adamantly. “No, her absence doesn't mean they don't care. Especially when it comes to First Ones’ tech, they would be especially protective over it now.”

And she must sound more bitter out loud, because Scorpia looks confused. “Wait, am I getting this right? Are you upset that things are actually going smoothly for us? I for one, personally think we deserve this win. You especially, I know it's been a hard few weeks—"

"Hard?" Catra asks. "You don't know the first thing about what I'm going through."

Night black and concerned, Scorpia's doting eyes are firm. "I can't know anything if you shut me out, Catra. And I know some things about loss, remember? My moms—"

Catra cannot have this conversation right now. She doesn't think she can have this conversation ever. Portals and deaths and casualties of war. Mercifully, a soldier approaches her. “Force Captain Catra, everything is loaded.”

“And the ship?” she asks.

“Secure and ready to be moved.”

“Good,” Catra says, relieved to have one less thing to worry about. “We’re going back to the Fright Zone immediately, send the order.”

“Yes, Force Captain Catra,” he says with a salute, and leaves.

Scorpia is just gaping at her. “What are you looking at? Get back to your transport.” They usually travel together, but Catra made sure to take a separate skiff by herself, solely to avoid talking to Scorpia about dangerous topics like feelings. She's a force captain, she doesn't have the time to spare.

“Right, sure thing, Catra,” Scorpia says sadly.

They make it back to the Fright Zone: the ship, the supplies, all of it. It shouldn’t have been that easy. Catra always knew the Rebellion relied on Adora, but she hadn’t realized they had relied on her this much.

As Catra curls up in her bed, one with a size she still thinks is too big for one person, she wishes that Octavia's stories were true, that the sand could have devoured her.

“Stay with me,” eight-year-old Adora begs, reaching for Catra's hand.

“Don’t tell me you’re scared,” Catra says.

“But I am scared,” Adora says. She’s older now. She has the Rebellion’s pin on her shirt, a single golden wing. “Aren’t you?” Their shared bunk bed is in the middle of the Crimson Waste, and the sky is full of stars.

“What are you afraid of, Adora?” Catra whispers.

“That it’s already too late,” Adora whispers back, squeezing her hand.

Catra's right arm is unmarked, the portal hasn't touched it yet. Poisoned words don't spill out, there's no swelling fury, and Adora doesn't stare at her despairingly; like when she left her to fall in

the Crystal Castle, when she nearly defeated her at the Battle of Bright Moon. None of it compares to what Catra sees now: Adora's hair is down, her lips parted, eyes gentle as they meet Catra's. Catra could apologize, but it wouldn't be enough, and it wouldn't count. "I already made my choice," Catra says instead. "It is too late," she says, removing her hand from Adora's, worried the portal's magic will come back, and infect Adora with it.

"I'm always gonna be your friend," Adora says, sounding like a child.

"No, you won't," Catra tells her sadly.

Adora only stares at her, wearing an expression Catra's never seen before. "You don't know everything," she says.

"I know this isn't real," Catra replies.

Adora tilts her head. "And I thought I was the one who ruined everything." She smiles softly, as if she's sharing an inside joke, not repeating words Catra wishes she could take back.

By the time scouts report that Catra has returned to the Crimson Waste and stole Mara's ship, it's too late. Even if the ship hasn't already been demolished by the Horde's greed for weapons, it's somewhere in the Fright Zone, out of reach. For a few desperate seconds, Glimmer considers calling an emergency mission to the Fright Zone to retrieve it. She looks around the war table, eyes her sullen friends. She can't remember the last time Sea Hawk made a joke, or the last snide remark Mermista made that wasn't just bitterness around Adora's absence. Swift Wind stands silently next to his new chair, he hasn't uttered a single word this whole meeting. The bags under Perfuma's eyes are as prominent as Bow's, and Bow—he looks as broken as she feels.

No. Every time they've gone to the Fright Zone, they've lost someone. Glimmer can't risk losing anyone else. Cautiously, she glances towards her mom. All she wants is to collapse into her arms, listen to her soothing voice as she promises her it will be okay, that the Rebellion is strong enough to win this war, that Adora will come back home.

But the news is too pressing, and Glimmer's still torn on whether or not she needs the apology, or if she should be the one to apologize.

“There’s only one reason the Horde would be interested in the ship,” Bow says eventually, breaking the silence. “They’re going to have Entrapta make more weapons.”

“We’re going to have to be on the defensive,” Glimmer says. “Catra is going to be relentless once the bots are ready to go.”

“We should strike before the Horde has a chance,” Mermista says. “Without their weapons—"

"Entrapta works fast," Glimmer counters. "The Horde has had Mara's ship for days now, new weapons have been made if they haven't already been sent out yet." She pauses, allowing Angella the chance to say something, but she doesn't. "And I’m not sending a team back to the Fright Zone again, it’s too risky. We’re going to have to spread our defenses across the Whispering Woods. When the Horde comes, we’ll be prepared.”

“Uh, how are we supposed to spread more resources?” Perfuma asks, raising her hand. “Most of Plumeria is left uncovered because we’re already protecting Thaymor and now Elberon is calling for help. We don’t have any more people we can send out without weakening our defenses.”

“We’ll figure something out,” Glimmer insists. "We need to prioritize the Whispering Woods, that's where the Horde will attack. The second new bots are discovered, we need to be there to take them down."

*

They're all in pairs as they search the woods, save for Frosta, who goes with Spinnerella and Netossa. In the heart of the woods, Bow walks in front of Glimmer, not beside her. She knows he's not thrilled with the plan, and especially wasn't thrilled when she suggested she go by herself so she can save her teleportation powers. But the woods are getting dark now, and quieter; she's relieved she's not alone, even if she and Bow aren't speaking.

She doesn't know how to break the silence with him anyway, they haven't spoken much since he spent the night last week. So she lets him lead, steady and silent, watching as the occasional heart-shaped mark etches itself on a softer patch of grass.

Bow stops walking once they arrive at a familiar looking clearing in the woods, where a suspicious tangle of brambles looks like its missing something. Adora's sword stays in Glimmer's room, mounted on the wall when she's not bringing it to the Crystal Castle. Glimmer wonders what would happen if she brought it back to the woods, if a new She-Ra would be summoned in Adora's stead.

Glimmer catches up to Bow, notices the pensive look in his eye. "Hey," she says, her hand brushing against his, letting him know that she's *here*. “Are you okay?”

Bow blinks as if he’s waking up from a dream. “Yeah,” he says wistfully. “This just reminds me of where we first met Adora. Do you think—" he stops himself. There are so many things he could be meaning to ask, *Do you think we’ll ever see her again, do you think she’s okay, do you think she’s here right now, somewhere, barely beyond us, in a realm similar to this one?* “Do you think it should have been us instead?” Bow asks. “We heard what

Entrapta said, about someone staying behind. And we let Adora —"

“No,” Glimmer says quickly. “It shouldn’t have been any of us. The portal shouldn’t have been made in the first place. The next time I see Catra—” the sound of something beeping cuts her off. The source of the noise is big. Without taking the time to look for it, Glimmer grabs Bow and moves them twenty feet to the left.

Glimmer has not missed the awful sound of lasers slicing through trees.

"Oh," Bow says quietly, "this one is different."

Glimmer turns around puts her hand over her mouth to muffle her gasp. The bot’s size is alarming; she and Bow have taken out many bots together, but this one doesn't move as sporadically, its movements and aim are far more precise. It finds them immediately, targeting them and drilling itself into the ground, revving itself up for something even worse. When its laser goes off the second time, she barely moves them fast enough.

But the noise the bot generates messes with her. She and Bow land far enough away, shaken up and near-paralyzed.

And Glimmer doesn't know how it happens, one second, Bow is right at her side shaking her shoulder and speaking to her, and the next, he's standing in front of the bot releasing an arrow. The blast goes off two seconds before Glimmer's able to teleport them both out of there.

“What happened?” he groans, clutching his stomach.

“The bot,” Glimmer says, wincing as the tinnitus doesn’t stop. Everything keeps ringing. "Are you okay?" she asks.

"I can't catch all you're saying," Bow says.

Glimmer nods, and teleports them back to Bright Moon. As soon as Bow is receiving some medical attention, Glimmer goes back to

teleport all the other princesses out of the woods safely. It takes her three trips and two recharges. She doesn't recharge after she gets Swift Wind and Sea Hawk back to the war room. Exhausted and sore, she feels stifled by the energy she's used, things shouldn't have gone this wrong today.

Spinnerella and Netossa have figured out a way to dismantle the same bigger bot that Glimmer and Bow faced, while everyone else tackled with smaller bots that were able to regenerate.

"So we were fighting two different types of bots today," Mermista says, eyes wide. "That's intense."

“Yeah,” Glimmer agrees. “And I think Catra is just getting started. She’s been waiting weeks for the chance to attack us like this.”

"And the bots were stationed everywhere," Netossa points out. "They weren't just coming from the Fright Zone. We need to find the source otherwise we won't be able to contain them."

"You're right," Glimmer says. "Their base could be anywhere in the Whispering Woods, but we won't let them stay there. Tomorrow we're going to go out in teams and seek them out." She's met with only nods and uncharacteristic silence from her mother. It's late. "Go get some rest, everyone," she says gently.

*

Bow is snoring. Contrary to his belief, he does snore, and he snores loudly. But Glimmer's relieved to hear it now, it’s comforting. He looks relaxed, but Glimmer doesn’t want to leave his side quite yet.

There’s a quiet knock on the door, and Glimmer knows it’s Angella, she always taps the same rhythm when she’s nervous. Glimmer

opens the door a crack, just barely enough to peer through.

"How's Bow doing?" Angella asks tentatively, voice low, so as not to disturb him.

"He's going to be fine," Glimmer answers, trying not to let her voice waver, ashamed of the truth, and what it might mean. Glimmer allows herself to look up into Angella's eyes: watery, desperate, and afraid. Glimmer suspects her own eyes look the same. "He took the blast worse than me, but he's going to be fine."

"What really happened out there, Glimmer?" Glimmer doesn't answer her. "Glimmer, you have every right to be upset with me, and I've tried to give you the space you've needed, but you can't keep shutting me out."

Glimmer swallows. *I froze out there,* she wants to confess, *and if I didn't get together and teleport fast enough, I don't know what would have happened.* On the verge of tears, she says, "I know but I still need more time."

"I understand," Angella says softly. "If you want to talk, you know where to find me."

Glimmer lets her walk away and carefully closes the door. Bow is thankfully still asleep. She kisses his temple. "I won't let it happen again," she whispers. "I won't let it happen to anyone else."

Conquering tastes like ash.

The excursion to Elberon was alarmingly easy. The rustic town was full of music and festivities before the bots came. For as much as the princesses claim to care about their people, they've

left them defenseless. Or rather, they are left without She-Ra to protect them.

Catra knows what that’s like.

The aftermath is full of smoke, it stings Catra’s nose and makes her eyes water. It reminds her of Thaymor—the yelling, the running, the burning. Catra had thought Adora was held prisoner there, but Adora was right, they were only innocent civilians, just like Elberon. There wasn't a challenge, not a single fight. There was only destruction. Catra’s teams didn't even have to leave their transports, the bots did all the work.

Catra never thought she would miss the dashing heroics, the gleaming blue taunts, the softest *whoosh* of a cape fluttering. Even now, met with flames, Catra’s peripheral vision seeks that flowing golden hair.

“I got you pretty good, didn’t I,” Adora would say, if she were alive and revealed herself, the same way Adora would talk to her after a practical joke. *“Catra, you’ll never believe who I saw making out in a supply closet. Catra, I think I hear a mouse under the bed. Catra, turns out I’m actually a princess and I have to leave you and everything we’ve worked for behind.”*

Yeah, good one, Adora.

“Elberon is ours, Force Captain," a soldier tells her, as if the Horde actually needs more territory to occupy.

“Good," she replies, and waves her hand up. The flags are raised, threatening and red. It doesn’t constitute as a victory, in Catra’s opinion. A victory involves a fight, and there wasn’t one.

When Catra delivers the report to Hordak in person, he merely says, "I am relieved to hear you didn't fail me this time," which is the closest thing she'll get to praise. She prefers it this way, genuine praise from Hordak would feel like she did something wrong.

His face remains expressionless, and Catra certainly wouldn't label Hordak as “happy,” but his temperament has improved with the amount of First Ones’ technology he has to work with. It gives him a drive. It means he’s too busy focusing on the materials in his lab to notice that technically, Catra is slacking. She’s not giving it her all. But she’ll allow him to think she is.

“The weapon I’m working on now will be even better,” he tells her. Something big.

Catra knows it’s wishful thinking to think it would be enough to take out the princesses immediately, but she would give anything for the war to be over already. Her resolve to win diminishes a little bit more each day, but at least once they win, Catra won't have to deal with incompetent commanding officers and malfunctioning bots and annoying princesses.

“I’ll be testing out the new pulse bot’s prototype tomorrow,” Catra announces with a forced smile.

“Good,” Hordak says. She leaves him and Imp to the irritating noise of drilling.

She’ll be staying here in the Fright Zone tonight, it’s too late to venture back into the woods, even though she prefers staying there. The cave with their bots is quieter than the Fright Zone. It’s full of less memories, too.

Her sleeved arm aches and as she rubs it, she bumps into Lonnie. "Can't you watch where you're going?" Catra snaps.

"Sorry!" Lonnie says, casually as if they were both only cadets. "I didn't know you were back."

Catra didn't tell anyone she'd be here tonight, not even Scorpia. She just wanted to report to Hordak and go to sleep. Battle or not, she's fatigued from being in Elberon all day.

"Scorpia was wondering where you were, she was worried that you'd be mad about the roof," Lonnie says cautiously.

Catra crosses her arms. "Why would I be mad about the roof?"

Lonnie parts her mouth openly slightly, astonished. "You haven't been up there?"

"Been up where, Cadet?"

“The *roof*,” Lonnie emphasizes, raising her hands in a gesture that says, *obviously*. She then rubs the back of her neck. "We... Kyle, Rogelio, and I... we always knew it was your spot." Catra only raises an eyebrow in response. "Both of yours."

“I don’t know what you’re talking about—”

“We thought it would be the best place to remember her,” Lonnie says gently, with the sense to know better than to say Adora's name out loud. “I know she wasn’t one of us anymore but, she still tried to help me, back in the portal." Of course she did, Adora the hero, trying to protect everyone. Look at the good it did her. "Catra, she still deserves to be remembered. We haven't had a service yet, but if you wanted, we could—”

"I have nothing to say to for it."

"Catra," Lonnie says sadly, not trying to conceal her disappointment. "Are you sure?"

"I'm sure," Catra says. *I don't deserve to be there*, she means to say, but she doesn't. She leaves Lonnie with that and makes a mental promise not to visit the roof, she doesn't want to see whatever shrine they could put together made out of materials from the Fright Zone. Adora hated the Fright Zone, she probably wouldn't want to see it either.

Instead of going to bed, Catra ventures to the First Ones' ship. Its interior is hollow, every step Catra takes echoes. It's been left untouched since Catra's squad had delivered it. Hordak had called it ancient, practically useless.

"So what if it's ancient?" Catra had asked. *"It's a spaceship, if the First Ones could use it, so could we."*

"We are in an empty shadow dimension," Hordak replied, as if Catra is aware of all the problems empty shadow dimensions have. *"That ship won't help us get anywhere. It doesn't even have a weapon, as far as I can tell. I have no immediate use for it yet, so keep it if you'd like."*

Catra knows the ship is still useful for something, she can sense it. Catra runs her hand over the very outdated control panel, she probably should have paid more attention to Entrapta's ramblings of how First Ones' tech functioned. Catra has a basic knowledge on how to repair faulty skiffs and how to rewire the doors in the Horde's security system, but the technology the First Ones left behind is its own beast.

The devastating thing is, Catra knows Entrapta would have loved it, if she were here, she wouldn't have gotten off the ship once. Hordak called it ancient, Entrapta would have called it too good to be true. She would have known how to make it work.

Catra can almost imagine her chattering away about the ship's command center or the sheer size of it, curious about how something this large could defy gravity. But there isn't the welcome sound of Entrapta's excitement, there's only her own pounding heartbeat. Catra slams her fist onto the surface closest to her. That's when something disturbing happens, a woman's voice says *"She-Ra,"* and Catra gives a pathetic shriek.

Turning around, Catra is face to face with the same hologram that was speaking to Adora right before Catra had captured her. (Catra shouldn't have expected, shouldn't have hoped that it would be anyone else.)

"I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone," the hologram says.

Catra inhales slowly, giving the hologram a chance to elaborate, but she doesn't. Catra narrows her eyes, before Catra had interrupted her in the Waste, the hologram spoke a lot more, warning Adora about the portal. She supposes it doesn't matter, Catra didn't heed the warning and now she's stuck with a different She-Ra, one who only speaks in a loop, rendering her useless.

Still, there's something eerie about her. *Mara*, she calls herself. *She-Ra of Etheria.* Catra didn't know there was more than one She-Ra, she thought it was some dumb princess thing that had snatched Adora away. Catra wonders if there were other She-Ras, or if more still exist, somewhere beyond the shadow dimension Etheria hides in. Maybe Adora isn't alone, maybe she was never supposed to be alone. *"If you never came through the portal in the first place,"* she had told Adora, she would have been better off.

But Catra can't distract herself over worrying about these other girls who may or may not exist. Catra walks to the other side of the hologram and stares at her, forces herself to really look at her. She's blue like the hologram Catra remembers from the Crystal Castle, slightly transparent, and lovely. And sad, she carries her grief in her eyes, like Adora. She's not wearing a tiara or a cape, meaning this really is *Mara*, not the She-Ra version of her.

Catra sighs, leans back on the command panel, and crosses her arms. "I hate to break it to you, but I don't exactly have a great track record with She-Ras," she says. "She's kind of my sworn enemy. Was. Does that mean you are, too?"

"I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone," Mara's hologram repeats.

"Of course you're gone," Catra says. "Isn't that all She-Ra is good for? To tell us what we shouldn't do and then *leave*?"

The hologram simply echoes. Catra looks down, unable to make eye contact with a hologram who can't even look at her back. "The leaving was my fault, the second time." Mara repeats herself,

and Catra can’t stand it anymore, she starts hitting every possible control until she manages to shut her off completely. The silence is deafening.

“What were you so afraid of?” Catra asks the nothingness. Catra always knew She-Ra was no good. The fear from Mara's hologram is enough proof of that, but unlike Adora, who blindly listened to the past, Mara knew something was wrong. Without full access to Mara's message, Catra will never know what.

When a week passes and they lose Elberon, Glimmer gives in, she seeks out Shadow Weaver willingly. It's easier than she'd like, she knows where the guards are stationed, and she knows Castaspella's anti-teleport spell shrouding Shadow Weaver's room can be broken, so she breaks it.

"I had wondered when you would pay me a visit," Shadow Weaver says.

"Catra has a secret base in the Whispering Woods," Glimmer says. "I need you to help me find it."

Shadow Weaver hums, almost disappointed. "Horde soldiers are trained to fear the woods. But Catra has never been afraid of the things she should have been. There is no established Horde base in the woods, Catra created her own."

“Tell me what I can do to find her,” Glimmer demands. “If I can stop Catra, I can delay the bots. She’s in charge of them.”

“If you would allow me to use magic—”

“That’s out of the question,” Glimmer says.

“I can’t help you if you don't allow me to access my own magic,” Shadow Weaver says simply. “But I wouldn't worry so much about this hidden base. Catra is using the bots to distract the Rebellion from something bigger, if she's still as strategic as I raised her to be. I urge you to find out what she's trying to keep concealed instead."

“The newer bots are dangerous, the Rebellion can't allow them to wreak havoc just because Catra is sending them out as a *distraction*. If we can get rid of the bots, we'll delay Catra that much longer."

“I could help you if you allow me, princess,” Shadow Weaver says. “I taught both Catra and Adora everything they—”

“Don’t talk to me about Adora,” Glimmer snaps. Being in Shadow Weaver's presence alone leaves her with an icy guilt. Adora was afraid of her, Adora didn't trust her. But with Catra's insistence to stay on the offensive, Glimmer doesn't know what other choice she has.

“You're wasting your time with the bots, which is exactly what Catra wants. Meanwhile, there's only so much you can do while your access to the Moonstone is limited."

Glimmer blinks. “What do you mean limited?”

“Surely you know that much, princess.” Shadow Weaver’s gaze feels almost pitying, as if Glimmer is the prisoner, not the other way around. “The other princesses are stronger because they have their full connection to their runestones. You, however, share yours with your mother, leaving you with half of your potential power.”

Adora had said Shadow Weaver was masterful with her mind games, but what she’s saying is starting to cusp around treason. “You’re lying,” Glimmer says. “My mother wouldn’t deprive me, she wouldn't *limit* me. She's immortal, she doesn't need to keep magic from me."

“I'm surprised you've gone this far without noticing how much you lack, princess. But I suppose it's no fault of your own, you've only been working with what you've been given."

“I don’t want to hear any more of this. I’m capable of taking care of Catra by myself, no matter what it is that you’re implying.” But doubt seeps in. Shadow Weaver's expressions are never easy to read, but something tells Glimmer that Shadow Weaver is pleased by her distress. “Just help me find Catra,” Glimmer says, resenting her obvious urgency. “I'll do whatever it takes.”

Against every instinct, Glimmer fetches everything Shadow Weaver bids: the specific flowers she calls for, a bowl of water, Shadow Weaver provides the rest. How she had so much supply of magic in this prison cell is beyond Glimmer, but she doesn't have time to think about it, she's too disturbed by the effectiveness of the location spell. No wonder Adora had been so scared her first trip to Mystacor. Briefly, Glimmer allows herself to wonder if it's possible to search for Adora through this spell, but the images in the water before her blur.

“Concentrate,” Shadow Weaver says sternly. “You cannot search outside of the boundaries of this realm, princess.”

Glimmer nods, exhaling slowly. She finds Catra hidden in an empty clearing the Whispering Woods. It looks as if she's alone, Glimmer can't find anyone else in the area. There isn't a bot in sight. "Is this a set up?" Glimmer asks. "Why is she alone?"

"It means the bots are somewhere else," Shadow Weaver says. "You can either seek them out, or approach Catra." It's not really a choice. Everyone else is already searching the woods for bots, and Glimmer doesn't want to lose the opportunity to fight Catra one on one. “Do you remember the spell I taught you?” Shadow Weaver asks. “It will help save your Moonstone powers.”

“I remember it,” Glimmer says stiffly. It doesn't feel as natural to use a spell to travel somewhere else, but it extends her own teleportation powers that much longer.

“Then you have better get going. Catra won’t be expecting you, you’d better use that to your advantage.”

Glimmer nods firmly. *I’m sorry,* she thinks, with Bow and her mother in mind. But Angella would never approve of what Glimmer's about to do, and Bow is still recovering from the other day.

*

The teleportation spell works unsettlingly easy.

Upon Glimmer's arrival, Catra startles, nearly dropping her communicator, but composes herself quickly. “I was starting to wonder if you had just given up, considering how easy it was to take over Elberon.”

Glimmer grips her staff tightly, summoning magic with her other hand. “We are never giving up,” she says.

“Who’s ‘we?’ Looks like you’re here by yourself. I heard Arrow Boy took a bad hit the other day, sorry about that,” Catra says, not sounding sorry at all.

“Don’t talk to me about Bow,” Glimmer says, jaw tight.

Catra shrugs. “I have to admit I’m flattered you took the time to find me on your own, Sparkles,” she drawls. “I’ve never been a particularly big fan of crowds." Glimmer doesn't reply, struck by Catra's bored expression. At least, boredom is how it first appears, but Glimmer recognizes the emptiness in Catra's once wild eyes. "You're too late, anyway, my forces are already in Thaymor right now."

"Why did you do it?" Glimmer asks.

Catra blinks, seemingly alarmed by the question. "Because it's a war, Sparkles, and the Horde's control of Thaymor is long overdue."

Glimmer shakes her head. "Why did you open the portal? You're the reason Adora is—"

"Didn't I tell you already, Sparkles?"

"Tell me what?" Glimmer asks, lowering her guard.

"That Adora would leave you, too. But you didn't believe me. You thought your friendship was enough, but it wasn't. Leaving is what Adora does, even in the portal she—" Catra stops to rub the arm she keeps covered with her black sleeve, black like the rest of her clothing. Black isn't the customary color to wear when one mourns in Bright Moon, but briefly, Glimmer wonders if it is in the Fright Zone. If grief exists in the Fright Zone. "Even in the portal she chose to leave," Catra says.

"You saw Adora in the portal?" Glimmer asks, startled. She tries to remember what Adora had told her, that the Fright Zone was gone, but Glimmer didn't even remember that the Fright Zone existed at the time. She didn't remember who Catra was. "What happened in the portal, Catra?"

"Does it matter?" Catra asks. Her brow narrows, and that's all the warning Glimmer gets before Catra strikes in full swing.

"It does matter," Glimmer insists, frustrated that her magic isn't enough. Catra dodges each attack seamlessly, like she was born to do this. She finally lands a hit on Catra, but she bounces back quickly. "Adora told me the Fright Zone was gone but you were there, weren't you, before it disappeared? You saw her there!"

"What difference does it make whether or not I saw her?" Catra asks, resuming her attack. Glimmer narrowly misses Catra's swipe on her left arm. "Adora is gone," Catra reminds her. "Which means *She-Ra* is gone and there's no hope for the Rebellion without her. You and I both know that."

“You’re wrong,” Glimmer says. “It’s not over for the Rebellion, and once we get Adora back, you’ll realize that.”

“What?” Catra croaks, getting knocked to the ground in her distraction.

“We’re going to get Adora out of that portal,” Glimmer says. Catra’s eyes widen at that. If Glimmer didn’t know any better, she’d think there was hope. “And when we do, we're going to finish what we started, together. The Horde won't stand a chance."

Catra laughs. "You really think you can open another portal to get Adora back? How are you going to do that without Entrapta?”

"We don't need Entrapta," Glimmer says. "Not when we have the sword and access to First Ones' magic."

Catra stands up and shrugs. “I’ll believe it when I see it, Sparkles,” she says, yanking out her communicator. “In the meantime,” she presses a button and there’s a large, stomping sound. “I didn’t send *all* of my bots to Thaymor.”

“Too afraid to keep fighting me on your own?” Glimmer asks, trying to sound braver than feels, bracing herself to face the same bot she fought with Bow.

“Please, princess,” Catra says. “As if I could be afraid of a little bit of glitter.”

As Catra runs, Glimmer bitterly deals with the fact that she wasn't able to take on Catra by herself, and alarmingly, she wonders if Shadow Weaver was right about her runestone connection after all.

When the bot shows up, Glimmer uses the rest of her energy to teleport it into the sky, letting it self-implode up there. Catra won today, and when she returns to Bright Moon, she doesn’t doubt that she’ll receive word on how they lost Thaymor, too.

"This stone matches your eyes," Catra tells Adora, partially as a joke.

"You think so?" Adora asks, the brightest thing in the creek bed, the brightest thing in the Fright Zone. Maybe all of Etheria.

"Yeah," Catra says, and Adora laughs.

"We need to find some that match yours," Adora insists, tucking the pebble in her pocket and standing up.

Catra laughs. "I think you're going to have a hard time with that."

"Aquamarine stones exist," Adora says. Catra gestures to the sad little creek running past them, they've come out here for years, and have never found a single gemstone. "Don't give me that, we could find some here if we tried." Adora puts her hand underneath her chin. "We would need to find amber though, for your other eye, and that will be harder. We'd probably have to go to the Whispering Woods for that."

Catra laughs. "You have given this way too much thought."

Adora flushes slightly, before straightening her posture, both arms down by her side. Shadow Weaver has found them.

"You're senior cadets," she says. "You know better than to walk around in this filth."

There are pebbles on the roof, smooth round ones the same color as Adora's eyes. Catra supposes they aren't standard for shrines of the dead, but they fit. There are dried and withering remains of flowers as well, Catra doesn't even know where they found them —she tries to picture Lonnie wondering the Whispering Woods, looking for ones that were pretty, flowers that reminded her of

Adora. She can't picture Kyle being the one to gather flowers, but it's not impossible. There's a neatly folded Horde-issued jacket, the same one Adora used to wear. Balanced on the center of it is a photograph of Adora, days before she was promoted to Force Captain. Catra remembers it all too well. She's the one who took the photograph, after all. She wonders where they uncovered it, or if they found it in her long since abandoned locker. Catra never touched it once Adora left, she didn't want to be reminded of everything good that they shared.

She shuts her eyes, remembers how proud Adora was for discovering this rooftop before Catra.

"I wanted to impress you," Adora had admitted, eager and breathless. *"I've been checking the area for weeks, and no one ever comes up here."*

"Okay, so we'll come up here and do what, exactly?"

"Watch the moonset. Catra, it has the best view," Adora told her.

"Okay then, as long as it has the best *view,"* Catra replied, savoring the way Adora smiled.

And Catra feels lost. She has nothing to give, nothing that could signify the weight that she feels, nothing that could give Adora justice, nothing to add to the only Horde memorial she's ever seen. But there is still something she can do, for Adora. It's a risk, but it was always a risk for her, wasn't it? Every rooftop visit, every lasting glance, every time Catra didn't make it back to her own bed.

"You promise?" Catra had asked Adora once, when she was younger. Technically, Catra didn't promise anything herself.

"I promise," Catra whispers to the shrine now. If Adora is still out there, Catra's not going to let the princesses be the ones to save her from whatever oblivion Catra had damned her to. *I'm going to look out for you*, she thinks. *If it's not too late.*

*

Hordak doesn't leave his lab. Catra doesn't know if he needs to eat or sleep anymore, she suspects that the First Ones' tech Entrapta gave him, the piece that's not securely wielded to his chest, might give him everything he needs to sustain himself.

So the lab is where she finds him.

"We need to open another portal," Catra tells Hordak, as assertive as possible. She leaves out that it's a race against time, that the princesses themselves aren't even trying to make another, that as long as they have the sword, they have the key.

"What?" Hordak hisses, sounding like steam.

"To take out the princesses for good, we need to open another portal," she says, louder, agitated.

"After everything that happened, you deem it wise to open another one?"

"Yes," Catra says firmly. "We took out She-Ra, and allegedly sent out a signal to Horde Prime. But it's been *weeks*, Hordak. Shouldn't he have found us by now? You're always going off about how advanced 'True Horde' technology is. Prime either can't find us, or he's choosing not to come for you. You have been MIA for years," she reminds him. "Maybe he doesn't think conquering Etheria is worth it."

"No," Hordak says. "He will find Etheria important."

"So let's make sure he can find us," Catra says.

His glaring red eyes remain unchanged. "Even with what's left from Entrapta's notes, I'm not sure I can reconstruct another

portal on my own.”

“You don’t have to,” Catra says. “I’m going to bring Entrapta back to the Fright Zone.”

Hordak stills. Even Imp almost stops flying midair. “You would dare suggest we bring a traitor back among our midst?”

“I’m saying,” Catra says through gritted teeth, “that we need to do whatever it takes to win this war.” Hordak considers this, but he doesn’t seem pleased. “We’ll get her out of Bright Moon, as our prisoner. If she wants to live, she’ll have no choice but to help us build another portal. When we’re finished, we’ll send her off to Beast Island, or whatever you think the best place is for a traitor.” Hordak stays silent. “Unless you think you can build a better portal on your own?” she asks, trying not to sound too taunting. The ruler of the Horde can’t even build himself a portal. It’s shameful, really.

“How are you planning on doing this?” Hordak asks.

“Just give me a week to infiltrate Bright Moon,” Catra says. It’s not that difficult to lie, after she gets Entrapta off of Beast Island, going to Bright Moon to steal the sword should be manageable. “I’ll come back with Entrapta and the sword. We won’t be able to make another portal without both.”

Hordak eyes her carefully. “You really think this is the best course of action?”

“Yes,” Catra says.

“You have a week, Force Captain. But if something goes wrong, don’t expect me to use any resources to assist you.”

“Trust me,” Catra says, keeping her voice level. “I’ve got it covered.”

Chapter End Notes

uhh. i'm hoping to post a modern au soon that will be relatively more light hearted than this.

shadow weaver telling glimmer her mom is holding her back from her true potential is something i've been wanting to explore forever so, here we are!!

comments and kudos are deeply appreciated

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I'm fighting myself. I know I am. One minute I want to remember. The next minute I want to live in the land of forgetting. One minute I want to feel. The next minute I never want to feel ever again."

— Benjamin Alire Sáenz

Catra finds it dizzying, delicious. It's possible her plan might fail, that she might not make it to Beast Island. Or that even if she does, she might not make it back. Maybe it's the overbearing smell of gasoline getting to her; the storage unit with the transports designated for Beast Island isn't as well managed as the others. The good news is, no one will bother her in here as she gets ready, or question why she's acquiring more fuel tanks than permitted. The skiffs for Beast Island are larger than the skiffs she's used to driving, but that's because they're designed for a one-way trip. She'll be able to manage it. Turns out she's a pretty great skiff driver when she's not fighting over control with Adora.

The skiffs carry enough fuel in their tanks to make the six-hour trek across the sea, assuming the numbers are correct, that is. Part of Catra is afraid the skiff will stop working in the middle of open water. The whole process is a wasteful one. It'd be more efficient to execute Horde traitors and prisoners, but no, Hordak has a whole supply of skiffs to waste for his theatrics. If only he valued efficiency. If he did, the war wouldn't have gone on as long as it has.

She groans as she loads up two extra fuel tanks onto the skiff, she's not going to risk running low on fuel if she can help it. Although the skiffs are programmed to only go to Beast Island,

Entrapta shouldn’t have a hard time rewiring the system to make it back here.

Her ears flatten, she’s making the assumption that Entrapta will want to come back, assuming Entrapta still alive. If she’s not, well, Catra's not sure she can handle being the reason two people she cares about are gone.

"I've kept you around this long because Adora was fond of you, but if you ever do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself," Shadow Weaver told her, right in front of Adora. Catra should have hated Adora for it, being the only reason she was allowed an existence, as bleak as it was. Catra had wondered once if she was Adora's best friend because she had no other choice, but the thought vanished as soon as it appeared. It was always *Adora* with her understanding eyes, her up-to-no-good grin, her relaxed side back on their rooftop days.

"Don't worry," Catra tells the skiff's shadow, as if it will pass along the message. "If it comes down to it, if I’m really the reason she no longer has a future, I'll do the job myself." Her right arm goes ice cold, as it often does when she thinks about Adora.

She ignores the growing doubt in her ventricles by double checking her bag: water, ration bars, stun batons, and batteries. (Adora would have triple checked it, with a list, but she is not Adora.)

Catra spent last night researching every file the Horde has on Beast Island, trying to figure out what she'd need for this journey. The records weren't much help, no one from the Horde has ever actually been to Beast Island. The details were all written by Shadow Weaver, who could only account for Mystacor's limited history on the place. Shadow Weaver’s spidery writing said: *Beast Island is an old and corrupt place; under no circumstances should we try to liberate it under the Horde’s name*. Catra’s not sure how a place can be corrupt, but if Shadow Weaver herself has warned against it, it must be bad. She thinks she'd prefer taking on the chibbits, scruffers, and razorfins Shadow Weaver made up to

frighten them as children. Razor-sharp teeth sound like a much better deal.

Catra's left ear twitches as footsteps echo in the unit, growing louder than the Fright Zone's perpetual hum. She braces herself. The almost abandoned storage unit could be a good place to fraternize. Or Hordak knew she was lying, and he’s here to ensure she’s taking a one-way trip. Scratch that, Hordak is too lazy to actually seek her out himself, and any soldiers he'd send after her she can handle.

Catra exhales once she realizes she recognizes those over-eager, optimistic steps. Scorpia smiles at her, sheepish and unsure. In response, Catra clenches her fist, letting her nails dig into her palms. “What do you think you’re doing here?”

“What?” Scorpia asks, unfazed by Catra’s attitude. Her patience rivals Adora's, or at least, Adora's patience in the past. “A gal can’t just come out here and uh—" she looks around the room, eyes lighting up as she spots a skiff "—inspect skiffs to make sure they’re functioning properly?”

“No one actually comes out to inspect the skiffs,” Catra points out. “You would know that better than anyone. Is that really the best excuse you've got?"

"Probably?" Scorpia asks, wincing as she does so. "You know, for all the things I’m good at, lying isn’t exactly one of them.”

“I’m aware,” Catra deadpans, crossing her arms and trying to stay composed. Scorpia shouldn't have been able to find her—if she knew Catra's whereabouts, it's doubtful she' the only one. “Care to explain how you found me? What I'm doing is confidential, even Hordak doesn't know." Scorpia looks nervous, which makes Catra start to sweat. “Scorpia, if Hordak knows what I’m about to do I need you to tell me right now.”

Scorpia waves her claws up defensively. “Oh, no, it’s not that. I mean, it's not impossible that he knows, I wouldn't know for sure

but—”

"Will you spit it out already?" Catra snaps.

"I've been worried about you, okay?" Scorpia says, which isn't exactly new, and it isn't helpful. "You've been... distant, since the portal. And even after we took over Elberon and Thaymor you haven't been happy."

"We're in the middle of a war, Scorpia, of course I'm not happy. How did you know I would bet here?"

“Imp records everything,” Scorpia says, as if Catra isn’t aware of that, the little good for nothing demon child. “But did you know that if you feed him a ration bar, he’ll play recordings for you? Apparently, he only likes the brown kind, took me weeks to figure that one out.” Catra glares at her and Scorpia sighs, defeated. “I heard you tell Hordak that you’re going to get Entrapta so she can build a second portal for the Horde. He thinks you’re getting her from Bright Moon, but we both know that’s not true.” Scorpia pauses, giving Catra the chance to say something, but she doesn't. Tentative, Scorpia adds, “Besides, I knew deep down that you always cared, you wouldn’t leave Entrapta there forever. You're a better person than that."

Catra *would* leave Entrapta there, she already has. That’s what scares her, more than anything. She could lie, she could say Entrapta got what traitors deserve, but Catra is tired of lying, and tired of fighting.

“The Horde needs Entrapta's help more than ever,” Catra says. “That’s all this is. Do you understand?”

Scorpia looks back at her skeptically. “I think if you didn’t care, you wouldn’t be doing this yourself. You’d send Kyle—”

“Kyle is useless and doesn’t know a single thing about discretion. It has to be me to bring her back.” There’s a weight to these words, but Catra swallows it down. "And I need you to promise me that you won't come after me, no matter what happens."

"About that," Scorpia says, and Catra mentally begs that she won't say it, but she's Scorpia, so she says it. Of course she does. "I'm coming with you, Wild Cat."

"No," Catra warns. "You're not." She's not even sure *she'll* make it to Beast Island and back in one piece. Scorpia will be safe if she stays in the Fright Zone.

Scorpia says, "If you don't let me come with you, I'm just going to follow you on my own skiff," and throws her bag on the ground before her. "I'm already all packed."

Catra's mouth is dry. She doesn't deserve Scorpia's help, and Scorpia doesn't deserve to get dragged down with her if this fails. "It's going to be dangerous."

"Come on, Catra. Surely there's nothing you and I can't handle. I mean, you did take over the Crimson Waste in a single day, remember?"

"That's because everyone in the Waste is an idiot," Catra says. "Beast Island isn't going to be as easy, we need to be prepared for anything. Did you grow up on the same stories about all the monsters with razor-sharp teeth?"

"Yep," Scorpia replies uneasily. "Shadow Weaver loved telling us about those. I wonder if they're real."

"They're not," Catra says. "Whatever is actually on Beast Island is going to be much worse."

"Great," Scorpia says with feigned enthusiasm. "You and me and the open water for six hours, and an island with unforeseen dangers? What could possibly go wrong?"

"Don't jinx it," says Catra.

The night after Shadow Weaver tells Adora she is not of Etheria, Adora spends the night in Glimmer’s room, quiet and guarded. Glimmer hasn't seen her like this since Adora first came to Bright Moon, it's discerning.

“Do you want to talk about it?” Glimmer asks. Adora shakes her head, ponytail still intact, even though she's wearing her night clothes. “Okay,” Glimmer says, teleporting down to grab a hairbrush before teleporting right back up to her bed. “This,” she says, tugging gently at the ponytail, “is coming down.” Adora removes the band and lets her hair lie loose: fine and flat over her shoulders. It's easy to brush, Glimmer's grateful she's not brushing She-Ra's hair instead. She can't imagine Adora being very patient if she had to manage it every day.

After a few minutes of silence, Adora says, “This is nice."

“Did you never do this with your friends in the Horde?” Glimmer asks, even though she suspects she knows the answer.

“No. The sleepovers we had—they were different,” Adora answers without elaborating any further. Glimmer can’t imagine what a Horde sleepover would entail at all. "Can I ask you something a little personal?"

"Sure, Adora."

“What was your dad like?” Glimmer sets the brush down. "Sorry," Adora stammers. "Was that not okay to ask?"

"It's okay," says Glimmer, eyebrows pinched. "I just wasn't expecting that." Adora moves to face her now, eyes wide and curious. "I don't remember too much,” Glimmer admits. She was young when he died. “He was kind, and he made me laugh. Why are you asking?”

Adora averts her eyes and hugs her knees, her loose hair covering half her face. "I never thought about my family before. In the

Horde, we were all told we were orphans, that our families died in the war. We weren't allowed to ask questions about them. I thought it was because the Horde was trying to protect us from painful memories. Obviously, I know better now." There's a strange bitterness to her voice. It's disturbing, the countless lies she grew up on. "I tried asking Light Hope about my family, from wherever it is I come from, but she didn't answer me. She was surprised I didn't remember anything from my 'own memory banks.'"

"That's how she phrased it? That's awful."

Adora laughs, harsh and unlike herself. "That's Light Hope for you."

Hesitant, Glimmer puts her hand on Adora's shoulder. "I know what it's like to miss someone who was never there. It's hard."

"That's the thing, though" Adora says, sounding a little startled. "I never missed them, until now. But it feels like losing all my friends again, like when I joined the Rebellion."

Glimmer considers this. "Do you mean Catra?" she asks, careful not to sound too judgmental.

Adora's mouth twists. "There were others too, Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio were all part of my rank. But yes, I do mean Catra, too. She's probably who I miss the most."

"Why?" Glimmer asks. "She's awful."

Adora laughs, and Glimmer's relieved she isn't offended. "Catra wasn't always so bad. It's complicated."

"I know," Glimmer says. "But still."

Adora nudges her playfully.

Adora wakes Glimmer up in the middle of the night. It's not intentional, which is what concerns Glimmer. It's always the same

thrashing, the sleep-fighting, it’s the way she sounds like she’s afraid of something.

*

Glimmer stares at herself in the mirror, the bags underneath her eyes are worse than she had expected. She could apply some makeup to make a poor attempt at concealing them, but she doesn’t bother. As she brushes her hair, she remembers the tremors in Adora's voice, the quiet way she spoke when she got sad. It's not easy to tune out, and distracted by her memory, Glimmer finds she's parted her hair in a different way. She likes it, she fixes it so it looks nicer, and then she changes into an outfit she doesn't usually wear.

If Catra wears a black sleeve for mourning, Glimmer will wear white. The sleeve isn't only for Adora—Glimmer *will* find her one day—it's for her father as well. It’s for everyone the Horde has taken away, including Elberon and Thaymor.

There’s a rebellion meeting later, but she doesn’t have the appetite for breakfast, or the energy to speak to anyone in the kitchen. So she skips it. She admires Adora's sword on her wall instead, she could swear it's waiting for its bearer to return.

As soon as Glimmer teleports to the war room, she knows something is wrong. She's notorious for arriving late to meetings, but the room is empty, save for Queen Angella. Regal and sad, her stare is as frozen as the murals behind her, as if she expects Glimmer to disappear before her very eyes. Glimmer could avoid confrontation, she could teleport herself back to her bedroom, to the Crystal Castle, or even back to the Fright Zone. But Glimmer remembers Angella's expression when she went to the Fright Zone with Shadow Weaver, and when she left her mother behind in the portal. She can't do that to her mother a third time, she's gone on

long enough without talking to her. As upset as she still is, she misses her.

“Where is everyone?” Glimmer asks instead, even though she's aware this must have been a set-up from the beginning. The Rebellion has felt Thaymor's loss more intensely than the others, Bow especially. She can only imagine that loss is what this is about. “I thought there was supposed to be a meeting this morning.”

“I sent everybody home, save for Bow, as he’s still too injured to make the trip,” Angella says stiffly, her violet eyes weary. "Before you argue with me, I am aware we were supposed to make plans to get Thaymor back, as well as Elberon, and everywhere else we've lost."

"So why did you send everyone away? You had no right, we're in the middle of a war—"

"You forget I'm the queen, I had every right," says Angella coolly. She stands up, but it doesn't intimidate Glimmer, not this time. "Meanwhile, you had no right to go fighting on your own without telling anyone."

"Shadow Weaver knew where I was going," Glimmer retorts.

Angella stills. “You told Shadow Weaver, and not me?”

“I don’t need your permission to do what’s best for Etheria,” Glimmer says.

“I’m not saying you need my *permission*, we’re well past that. But you can’t leave without telling anyone else, someone who *isn’t* Shadow Weaver. What if something had happened to you? Do you really think we could have trusted Shadow Weaver to tell us where you were?”

“But—”

“That sort of behavior is far too reckless, especially when we’ve been suffering from even more losses.” Angella sighs and pinches her nose. “And you scared, Bow, Glimmer. It’s not fair of you to worry him.”

“But I’m fine, I handled the situation with Catra—”

“Who got away,” Angella reminds her. “And sent the rest of her bots to Thaymor.”

“I know,” Glimmer says. Tears of anger threaten to burst. Her mom is right and she knows it, but that doesn't make it any easier.

Angella’s expression softens. “I know things haven’t been resolved between us, but Glimmer, I don’t know what else I can do. I’ve tried to tell you, I wanted to stop Adora, but she said—”

“I don’t want to hear any more about your last words with Adora,” Glimmer says. “I’m not ready to talk to you about that yet.” The words come out harsher than she means to. “Mom,” she says, quieter. “Is it true that I don’t have as much power as the other princesses because we both rely on the Moonstone?”

“Who told you that?” Angella asks. It’s neither confirmation nor denial.

“Who do you think?” Glimmer asks.

“We’ve always split it equally,” Angella says, sinking down into her chair. “When you were born, I relinquished half of my power so that you could—”

“And what have you done with yours?” Glimmer snaps.

Angella only looks ashamed, which isn’t what Glimmer had wanted. “You’re right,” she says, stricken.

“Wait,” Glimmer says, surprised.

“I had always wondered if there would be a cause to give you more,” she says. “I suppose if there was such a cause, it would be now.”

“Mom—” Glimmer begins, but Angella cuts her off.

“I can’t give up all my magic,” Angella says. “I can’t live without it. But I can give you all that I can spare.”

“You would do that?” Glimmer asks. And she realizes that's an unnecessary question, of course Angella would do anything to try to make things right. Glimmer shouldn't have allowed things to get this far. "Mom," she says, voice wavering. "I'm sorry, I—" and she teleports over to her. Angella hugs her, tightly.

"I know," Angella says.

"You don't have to give up any of your magic for me. I shouldn't be listening to Shadow Weaver in the first place."

"No," Angella says. "She was right," she says, sounding defeated.

"What?" Glimmer asks, as she pulls away.

"I've always been a coward," Angella says, gaze fixed on Micah's mural. "I've so rarely fought myself. As much as I resent that woman, she has a point. If I can lend you the slightest bit of magic to change the course of the war, I will do it gladly."

“Will it hurt you?” Glimmer asks. Angella is immortal, but that doesn’t mean she’s immune to pain.

Angella smiles and shuts her eyes. “No, it won’t hurt me. It will make me less powerful, but, as you know,” she says, opening her eyes, "I’ve never been as strong as you. And you—you've always been strong. But if I can give you more strength, I will give it to you. The Rebellion needs you. I don’t want to be the reason you’re holding back.”

“You’re not,” Glimmer says, letting her tears fall, realizing she's not the only one.

“I wish your father were here,” she says. It’s not something Angella says often, likely because she’s the reason he’s gone. “He’d be so proud of you.”

“But we’re losing,” Glimmer says. “We’re losing the war, and we lost Adora—”

“We won’t lose to the Horde,” Angella says with finality. “And we will find a way to rescue Adora, I’m sure of it.” Her expression softens. “I need some time to prepare for the exchange, but I’ll meet you at the Moonstone in an hour, if you’re ready.”

“I’ll be ready,” Glimmer says.

Six hours. That's how long Catra's been stuck with an endless horizon, forced to listen to Scorpia sing and practice something she's calling a "comedy routine." It's a cross between endearing and annoying, but it's preferable to when Catra has to dodge questions she doesn't want to answer, like "What will you say to Entrapta once we find her?" and "How are you going to get away with keeping the truth from Hordak?"

What's worse is the perpetual queasiness that comes with ocean travel, she's worried it won't go away even when they reach Beast Island. Well, that's almost the worst thing. Catra *doesn't* know what to say to Entrapta if they can find her, apologizing has never come naturally to her. She's not sure if she's ever apologized to Adora, even as a kid. But that's who she's doing this for, Catra has to get Adora back before the princesses figure out how to do it first.

Beast Island shows up like a skull among flowers. It grows in size as they approach, looking like a jagged piece of rock. The salty air becomes less fragrant, replaced with the odor of foreign flora. It's sour.

As they get closer, Catra realizes it's not rock, but the sharp edges of a structure reminiscent of the Crystal Castle: lit up a familiar, disdaining blue. “It’s First Ones’ tech,” she whispers. Of course it is.

“Huh?” Scorpia asks.

“It’s First Ones’ tech," she says, loudly this time. "It looks like the whole island is made of it."

“What’s First Ones’ tech doing all the way out here?” Scorpia asks. “Why is there so much of it?”

Catra's eyes narrow. *Old and corrupt*, Shadow Weaver had said, and she wouldn't have had a reason to lie. "I think there's something wrong with it." She holds in a breath, remembering the way First Ones’ tech infected She-Ra, made her violent, powerful, out of control. Her sleeved arm spazzes, she tries to ignore it.

As they approach the shore, Catra can hear it: a dissonance of humming and high-pitched sounds that only a technological monstrosity could create. Back in the Fright Zone, the ambiance was something she learned to get used to, but the noise here makes her shiver. The First Ones have been gone for a thousand years, which means these abandoned pieces have been left here for centuries, and something in them still functions, even though it shouldn’t.

"Scorpia," Catra says, sounding small in the way she hates. "What if Entrapta doesn't want to leave this place?"

“Entrapta will want to leave,” Scorpia assures her. “Sure, she loves tech but…” she trails off. They both know Entrapta's love for tech is beyond anything they can understand, and if there's something faulty with the First Ones' tech, it will make her even more

interested. Catra had been worried Beast Island would have done the worst to Entrapta, as resourceful as she is, but instead, Catra really sent her to a trap.

Catra angrily overrides the automatic feature on the skiff and sets it on manual, landing them on the shore. "The skiff should be set to take us back once we find Entrapta," Catra says. She looks around the area; the skiff is their only way off the island, but it doesn't look like anyone or anything is around to damage it. Still, Catra isn't going to trust the unknown. "Help me conceal it," she tells Scorpia.

There isn't much foliage, but they work with what they have.

"Okay, that should do it," says Catra, rubbing her covered arm. "Let's make this quick, I don't plan on staying the night here." She doesn't particularly want to venture back across the water at night either, but that would be less dangerous than spending the night on island covered with strangely tall and wired purple trees.

“That only gives us a few hours,” Scorpia says, looking at what's a cross between a jungle and a First Ones' palace before their eyes.

“Then we’d better get moving,” Catra says. “This place gives me the creeps.” She’s sincere about that, it's the same uneasy feeling as when she went into the Crystal Castle, and when she accidentally triggered Mara's hologram on the First Ones' ship.

“Entrapta’s going to be wherever the most dangerous piece of tech is,” Catra says. “Once we find it, we find her.”

“Right,” Scorpia says. “The only problem is, we don’t know where that tech is.”

“Then we'll have to look everywhere,” Catra says. "Even if she's not around the tech we look at, she'll probably have left a trail, and we'll follow it to find her."

Hours pass, and there's no sign of Entrapta near any tech they've come across. There's only more corroded machinery.

The deeper they go into the island, the more unsettled Catra becomes. Catra had always thought the Whispering Woods were fairly creepy, even as she spent more time in them. They were old, full of magic, and Catra knows better than to trust anything remotely magical, but now, she considers the Whispering Woods to be a paradise. Everything on Beast Island is sharp and twisted and it's even easier to get lost here, somehow.

A creature walking on its hind legs with very large eyes crosses their path and stops in front of Catra, so she hisses at it. Revealing its many, many teeth, the creature hisses right back. Catra holds her guard, doesn't flinch, so the creature hisses again and scampers off.

"We're being watched," Catra says, keeping her voice low, unnerved by the seemingly endless woods of purple and black.

"By what?" Scorpia asks. "More of those—those things?"

"I'm not sure," Catra says. "Just stay close."

"Aw, I knew you cared."

"Now is not the time for that," Catra says, and winces as the deep humming sound rumbles even louder. Scorpia doesn't react to it. "Don't you hear that?"

"Hear what?" Scorpia asks.

Catra tries to shake it off. It's quieter now, but it's still vibrating. "It's probably nothing, my ears are more sensitive than yours, that's all," she says. "Let's just keep moving."

A branch snaps. The two of them turn around. It's the same creature they saw a minute ago. "Oh, look how cute it is when it's not hissing at us. Maybe it's secretly friendly," Scorpia says. "Hi little guy," she says with a higher inflection.

"Scorpia," Catra warns, looking higher up in the trees to see too many pairs of eyes to count looking down at them. She and

Scorpia both have stun batons on their belts, they could take the creatures if necessary, but they have every advantage at present. “I don’t think it wants to be our friend. We need to leave.”

“Leave,” Scorpia repeats, as if she's trying to convince herself. It’s then she looks up to see what Catra’s looking at. “*Leave,* okay, got it. We’re just going to go on our way now,” she tells the creatures. “Should we make a run for it?”

“No, not yet. I think that would only draw their attention even more. We walk until we have to run.”

“Okay,” Scorpia says slowly.

Too late, Catra realizes that as she thought they were walking from the creatures, they were led to a trap, surrounded by possibly hundreds of them. She extends her claws. What she wouldn’t give to be surrounded by the buffoons that run the Crimson Waste instead.

“Can we run now?” Scorpia asks.

Catra starts to sweat. “Yeah,” she answers. “Now we run.”

So they run, but they don't get very far before Catra hears a thud followed by a panicked yelp. She turns back, and freezes—Scorpia has somehow managed to get herself tangled up in threatening black vines. “Scorpia!” Catra yells, scared.

“Catra!” Scorpia cries. “Go on without me, I’ll be fine.”

Catra would roll her eyes if there weren’t a whole pack of the creatures gaining their distance. “There’s no time for that,” she says. “I’m not leaving you behind. Just, claw your way out of the vines!”

Scorpia struggles to move one of her claws, and the vines only grip themselves tighter.

“Do I have to do everything myself?” Catra asks aloud, not expecting an answer. She uses her own claws to start swiping at the vines. They’re thicker up close, and not as easy to cut through as she had anticipated. Now she lets herself really panic. She can’t take on the whole pack of creatures on her own.

Next to Adora's sculpture in the garden, Bow rests on a bench, an arm wrapped around the bandages on his stomach. He never should have gotten hurt. When Glimmer tried to apologize, he wouldn't listen. He didn't blame her for the way she froze, didn't blame her for the injuries he got because she took two seconds too long to get him out of there. He should blame her, she thinks. It would be easier if he did.

But he's *Bow*, and he's noticed her now. "Hey," he says cautiously, but his eyes are warm.

"Hey," she says, and teleports over to him.

“How’d it go with your mom?” he asks.

“It was fine, thanks for the warning, by the way," she says, half-joking. She understands why he didn't tell her in advance. Angella said he was worried about her, and it wasn't fair that she thought she was helping him by keeping her plans to find Catra a secret. She's not going to make that mistake again. "Is it okay if I sit down?"

Bow nods, so she does. She doesn’t look at him, she looks at the She-Ra statue, far more peaceful than she's ever known Adora to be.

“I was worried you’d run off again,” he eventually admits. "Or teleport yourself out of the meeting."

"I thought about it," Glimmer says truthfully. "But I didn't want to do that to my mom again. I didn't want to do that to you again... I really thought I could handle Catra on my own but I was wrong, and I'm sorry."

"Hey," Bow says, putting his hand on her shoulder. She allows herself to look at him, kind and concerned. "Don't be so hard on yourself. Catra was prepared to take down Thaymor, I just can't figure out why she wasn't there when it actually happened."

"Probably messing with her new bots."

"You don't think it's possible she felt a little guilty?"

"Guilty?" Glimmer laughs. "Trust me, she wasn't. I don't think Catra knows the first thing about guilt." But she remembers Catra's reaction when she told her they were going to get Adora out of the portal, it almost mirrored the way Adora would always get sad when Catra got mentioned, how she went quiet. Almost. "But maybe Catra does feel something. She saw Adora before we did, in the portal."

"What?" Bow asks. "What happened?"

"She wouldn't tell me," Glimmer says. "But we're going to find out one way or another. My mom’s going to give me some of her power from the Moonstone.”

"Oh," Bow says, frowning. "How did that come up?"

Glimmer averts her eyes. "Shadow Weaver told me my mom was holding me back, and I didn't want to believe her, but it's true. When I asked my mom about it, she offered to give some of hers up. She's getting it set up now, I wanted to tell you before it happened.”

Bow stays strangely silent as he mulls it over.

"I think it's for the best," she says, filling in the silence. "If it will help me, help *us* take down Catra, take down the Horde—"

"If you think it's for the best, and your mom does too, I'll support it," Bow says. Glimmer knows he means, *I'll support you*. "If this is happening, does this mean things are better with your mom now?"

Glimmer nods. "I told her I'm still not ready to talk to her about Adora, but we're starting to move forward now. That counts for something, right?"

"Yeah," Bow answers, smiling. "That counts for something."

*

The Moonstone has always been beautiful, always been elegant. When Glimmer was little, Angella had once told her the story of how the Moonstone arrived to Etheria as a very large moon shard, left abandoned where it fell in the Whispering Woods, until the First Ones came and helped an old queen of Bright Moon channel its magic.

The truth is, no one knows how the Moonstone came to exist, but Glimmer wonders if part of it is true, if it came from out in space, or if the First Ones helped Bright Moon with their understanding of magic.

Underneath the Moonstone, Angella waits for her patiently.

“I don’t want you to feel like… you have to relinquish any of your power to me,” Glimmer says. "I don't want you to do this out of guilt for what happened to Adora. I know it wasn't your fault, I promise."

Angella looks at her fondly and smiles. "I wish the truth came from me and not Shadow Weaver. But I'm not giving up my power out of guilt. Ever since you were little you were always so bold, so eager to fight. You already have all the strength you need, but if

this means you don’t need to recharge so frequently, or at all, I’d rather you have it so I don’t have to worry so much about you on the battlefield.”

Glimmer is speechless, despite their conversation earlier, part of her couldn't believe that this was actually happening. Eventually, she manages to say, "Thank you."

Angella laughs, a magical sound, one Glimmer hasn't heard in weeks. “You can thank me after you’ve defeated the Horde,” Angella says.

"Okay," Glimmer says grinning. She looks up towards the pastel pinks and purples of the Moonstone. It’s her power source, her essence, her connection to her mother. The jewel of Bright Moon. Now she finds herself a little intimidated. “So how does this work, exactly?”

“Your father helped make the spell when you were a baby,” Angella says. “I believe I can replicate it, but you’re going to have to help me.”

“Dad taught you magic?” Glimmer asks. “I never knew that.”

The corner of Angella's eyes crinkle. “I was never very good at it,” she admits. “But that never discouraged him from trying, he was a very patient man, and he loved sharing all his knowledge.” Angella’s hand circles around in the air, tracing a flickering pink and white outline of a rune.

“Oh!” Glimmer says, anticipating Angella’s next movements. “Let me see.” The base is like what Shadow Weaver created to share in the Fright Zone. Glimmer adjusts things to make it a kinder spell. “I think I’ve got this.” Glimmer touches it and the rune lights up as white, and then evaporates, shrouding them with light.

Angella takes Glimmer's hands. “Do you feel it?” Angella asks.

And Glimmer does. She’s growing stronger, she's always felt her magic, but now she can actually feel it coursing through her veins.

It’s delightful, slightly bubbly, almost like laughter. But then she sees Angella wince.

“Don’t stop,” she commands, as Glimmer wills the magic to slow down.

“I thought you said it wouldn't hurt you,” Glimmer says.

“It’s not—” she gasps “—painful, really. It’s just a minor discomfort.”

“Mom,” Glimmer says afraid, and she pulls her hands away. Shadow Weaver took too much from her, she won't do the same to her mother. "The whole point of this was to get what you could spare. You clearly can’t spare anymore. Besides,” she says, opening her hand to summon some magic. “I’m ready to test something out.” It’s not an infinite supply, Glimmer knows that, but it feels incredible. “Be right back,” she says to Angella.

She goes to Salineas, to the throne room, startling a previously occupied Sea Hawk and Mermista. "Uh," Mermista says, completely flushed.

“I was just testing something out,” Glimmer says quickly. Turns out the downside to teleporting across Etheria is accidentally witnessing your friends make out. “Bye!”

She makes it to Plumeria, right outside the Heart Blossom tree. Perfuma is deep in meditation, so she leaves her be. She goes to the Kingdom of Snows, and Frosta begs her to take her back to Bright Moon. So Glimmer does, and drops her off near Swift Wind, before going back to the Moonstone, where Angella is standing with her hands on her hips.

“Well?” Angella asks curiously.

“I’ve been all over,” Glimmer says. “And I still don’t need to recharge.” Angella smiles at her. “I don’t think it’s limitless,” she adds. “But it’s more than it was before, that’s clear.”

*

“What’s it like?” Bow asks that night, in her room with her.

"What, almost unlimited power? Fucking amazing," Glimmer says. “It’s going to help a lot. The next time I face Catra, she’s not going to get away so easily.” Bow shifts on the bed, and then makes a face. “What?” Glimmer asks.

“I’m always afraid I’m going to fall off,” he says, making the same face he always makes when he gets self-conscious. “Why do you like sleeping with your bed so high?”

“It’s for the aesthetic,” she jokes. “And I don’t know. It’s kind of fun.”

“Mhmm,” Bow intones. “Not sure if that’s the word I would use.”

Glimmer props herself up, both her hands underneath her chin. “Did I ever tell you about Adora’s first night here in Bright Moon?”

“You mean, how she murdered her bed?”

Glimmer laughs, remembering Adora’s panic as she showed her the damage: the mattress deflated, feathers covering the whole floor. “She came in here at some point in the night. I woke up to see the Horde symbol on the back of her shirt, and totally flipped out. That was the only time I fell off the bed. I was too shocked to stop myself.”

Bow laughs half-heartedly. “That sounds about right. She never liked sleeping alone.” There’s a tremor in his voice. But neither of them speaks about it, the fact that she’s alone right now.

Glimmer reaches for his hand. “When we get her back, we’ll have so many sleepovers she’ll get sick of us.”

“We’d better,” he says.

“We will,” she tells him.

There's a burst of bright purple light, it startles the creatures, and it scares Catra for a different reason. It's not the same magic Sparkles uses, but magic is magic, and Catra would recognize it in any dangerous form it takes. Still, it doesn't make sense for magic to be here. For a split second, she wonders if it's Sparkles after all. The princesses have made an awful habit of going after the same things she's after, but surely they wouldn't have a way to travel to Beast Island.

A gruff voice says, "Get her out of the vines and follow me."

Not the princesses.

Catra doesn't have time to question it, but she glances towards the voice’s direction, it belongs to a man, hooded and wearing faded purple clothing. Catra can’t get a good look at his face. “And how do I know we can trust you?” she asks, helping Scorpia get out of the vines while they're temporarily stunned and not thrashing.

“Because unlike the pookas,” he says, pointing to the creatures behind her, “I’m not interested in eating people.”

Pookas, Shadow Weaver missed the mark with her made-up names. Catra will need to remember their name for when she edits the Beast Island file once she's back in the Fright Zone, safe from pookas and First Ones' tech and princesses. True to the stories, it does seem like their teeth are razor-sharp, even if the other descriptions were off.

“Good point,” Catra says.

“Do you really think we trust him?” Scorpia whispers.

“We don't have to trust him, we just have to let him get us out of this mess," Catra says, voice low. He starts to run, certain of where he's going. Catra wants to say he's heading south, but her sense of direction has been completely warped. She gives Scorpia a look, and they run after him. "Besides," Catra adds, "pretty sure if it came to a fight, you and I could take him."

Scorpia chuckles at that.

To his credit, the man is faster than he looks, and he doesn't once check to make sure they're following him. He dodges tree stumps and vines expertly. He knows his way around this place, Catra observes. Good. They’ll need a guide if they want to find whatever tech haven Entrapta has discovered.

The man leads them to a secure area, well, as secure as any place on Beast Island could be, Catra supposes.

“We’ll be safe here, for now,” the man says. He removes his hood. There’s something familiar about him, but Catra can’t place it. She never actually had to see any Horde prisoners, as a child, and he certainly wasn't a Horde soldier.

Scorpia squints at him. “You know, you look very familiar,” she says.

The man laughs. “I doubt it,” he says. "You look a little young to have been sent to the battlefields. But then again, Horde soldiers usually wear their helmets, so who knows."

Catra stills. She and Scorpia never bothered to change out of their Horde uniforms, and Scorpia hasn't taken off her Force Captain badges. They weren't expecting anyone else to be alive out here save for Entrapta. "You knew we were from the Horde and chose to help us anyway?" she asks.

He shrugs. "The war out there doesn't mean anything here, Horde soldiers and Bright Moon royalty are all the same once we’re

exiled to Beast Island.”

“Royalty?” Catra asks.

“Where are my manners?” he says. “My name is Micah, former King of Bright Moon.”

Catra stifles a gasp. Of course he looks familiar, he’s Glimmer’s father. It explains the Bright Moon colors, as well as the magic. Catra briefly recalls from somewhere that the king had been killed, but that wasn’t true at all. He’d been sent here instead. The King of Bright Moon would have been one of their most valuable prisoners, but Hordak has never been the brightest.

"You're the king?" Scorpia asks, "I didn't even know Bright Moon had one."

But the king simply laughs, “Oh, please. I’m no king, not here. Titles are of no use to us. You can just call me Micah.”

"Micah," Catra says slowly. "Thank you for getting us out of there. I'm Catra, and this is Scorpia." She knows he said titles don't matter, but she suspects he'll appreciate some veneration, and the invitation for Princess Prom taught her all proper forms of address. "Your majesty, I'm going to be brief with you. Scorpia and I are pressed for time, we weren't exiled to Beast Island. We came here to rescue the Princess of Dryl, have you seen her?"

Micah's friendly demeanor shifts. "The two of you... chose to come here? On purpose?" he asks, bewildered. Not that Catra can fault him, no one in their right mind would want to come to this awful place.

"Entrapta, the princess, is one of our allies. She was wrongfully sent here," Catra explains, leaving out that she's the reason why.

"The Horde has recruited princesses now?"

"Hey, I'm also a princess, technically," Scorpia says, offended.

Micah gapes for a moment, before asking, "What else has changed since I've been away?"

Catra has to be careful with what she says next, she's not sure how long Micah has been stuck here. "Look," she says. "Scorpia and I will answer any questions that we can if you help us find Entrapta." Micah's expression is firm, unmoved. "Once we find her, we're getting off this island, and we'll take you with us."

Micah's eyes widen. "You would get me out of here? Why?"

"Because... it's not right to send prisoners here," she says simply. "And like you said, Beast Island isn't the place for war. All I see is a man who wants to see his family again. We'll help you, I promise you that." She means it, she would never say the word lightly.

Micah considers this. “You really have a reliable transport to get out of here?”

“Yes,” Catra says, mentally grimacing at the thought of them all sitting on one skiff. The journey back will be a snug one. She won’t tell him the location of the skiff, though, just in case he tries to go off on his own.

“Okay then,” he says, holding his hand up. Cautiously, Catra shakes it. "Can you describe the princess for me?"

“She’s got really long purple hair that moves,” Scorpia says. Micah looks unsure, which is a bad sign. “She really likes tech and tiny food?” she tries.

“Oh!” Micah exclaims. “She stole my rations once, but only the smaller ones.”

Catra could cry in relief. "So she's okay, then? You've seen her?"

"This was a while ago," Micah admits. "Before I saw her head off towards the center of the island."

“Let me guess,” Catra says, “that’s where most of the First Ones’ tech is.”

Micah nods. “No one who goes there ever comes back.”

“Entrapta’s pretty resilient,” Catra says, but she’s still worried. “Can you take us there?”

Micah looks torn, and glances up. Catra does the same, the sky is barely visible here, covered with ominous, vine-covered branches. Micah says, “It’s getting late, though, and I dare not go to heart of the island during nightfall.”

“Of course,” Catra says, even though she does not want to stay on this island any longer than she has to. "We'll leave first thing in the morning, and then get out of here."

Micah nods. "I was wondering," he begins, but he cuts himself off.

"What is it?" Catra asks.

"I know you two are from the Horde, but, do you have any news of my wife and daughter?"

"They're doing well," Catra says. "You'd be proud of Glimmer, she's strong. Almost beat me in a fight the other day."

Scorpia and Micah both ask, "What?" at the same time. Catra chose not to tell Scorpia about the incident, it was embarrassing. If Glimmer didn't have to monitor her magic outtake, it might not have gone so well for her.

"Why is my daughter fighting?" Micah asks, on the verge of a full out panic that Catra is not equipped to deal with. "She's far too young for that," Micah insists, as if Catra has the power to shield her from the war. Catra only stares at him sullenly. "Oh," Micah says, after a moment. "It's been that long, hasn't it?”

Scorpia says, "She's around Glimmer's age now, sir."

Catra's not certain if the confirmation will help him. She almost feels bad, but she can't spare any more guilt. Not for a man she just met, not for a man she's about to use.

"I see," Micah says. "Excuse me, for a moment."

"It's a lot to process," Catra says sympathetically. "Scorpia and I will give you some space. We'll go gather firewood."

At a safe enough distance, Scorpia says, "You know, I don't think it's right for you to lie him."

"Who says I'm lying to him?" Catra asks.

"Catra, I know you. You're not really going to get him off Beast Island, are you?"

"I promised him, didn't I? He's going to help us find Entrapta, and then he's getting out of here with the rest of us." But Scorpia doesn't look convinced, so Catra sighs. "Look," she adds, "once we get him back to the mainland, the Rebellion will give *anything* to get him back. We're going to make an offer with Bright Moon, an exchange, and it will be one they can't refuse."

“Oh,” Scorpia says, not bothering to conceal her disappointment, as if she could have possibly expected anything else from her. "So he's your bargaining chip."

"Someone has to be," Catra says flatly. "Micah will see his family again, once they give us the sword. If they don't agree to the terms, that's not my problem."

*

You don't see it, you don't see the way she looks at you as you lie on the ground. Betrayal, you once joked about it, back before you

knew the depth of its meaning. But betrayal is engraved on her face, both yours and hers. The ground has stopped shaking, but it disappears, and you fall. She falls too, and you aren't capable of catching her this time, if you would even choose to do so, this time. You used to catch her, in dancing simulations and training exercises you would catch her, steady in your arms. And she would smile at you, playfully roll her eyes. But you can't deny that letting her fall in the Crystal Castle's chasm felt good.

And even now, in what appears to be oblivion, you would probably feel thrilled that it was the two of you together.

But she watches, as you dissolve into thin air. She watches, and you don't get to see the heartache of her expression, wondering if it's the last she'll see of you.

Chapter End Notes

tbh i just wanted to write catra going to beast island and getting worse, so, let's go!!

thank u for reading!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> cw for a few moments of suicidal ideation—it's mostly exploring what gets alluded to in canon, both with the portal and beast island
>
> also, my previous ao3 username was gaymergirl, sorry if there was any confusion about the change!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I fell asleep in a river, I woke in a river, of my mysterious failure to die I can tell you nothing."

— Louise Glück

Catra would rather fight pookas in the dark than spend another tense minute at Micah's camp. *"Glimmer is really around your age now?"* he had asked, not long ago, once he finished processing the true duration of his absence. More questions followed, and when Catra told him to quit, it came out as a warning. That's when he turned his attention to Scorpia.

To her credit, Scorpia answers the questions as best she can, upbeat and open. No, she doesn't know who is on the Bright Moon Court or how Mystacor is doing, but she's heard that their baths are amazing, and is that true?

As the two of them speak, Catra stares at Micah, carefully eyes the lines in his face, the gray in his hair. She's never seen anyone show a sign of aging before. The Horde's lifespan is a considerably short one; Hordak has always looked the same and Shadow Weaver keeps her face covered. The rare single glance Catra ever got of her face didn't give her a clue then, either. Catra

has concluded that Shadow Weaver is ancient, someone who would be dead by now if it weren't for the Black Garnet.

Catra wonders if Micah's appearance would be different if he hadn't been stranded out here for years. She doesn't ask him—the former king, the lost king—has enough to reconcile as it is. He tries to refrain from mentioning Glimmer, Catra can tell, but the occasional question still slips. The concept of having parents is still strange to her, she doesn't remember any of her own history before the Fright Zone. They were never allowed to ask. Even though Scorpia was raised by her mothers till she was four, her memory mostly comprises of the Horde.

Beast Island's darkness grows even more looming as night falls. Scorpia is the first to fall asleep, her snores are almost loud enough to block the ongoing hum from the island. Catra tries to cover her ears, but she can't mute the noise. Oh well. She didn't plan on sleeping tonight anyway, she wouldn't want to let her guard down out here, surrounded by tortured looking trees and skeletal remains. And her covered arm is so cold that it burns. She's been sitting near the fire Micah made, but it's started to dwindle. Not that it matters, the external warmth doesn't make a difference to her arm.

Micah walks over with more branches. He adds them to the fire, patient as he waits for them to burn, smoky and warm. "Couldn't sleep?" he asks.

Obviously not, she thinks.

He's either amused by her lack of an answer, or he's lost all social cues, because he sits next to her. "You know you're safe here, right? I've shielded this space from unwanted eyes. I wouldn't have started the fire if it wasn't safe."

"Magic isn't reliable," Catra tells him. "You should know that." It's not as if magic has helped him leave this place or communicate with anyone beyond the confines of the island. Catra wonders now how Glimmer can teleport when he can't, but she supposes

magic works differently for everyone who wields it. Adora needed the sword for magic, Glimmer's summoned it with her fists alone.

“Magic isn't the solution for everything,” Micah says agreeably. “But it is protecting us tonight.”

“If you say so,” Catra says.

They sit without speaking. Catra’s gaze is focused on the fire, the shadows surrounding them create twisted shapes, reminiscent of nightmares from her childhood.

Minutes pass and Micah still won’t leave. Catra has no interest in starting a new conversation with him—there's probably never been a time in history when a Horde commander and a Bright Moon royal were stuck together. She cares little for their forced allyship, as temporary as it is. Catra could have taken Micah as a prisoner earlier—she still has the means to, that gives her some comfort—but she'd rather take his cooperation for the time being. She doesn't want to wander Beast Island without a guide.

When the island's machines generate a particularly loud *thrum* she winces, and he notices. "Are you alright?" Micah asks, as if the only sound has been the fire crackling. The concern in his voice is genuine, but Catra can’t allow herself to dwell on that.

“What, you can’t hear that?” Catra asks him with a half-smile. She supposes that he would be used to all of Beast Island’s racket by now, he would have to adapt to survive. It makes sense that she’s still on edge, it’s only her first night here; but that blast was louder than the others, she’s still suffering from prolonged tinnitus.

Micah's eyes have narrowed. "What did you hear?"

She lifts a single shoulder. “I’m just not used to all the commotion here. I don’t know how you tune it out. The droning noise is more annoying, than anything.”

“A droning noise?” he asks, visibly shaken. That startles Catra, there's no way this should be news to him. “Like a signal?”

“Sure,” Catra says. “It’s just the sound all the tech makes, right?”

“It comes from the tech in the center of the island,” he says slowly. “It never stops. It might not be wise for you to go with us tomorrow, the noise will only get worse there."

“Please," Catra says, with an eye roll. It’s apparent he’s been on this island for too long if he thinks *sound* can hurt her. "The noise is nothing I can't handle."

Micah shakes his head, and there's something indignant about the way he moves his head, it briefly reminds her of Glimmer. Royals know best, according to them. “It’s not the sound itself, it’s what it does to you. The source comes from a corrupted signal, one that will... drag you down. Make you give up your will to live. I’ve seen it happen to other prisoners the Horde sent out here.” His face hardens. “Just be careful, Catra. If you start to feel weighed down by it, you have to let me or Scorpia know.”

Catra laughs, she can't help it. Princesses and their feelings. “Trust me, you have nothing to worry about.” Micah shoots her a look that's a cross between disbelief and concern. It’s too much for Catra to take, coming from a stranger, an enemy. She stares at the mess of vines and rocks in the distance, pretends she's talking to them, instead. “I’ve already lost everything. There’s nothing this stupid signal can do to me.”

“Oh," Micah says. And then, after a moment: "Who did you lose to the war?”

To the war, as if the war wasn’t theirs, as if Catra isn’t the war herself, a being made of rage. She learned that from the portal. The anger has ceased within her, but it hasn't vanished, it lies dormant for now. She was already consumed by it once, in the portal, she’s wondered if it will ever completely swallow her whole. It would be easy.

She bites the inside of her cheek. She lost Adora before the war, and that marked the beginning. The portal marked the end.

But here she is, still breathing.

“I’m assuming you’ve forgotten how to talk to people,” Catra says, unable to stand his empathy. Soon he’ll be a prisoner, and then he’ll be reunited with his family, and he’ll never have to talk to Catra again unless they see each other on the battlefield. "But temporary truce or not, I'm still your enemy. If you ask me a question like that again, I'll claw one of your eyes out."

Astonished by the threat, Micah merely nods in response.

“I think I’m going to try to sleep now,” she says brusquely, before he tries to say anything else.

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Catra's sitting by the fire Micah made. It’s almost completely dead now, she stares at the remaining embers. She counts them.

“This seat taken?” Adora asks. Adora has never once asked this, she’s always sat down next to Catra without a second thought. That’s how Catra knows this isn’t real.

‘Whatever,” Catra says. If she can't talk to the real Adora, she doesn't have much use for Dream Adora. But Dream Adora isn't deterred, she sits next to Catra and reaches for her covered arm.

Gingerly, Adora removes the sleeve, inspecting her bare skin. "It's strange having an injury that's not visible, isn't it?" Adora asks, an expert on injury. Catra doesn't answer her. "Every mark that She-Ra gets disappears by the time I'm me again."

Catra has already noticed: her cheek healed before she even transformed back to herself. Catra never doubted that the claw marks on her back have long since faded.

Adora continues to touch her arm, as if she's searching for a sign that the portal claimed her skin once. "Does this one hurt more or less than when the incinerator burned your tail?"

Catra sighs. "I don't think this even counts as an injury. It's just a side-effect. A scar without a scar." She allows herself to look at Adora now, but it's been so long since she's seen her that her eyes start to blur before her. Were they grayer, or were they blue? She startles, wondering how she could possibly forget. She yanks her arm away from Adora's gentle grip. "At least when I had a normal burn, it didn't come with nightmares about you."

(When Catra had nightmares of fire, Adora was there when she woke up whimpering. "Sleep in my bed tonight," *Adora told her. So Catra did.)*

"Is that what this is? A nightmare?" Adora asks, sounding offended. "Here I was thinking we were having a nice time."

"Of course you would say that," Catra snaps. "You always think everything is better than it is."

The whole world shifts before Catra has the chance to consider offering an apology. But now they're no longer on Beast Island, they're somewhere in the Whispering Woods. It's still, quieter than Catra remembers. When Catra looks to her side, Adora is there, half covered with portal light, only one blue eye untouched. It's devastating, she's never seen Adora look so angry.

"Adora?" she asks feebly, as if treating her like she's still her normal self will fix this. Catra's never wanted to fix anything this badly till now.

"You made me this," Corrupt Adora tells her. "You took everything from me."

Catra recognizes her own words, she wishes she could take it back, that she could say she didn't mean it. But whatever part of her was there—she did mean it, and both her subconscious and Adora know it. So she reaches for Adora's hand anyway, not afraid to touch her, to become part of the portal again. Catra would do it if it meant Adora wasn't alone. As soon as their palms touch, Adora disappears completely.

Morning comes, overcast and heavy. Glimmer wakes up with Bow close to her, in the center of the bed, safe from falling off. Their legs almost touch, Glimmer wishes they would. She finds herself holding her breath as she takes in how peaceful he looks. These days, when he's awake, he's worried, quieter than usual, laughing less. Ever since she met him, Glimmer's admired the way he tries to stay hopeful. Lately, she's discovered that even his optimism has its limits, the brightness in his eyes has faded.

Glimmer's tempted to scoot even closer to him, to shut her eyes and go back to sleep, but there's an energy keeping her awake. She assumes it's from the new magic, it'd *better* be. She can't fathom the idea of becoming a morning person. She glances at Adora's sword displayed on her wall as if it's an old relic, not something that belongs to a friend.

You wouldn't believe me if I told you I was the one who woke up early for once, she thinks, as if Adora can hear her.

She looks at Bow again, wanting to talk to him but decides against it. He rarely sleeps in, and he deserves the break. Quietly, she gets off her bed, tiptoeing down the stairs until she's far enough to be sure the chiming sound of her magic doesn't wake him as she leaves.

Glimmer teleports to the garden, it’s been a while since she’s visited Adora’s statue there. It wasn’t an intentional absence, war keeps her busy, but the guilt bites at her anyway.

The clouds darken. There's no roar of thunder yet, no lightning strike, but it will storm today, Glimmer can sense it. As she watches the sky, she’s grateful for the solace; Shadow Weaver's security has been tightened, so she won't be disturbing anyone in the garden anymore.

But that doesn't mean Glimmer is free from unwanted interaction.

"Morning, Glimmer!" Swift Wind calls to her from above, too loud and enthusiastic. Maybe Glimmer did wake up too early, maybe mornings should be cancelled.

"Hey, Swift Wind," she says at an appropriate volume. “What are you doing here?”

He lands on the ground in the flamboyant way he always does, leaving Glimmer afraid that she’s about to be trampled to death. Less than two feet away, he flaunts his mane. "I was just dropping by to fill Adora in on what she's missing," he says.

"You talk to her statue?" Glimmer asks, the guilt gnawing at her even more. She’s noticed that the statue is adorned with a crown of daisies that wasn’t there the last time she visited. She wonders if Bow gathered the flowers, as Swift Wind can’t.

"Sometimes," Swift Wind says, a little defensive.

"I do it too, but maybe not as often as I should," she admits. "It's hard when she can't talk back. And then I don’t know what I should talk to her about."

"Tell me about it," Swift Wind says, lowering his head. "Sometimes I really do think I'm getting close to finding a connection, but then it's gone. When I talked to Razz about it, she told me I was being too insensitive and hit me on the head with a broom. She said that just because I can't get a signal back doesn't

mean there's not a signal going out, that I shouldn’t stop trying." He glows—it's more of a flash, like lightning—and then it's gone completely. "I just wish I knew that she was getting any of this."

"Wait, you were talking to Madame Razz?" Glimmer clarifies. She's never met Razz herself; she's only heard Adora mention her now and then.

"What other Razz would I be talking about?” Swift Wind asks. Sympathetically, he adds, “Poor lady. She still gets Adora confused for Mara.”

“Mara?” Glimmer asks. “As in, *She-Ra*, Mara? That doesn’t make any sense. How could she mix them up? Mara lived a thousand years ago.”

Swift Wind stares at her solemnly, Glimmer rarely sees him this serious about anything aside from apples. "That doesn't mean that Razz didn't know her. I don’t know. She’s old and gets mixed up. And she just lives out in the woods by herself. She claims to have friends she sees often but I’ve never met them. And I go over there quite a bit.”

Glimmer considers this. "Could you introduce me to her?"

Thunder strikes, so Swift Wind covers his head with a wing. He peeks at the sky under the makeshift cover, groaning. "But it's going to rain soon," he complains.

"I can teleport us there. She lives in the Whispering Woods, right? That’s not far at all." He doesn't look convinced. "Please Swift Wind. I think I should meet her."

"Okay," he says. "But you better make sure I get some apples when we come back. The red kind."

"I think I can manage that," Glimmer says.

She leaves two notes, one for her mother and for Bow, before leaving. She’s not going to let them worry this time.

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Glimmer’s probably heard every story about old women living on their own in the woods: witches, healers, exiles. The princess seeks them out, makes a bargain, offers away her gold, her firstborn, her kingdom. Glimmer knows this isn't one of those tales, Razz isn’t made of magic, surely, but she mulls over what she would give up in exchange for Adora's return: her father's staff, her favorite piece of jewelry, an eye.

Her magic.

If only things were that simple.

Razz's cottage is quaint and colorful, nestled underneath the roots of a great tree. Madame Razz herself wears vibrant clothing, and butterflies dance around her. Razz pays the butterflies no mind, she sweeps the doorway with a stubborn passion. If she noticed the strange and sudden appearance of a girl and an alicorn out of thin air, she doesn't say anything about it.

“Oh!” Razz exclaims as a roll of thunder startles Swift Wind. "Dears, you can't stand there in the rain! Come on inside, Adora is waiting to see you."

"Adora's here?" Glimmer asks, suppressing her desire to believe her. Swift Wind already told her Razz forgets things. That, or Glimmer must have misheard her. If Adora was here, she would go back to Bright Moon, wouldn’t she?

"Uh, Glimmer, you shouldn't encourage her,” Swift Wind half-whispers. “She's confused, remember?"

"Shh," Glimmer says, stepping inside the cottage. It smells like freshly baked bread and flowers. Predictably, there's no sign of

Adora, there's no sign that anyone has been over recently, save for a small, unmade bed.

"Ah," Razz says, shaking her head. "She never makes the bed before running off, that girl," she says as she lifts a quilt up and spreads it over the small but cozy looking mattress.

"Madame Razz," Glimmer says gently. "My name's Glimmer, I'm the princess of Bright Moon. I'm—I was—one of Adora's friends." There's no response, Razz begins to hum to herself as she fluffs the single pillow on the bed. Glimmer clears her throat. "I'm sure Swift Wind told you, but Adora's trapped in a portal."

Razz laughs. “Nonsense, she helped me make a pie yesterday.”

“Adora was here yesterday, too?”

Razz hums. “Could have been today, could be tomorrow.”

“Great,” Glimmer mutters.

“I told you so,” Swift Wind intones.

“Not helpful, Swiftie,” she says.

"Now that you're here," Razz says excitedly. "You can help me cook!"

Glimmer wants to protest—she's only cooked twice in her life, both times with her mom—but when Razz hands Glimmer a basket of vegetables that need to be rinsed, Glimmer can't refuse her. It's not as if Swift Wind can help, and Razz clearly needs a hand, even if it's too early in the day to be preparing dinner.

It pours outside, now. Glimmer catches the occasional flash of lighting, but the cottage is warm and sturdy—there isn’t any rain leaking through the roof. Swift Wind is curled up by the fire.

Once the vegetables are cleaned, chopped, and cooked, Razz takes a bite. “Just how Mara likes them,” she says approvingly.

“Much better than the stuff in boxes they try to make her eat. She still hasn't told me what protein slaw is."

The disgust in Razz's voice makes Glimmer laugh. "You knew Mara, Razz? The other She-Ra?”

Razz makes a clicking sound and shakes her head. “You should know She-Ra and Mara are one of the same, Dearie.”

"The same way She-Ra and Adora are the same?" Glimmer tries.

Razz takes her glasses off, wipes them with her apron, and puts them back on as if that act was more important than answering the question. “Mara,” Razz begins slowly, “has a message for Adora. It's very important, she has to hear it.”

Glimmer rubs her head. She was hoping Razz could tell her something a little more useful. “I know,” she says, unable to conceal her disappointment. “She warned Adora against opening the portal, but things didn’t go like we planned.”

“Ah, that's it,” Razz says sadly. “Mara knows about portals.”

That’s when something clicks: Mara did live a thousand years ago, but Glimmer saw her, they all did. In a reality where stars existed, they saw Mara outside of the Crystal Castle, looking as surprised as they did when she realized she wasn't alone. "We've been going about this all wrong," Glimmer says out loud. "Swift Wind and I—we tried to get help from Light Hope, but she never showed. Mara can still help us, can't she?"

“How should I know?” Razz asks her.

Glimmer smiles in spite of it all. To Swift Wind, she says, "We're going to find that message for Adora. There has to be more to it." Razz looks lost in thought. "Thank you for your help," she tells her.

"You're welcome," Razz says. “When you see Adora, will you tell her to visit? Rude of her not to come like she promised.”

“I’ll tell her,” Glimmer says.

“Catra, too,” Razz adds. "I know that girl is still not eating enough."

Glimmer frowns. It’s not possible for Razz to have met Catra. Adora must have mentioned her to Razz at some point, and that thought troubles her. But politely, she says, “Sure, Razz. I'll see what I can do. Swiftie, you ready to go back home?"

"Only if you teleport us indoors," Swift Wind says, wincing as more lightning flashes.

"I'll take us straight to the kitchens," she says. "And then, I need to make sure my powers are fully charged.”

“Why?”

“Because,” Glimmer says. “I’m going to get Mara’s ship back from the Fright Zone. I think her hologram might be able to help us figure out how to save Adora. We're not going to keep waiting for Light Hope to show herself."

Two hours into their journey towards the center of the island, Micah insists they take a break. He offers them each a bug he’s pierced with his staff. Scorpia declines, mumbling something about how she’s not sure if that counts as cannibalism or not, and Catra isn’t hungry. She hasn’t been feeling well since her dream last night.

If part of Catra was devoured by the portal, it’s possible the same thing happened to Adora, stranded there without any refuge. Perhaps Adora’s spent the past few months living as a writhing, angry thing. Adora’s always had a softer side, even if she tried to

conceal it from the rest of the Horde. Catra couldn’t live with herself if she’s the reason that’s changed.

Once they’re ready, with a hushed tone, Micah says, “We’re getting close to the most dangerous part of the island, so stay close to me and stay quiet.”

“That won’t be a problem,” Catra replies, giving Scorpia a warning glance.

“Yep, oh, quiet, yeah, I can do that. I can definitely stay quiet,” Scorpia whispers worriedly.

Catra sighs. This is going to be a disaster; it seems impossible that they've even made it this far without running into any more pookas or other beasts. She lets Micah take the lead, followed by Scorpia. Micah keeps a quick pace, one that Scorpia manages to keep with no trouble.

Somehow, Catra can’t maintain the pace. Scorpia must be determined more than usual—the distance between her and Catra grows with every step. It's strange, Scorpia's never been particularly fast, that's something Catra learned about her early on.

The island's droning noise gets loud again, and Catra clenches her fists. The sound is beyond annoying now, it aggravates her. She tries to walk faster, she's never had to consciously do so before. She's used to marching across the Fright Zone getting things done, used to running across the battlefield, and she always beat Adora and their fellow cadets at a race. That was when she was allowed a moment of triumph. But her limbs almost feel like they're bound in place, like she's been weighed down, as if she's walking through water.

It’s then Catra remembers Micah’s warning about the signal. “Wait,” Catra calls after the two of them, but the word comes out as a whisper. Neither Scorpia nor Micah can hear her.

That's when she notices a shadow looming next to her. The shadow alone would unsettle her—she has Shadow Weaver's tricks to thank for that—but this belongs to something menacing, something *big*.

She looks over her left shoulder to meet something serpent-like, with an unnaturally friendly face. Glancing at it is enough to snap Catra out of whatever trance she was in.

"Great," she says under her breath. "And I thought today might actually be good, for a change."

"Catra!" Scorpia calls from the distance. "Catra you have to run!"

"Fall back," Micah yells. "I've faced these beasts before. You need my help!"

"No," Catra says back. It's clear to her, now, she needs the fight, more than she's ever needed it before. She needs the adrenaline that's starting to spike through her system. There's no one to prove, she's not even doing it to prove it to herself. Her body has to move, it's as simple as that. "I've got this."

"No," Micah says, voice stern for once, "you don't."

She doesn't listen. He has no authority—no one has authority over her here. It's freeing.

She extends her claws and jumps towards the creature, enjoying the return of her agility. She manages to get a good swipe at it—unlike the large spider she faced in the Crystal Castle, its flesh is easy to slice through. As soon as Catra's feet touch the ground, though, the creature starts to flop on the ground. Its movements are unpredictable, and everything is shaking, just like the portal, just like her nightmares. She grabs her stun baton, but it's no use, it doesn't seem like the creature is affected by it.

"Fall back," Micah says again, he's closer this time.

But Catra won’t. She’s not going to lose to a big stupid snake. She jumps onto a nearby tree and starts climbing higher to gain some height—she needs a better view of these unfamiliar surroundings. She spots a cliff approximately twenty yards away from here.

She's not high enough—the creature rises so it's face to face with her. The creature then reveals its true face and hisses, its breath is a foul combination of mulch and rot. Catra swallows, she’d give anything to face a princess right now instead. Or a spider, or several of them.

Micah starts using his magic to attack the creature, but that only draws its attention.

As it starts to head towards Micah, Catra leaps down and swipes the creature's tail-end. And then she runs. The creature follows her, flopping up and down on its way. It would be comical if her heart wasn’t beating so rapidly. She spots the cliff’s edge—and she freezes. If she fell here, no one would catch her.

The island hums, violent and distorted.

Catra didn’t know if she would live or die when the portal took her the first time. She didn’t care. That was the crux, and that anguish hasn’t gone away entirely—there’s a pull from the chasm here. As the droning sound grows louder, it calls to her. She could put a stop it.

“Catra!” Scorpia yells, more afraid and desperate than Catra has ever heard her. It's frightening, and it jolts her.

Catra exhales and starts to run left, and keeps veering left, away from the cliff. The creature doesn't have time to turn, it can't move as quickly, so it falls off the edge, making a painful sounding shriek.

To keep her hands from shaking, Catra bends slightly and balances them on her knees. Her legs tremble too. “I told you I’d take care of it,” Catra tells Micah and Scorpia once they catch up to her.

“That was an incredibly dangerous move,” Micah says.

“Catra, what were you thinking?” Scorpia asks. "We could have helped you! You shouldn't have done that on your own."

She stands up straight now, defiant. “I killed it, didn’t I? What’s the big deal?” She thought she’d feel good after fighting something and winning, but she doesn’t. There’s a sinking, deep feeling in the pit of her stomach, and her sleeved arm throbs like it never has before, despairingly. She tries to shake it off.

Micah stares at her as if he can read her thoughts. “You heard the signal again, didn’t you?”

“Don’t you get it?” Catra asks. “The sound from the signal doesn't stop, but it doesn't matter. The signal isn't affecting me like you think it is, I can tune it out!" It's as she meets Micah's wide eyes she realizes she hasn't been able to tune it out. The island was the reason she couldn’t keep up, why she considered falling.

“What signal?” Scorpia asks. Catra looks at Micah for help, she doesn't want to explain it herself. But he shakes his head. "Catra?" she asks expectantly.

"It's nothing," Catra says, but her ability to lie well has disappeared with her resolve.

"Nope," Scorpia says. "I am not accepting that as an answer. Your eyes are black, as black as mine. You tell me what's really going on, or I paralyze you."

Catra laughs. "Right," she says. The only time Catra had been paralyzed by Scorpia's tail was by accident. She crosses her arms. "There is no way you're going to—"

*

Catra wakes up to a stillness she’s never known. The air is stale, and there’s no threatening humming noise. Catra’s back is still sore where Scorpia stung her, and her head feels foggy. Her only solace is that it's not the island messing with her head this time. Her eyes blink open, and as she processes her surroundings, fear seeps through her. She's surrounded by old structures the First Ones built, mighty and broken.

Scorpia sits across from her, and Catra's eyes narrow. First, Adora stunned her and took her across the Whispering Woods, and now Scorpia has stung her and carried her across Beast Island. The rational part of her understands their intentions, but she’s still furious. Well, if she had the energy, she’d be furious. Mostly she wants to be left alone.

“Hey, Catra,” Scorpia says, visibly nervous. “I've got some good news and I've got some bad news."

“Where are we?”

“That falls under the good news. Micah and I found Entrapta and we’re currently at her hideout. She says the signal isn’t as bad in here, that we have a bit of a barrier.”

“So she’s okay?” Catra asks.

“Oh, Entrapta’s doing *great*,” Scorpia says with a smile, but it falters. “The bad news is, you were right, before. Entrapta says she doesn’t want to leave Beast Island, that she’s happy here.”

Catra hugs her knees. “Of course she is.” Too bad she’s not leaving Beast Island without Entrapta, one way or another.

“She’s in the other room,” Scorpia says. “You know, if you’d like to talk to her and apologize or—”

“I don’t,” she says sharply. “Just, give me some space for now, okay? I don't appreciate that you paralyzed me against my will.”

“It was for your own good,” Scorpia says. “Why didn’t you tell me you were being affected like that? I could have helped.”

“How could you have helped?”

“I would have figured something out. I’m pretty good at staying positive, in case you haven't noticed. Micah says that’s how the signal hasn’t gotten to me.”

“Do you have any advice then?” Catra asks, hating the desperate way the words leave her. “On how to stay… positive. I can’t—I can’t get like that again.”

“Catra” Scorpia begins sadly, "I'm not a professional or anything but... if this will help you handle staying on Beast Island... I think you need to think about something that makes you happy." Catra only blinks at her. "Or... if that doesn't work... keep thinking about something that makes you want to live. Micah said Beast Island wants you to forget everything good, but you can't, Catra. Promise me you'll try."

Scorpia has never asked Catra to make a promise before.

"I'll try," she croaks, and Scorpia seems to think that's enough.

When Scorpia leaves the space, Catra is alone.

Catra pictures bright blue eyes for a moment, but she stops herself. The thought of them would just depress her even more.

Swift Wind accidentally let her plan slip, meaning everyone had something to say about it.

Bow told her she couldn’t move an entire ship by herself, Glimmer told him to watch her try. Angella said it was too risky to go into

the Fright Zone by herself, Glimmer said she couldn’t risk bringing anyone with her, that they always lose someone when they go into that haunted, awful place. The other princesses were divided: Mermista and Frosta thought it was a good idea, Perfuma said she needed to meditate on it, and Spinny and Netossa both said no. Sea Hawk asked if setting it on fire would help, to which Glimmer had to explain it wasn’t that kind of ship.

Eventually, Glimmer snapped. She said she was going to move the ship whether she was staying in contact with them or not. No one wanted Glimmer to go to the Fright Zone without any sort of back up, so they gave in.

Retrieving Mara's ship was easier than Glimmer predicted: the ship was unguarded and empty. Entrapta was probably preoccupied with one of her million weapon-making projects, and she didn’t even want to think about what Catra was doing. She figured this was her best chance, and it worked: Glimmer moved the ship, all by herself.

Well, it sort of worked.

The ship was massive, and even with greater access to the Moonstone's power, Glimmer could only move to the Whispering Woods before she needed a break.

*

The Whispering Woods turned out to be the best place.

“I didn’t realize the sheer size of it,” Angella tells her, looking at the ship in awe. “We certainly don’t have room for it in the castle.”

“Good,” Glimmer says. “I don’t particularly feel like moving it twice.”

Angella arches an eyebrow. There’s a laugh that nearly escapes, Glimmer can tell, but it doesn’t. Angella has been carrying Adora’s sword, she grips it tightly, as if she's afraid to drop it, as if it'd be the equivalent of letting Adora go. It's rare to see her mother with a weapon in her hands.

“What do you need the sword for?” Angella asks.

“There’s a message the previous She-Ra left for Adora,” Glimmer answers. “I’ll show you.”

That afternoon, the ship gets crowded.

Perfuma says for a piece of machinery, the ship carries a lot of energy. When Glimmer asks if that's a good thing or a bad thing, Perfuma says that it's a neutral observation.

Glimmer doesn't buy it. Those in the Crimson Waste thought the ship was haunted, and even though she knows it's because Mara's hologram was stuck on a loop, she can't shake the feeling that they're not the only ones on the ship.

Bow brings George and Lance with the hopes that their First Ones knowledge will help. Glimmer likes George and Lance. Really, she does. But she wishes Bow introduced them to her sooner, maybe that way she could have a better grasp on their dad jokes.

But as they stand in the woods, looking up at the ship, the jokes subside.

“This was what you found in the center of the Crimson Waste?” Lance asks.

“It’s an incredible piece of technology," George says. “I’ve never seen anything like it. I can't believe the First Ones built a craft that could travel through space."

"And it still works?" Lance asks.

"We're not sure," Glimmer says. "Some things still work, but we're still trying to figure out all of the controls. Most of it is straightforward, but some things are written in First Ones' writing. Do you want to see?"

George and Lance make eye contact with each other. Their excitement is a little infectious. “Oh, can we?” Lance asks.

Glimmer teleports them in. Bow guides them to the controls, explaining what they've figured out so far. It's not easy, Glimmer knows. If the Crystal Castle reacted to Adora's presence, to She-Ra, it's clear the ship would too.

"You said the previous She-Ra brought the ship to Etheria?” George asks.

"There's a recording of her that we can play," Bow says. "She's on a loop. Some of it got distorted, we're not sure if it's from old age or the crash."

After they watch the recording a few times, there’s been an obvious shift in mood. Every time she watches it, Glimmer has hoped that something would give, that the glitches would stop, that Mara would keep talking. But she doesn't.

"So this is Mara," Lance says, once the recording ceases. "The constellations, Adora, Mara... they were all connected."

"I think I understand now why you went into the Crimson Waste against our wishes," George says. "But, I think you're going to have to go over everything that happened in the portal one more time."

Bow meets Glimmer's eyes, worried. She knows he doesn't want them to know about the whole "I was a librarian in that other life, just like you always wanted me to be" thing.

They spend hours on the ship, Bow accidentally gets in contact with the ship's A.I. who asks for the administrator, Glimmer is the one who shuts it off. Perfuma insists on rolling every window

down so that there's fresh air, and Mermista finds out that there's still running water.

They find no new information about Mara, Adora, or portals.

*

When Glimmer teleports both George and Lance back to their library, they hug her.

"We want to thank you," George begins.

"For being there for Bow," Lance finishes.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asks.

“Bow’s never really… experienced a loss like this. Adora’s the first person—well, I know she isn’t *gone*, but—”

“I understand,” Glimmer says too quickly. She didn’t mean to cut him off. “But if I’m being honest, it feels like Bow is the one who's been there for me.”

Knowingly, Lance says, “George and I are very grateful you have each other.”

By the time Glimmer returns to Mara's ship, everyone else has gone home, it's only her and Bow. She’s found a way to mute Mara’s recording, but she doesn’t want her to disappear completely yet, so she watches as Mara mouths the same words, over and over.

“What are you thinking about?” Bow asks.

“Razz said that Mara had a message for Adora,” Glimmer says. “I guess I was hoping that there was something more than what we

already heard. I know the recording got damaged, but I'm scared we're still missing something. Something that could help us."

“The damage doesn't mean that it's lost for good," Bow says. “I might not be on Entrapta’s level, but I might be able to figure something out, we’ve only had the ship back for a day. There's still time.”

“You’re right,” she says, offering him a smile.

“Is there still something that's bothering you?” he asks. Sometimes Glimmer thinks that Bow knows her better than she knows herself.

“What,” she says playfully, “besides everything else?”

“I’m serious,” he says.

"Mara mentions Light Hope in the part that glitches. I'm worried that... Light Hope might be gone, too. That something happened to her when the portal went off."

Bow’s brow furrows as he concentrates, a hand on his chin. It’s what Bow always does when he’s lost in thought, and Glimmer now knows that he gets this from Lance. “Mara was outside the Crystal Castle when we saw her. Since Light Hope is an A.I.... do you think she somehow got trapped? That something went wrong with her system?"

"I'm not sure, but it's possible, don't you think?" Glimmer gazes at Mara for a few seconds: scared and strong. She hopes Adora isn't as afraid wherever she is. Glimmer’s eyes grow wet, she shuts the recording off. "Maybe it means Adora might not be alone after all," she says.

"We're going to find her," Bow assures her. "We're closer than we were a few months ago, I can feel it."

Glimmer nods, and wipes at her eyes.

“Do you want to stay here, tonight?” Bow asks.

The question surprises her enough to make the tears stop. “What?” she asks.

“Lance and I found living quarters earlier,” he explains with his casual earnestness. Glimmer just gawks at him. He shrugs. “I don’t know, we’ve slept on nothing but literal grass before, I didn’t think it’d be that weird.”

“No, it’s not that weird,” Glimmer says. "It's kind of like an adventure. A pretend one. I'd like to stay the night here." She smiles.

Bow beams at her. “It’s strange, isn’t? I can almost feel her, like she's hanging out in the other room.”

“Adora?” Glimmer asks. He nods. Maybe the ship is haunted in its own way, and maybe that doesn't have to be a bad thing.

They have their options: there’s a room with two twin beds, a room with a larger bed, and a room with a single twin bed. They don’t address how they're used to sharing a bed. Somehow Glimmer's room always feels appropriate, even Angella's never commented on it, but here, it feels like they're trespassing.

"This room was probably Mara's," Glimmer says, referring to the bedroom with the biggest bed. What she means is, it would go to Adora by default, if Adora was here. What she says is, “Let’s go the room with the smaller ones.”

They push them together. It’s darker here in the Whispering Woods, inside Mara’s ship, than it is in Bright Moon. But Glimmer isn’t afraid. Not with Bow by her side.

“I wish Etheria could have stars again,” she finds herself saying. The view from the window shows them a clear area in the woods, a stretch of Etheria's starless sky. "Adora was so moved when she saw them in your dads' projection."

“Do you think there are stars where she is now?” he asks, quiet.

In the portal they were violently beautiful, untouchable. The stars didn’t belong. Glimmer and Bow didn’t either.

“Who’s to say there aren’t?” she says back.

Scorpia fetches her after a few hours, says that Entrapta has prepared everyone food. Catra tells her she’s not hungry—she knows her body could use the food, but she lacks an appetite. Scorpia insists she join her anyway, so Catra follows. She doesn’t feel like getting paralyzed again, since apparently that’s something Scorpia is open to doing now.

They’re higher off the ground than Catra had realized, she wonders if that’s safer than walking along roots and monsters. There are large screens covered with maps, dates, videos. One of them makes Catra hold her breath: it's a video of Mara. Catra recognizes her from the hologram, but here she's no longer a translucent blue. She's holding the sword—the same sword that's been pressed to Catra’s throat—and Mara’s in pain as she accepts it.

Did the sword ever hurt Adora? Did transforming take a toll on her? Catra never thought to ask. Adora probably would have thought she was mocking her if she did.

“What is this place?” Catra asks.

“I am so glad you asked,” Entrapta says, standing towards the end of the walkway. She doesn’t look at Catra directly, that’s not abnormal, and it gives Catra the tiniest bit of relief. Entrapta’s carrying a tray of berries and tiny pieces of cooked meat that Catra assumes is pooka. Entrapta sets the tray down—Micah takes a seat on the floor and helps himself, but Catra just stares at

Entrapta, Beast Island hasn't taken the same toll on her as it has Micah. That much is clear.

Entrapta's eyes do meet Catra's now—pink, sharp, and alert. "I would love to talk to you about my findings—I've been able to do more research on Etheria here than I have in years—but I need something from you first."

Catra swallows. She's been muddling over how to apologize for sending her off to this place.

Entrapta pulls out a recorder—Catra can't tell if it came from the Fright Zone or if she built a new one from materials she found here. "I already talked to Micah and Scorpia about their experiences with the portal. I need to hear yours too."

"You want me to talk about the portal?" Catra asks.

Entrapta nods. "Micah thought it came to him in a dream, and Scorpia said Adora helped her before she disappeared."

Catra whips her head to face Scorpia. "You saw Adora in the portal? Why didn't you tell me?"

"I, uh, didn't know how? You get… sensitive when Adora comes up in conversation."

"That's typical behavior, isn't it?" Entrapta asks. "She's always sensitive when Adora gets mentioned."

"But it's different, now," Scorpia says.

"Who's Adora?" Micah asks.

Ignoring Micah's question, Entrapta asks, "How is it different?" She's met with silence. Catra stares at her feet, at the small, tiny cracks on the surface she stands on. "Oh," Entrapta says, quiet and sad. "Adora stayed behind, didn't she?" She covers her face with a mask, a new one, inspired by a bug that Catra hopes is far smaller than the mask's scale suggests.

There's a lick of anger Catra didn't expect to feel, it brings her back to focus on her mission. "You knew someone had to stay behind?”

“Of course I knew,” Entrapta says. “I’m the one who built it, it was easy for me to figure it out. In the portal realm, I was in Dryl doing research. That’s where Adora found me, she brought Glimmer and Bow with her."

At the mention of Glimmer, Micah tries to interject, but Entrapta ignores him.

"By that point in the portal, I knew the reality we were living in was a shrinking one. They needed my help, so I told them how to fix it. But I didn't realize Adora would choose to stay. I suppose it adds up... she was always brave."

"Brave? She's stubborn and hotheaded," Catra says. "She plays the hero, and she leaves. And this time, she’s gone for good.” She takes Entrapta in, seemingly unshocked by the outburst. “I have nothing useful to tell you about what happened in the portal. Adora left, the same as always.” She doesn’t wait for a response. She goes back to the area Scorpia had found her.

She finds a corner and sulks. Adora *was* brave, she saw what the portal was like and chose to stay anyway. Catra wouldn’t have made that choice.

She wraps her arms around her knees, rests her head.

It’s Entrapta of all people who follows her there later, bringing the rest of the food. “I think you need to eat something,” Entrapta says.

Catra doesn’t speak, but she takes a piece of pooka, chews it thoughtfully. It’s tender.

“I'm sure Scorpia already told you I don’t want to leave Beast Island,” Entrapta eventually says.

“Yeah, she told me. And I don’t blame you. Of course you would find something good about one of the most terrifying places in Etheria.”

“Oh, Beast Island isn’t terrifying, it’s amazing,” Entrapta says. "There’s more First Ones’ tech than I’ve ever seen in one place. Granted, a lot of it is broken and worn down, or it’s been laced with malware that never got fixed, but I’ve learned more about Etheria than I’ve ever learned before!”

“That’s great,” Catra says, wanting to sound more genuine than she feels. "That's really great, Entrapta."

“That’s why I’m going to miss it,” Entrapta says. “Scorpia told me you want to make another portal to rescue Adora, and I want to help.”

“Scorpia said that?” Catra asks, not wanting to know how many more times Scorpia plans on betraying her today. Entrapta nods. “Well, she’s wrong. We’re opening another portal to make sure Horde Prime can find us.”

“Scorpia also predicted that you would deny it. She said you’re better about lying to Hordak than you are at lying to her. I don’t have enough data to prove it, but I believe it. I don’t understand why you would lie to me though… don’t you want Adora to come back?”

“Is it even possible?” Catra asks.

Entrapta nods. “Like I was saying, I’ve learned so much about Etheria and it’s mysteries. Etheria is all connected, it happened when the First Ones mined Etheria for its magic, when they made the runestones.”

“The princesses,” Catra says. Of course it all came back to them.

“You know that the sword is the key,” Entrapta continues. “And that Etheria’s elemental magic has been off-center—that’s why I experimented with the Black Garnet’s power at the Battle of Bright

Moon. I never had a concise explanation for all the anomalies, but Beast Island has the data. The whole planet is still imbalanced. That's why the portal," she quiets herself, "that's why the portal didn't work. Its capabilities weren't fully functional."

“Are you saying once the planet is balanced, we can use an operational portal? How do we balance a whole planet?”

“Oh, that’s the easy part. We just need to go back to the Fright Zone,” Entrapta says. “Scorpia needs to connect to her runestone.”

“Magic,” Catra says solemnly. “What’s the hard part?”

“The Heart of Etheria Project,” Entrapta says. “All that magical energy from the runestones… well, it’s complicated. I’ll explain it to you in the lab. Not even the First Ones could get themselves out of the mess they made.”

“We’re not First Ones,” Catra says, though she’s curious about a failure of the First Ones. The Heart of Etheria Project sounds important, but she won’t press it right now, what matters is that Entrapta is leaving Beast Island willingly. “We shouldn’t have the same problems.”

“Right,” Entrapta says. “I still need to run some tests, but I think it’s possible that once we balance the planet, we can make a new portal without exchanging anyone.”

“I’ll volunteer,” Catra says, surprising herself. “If it comes down to it. Whatever you need, I'll help you. And I'll... I'll listen to you this time."

"Okay," Entrapta says.

"No, Entrapta, I mean it. I'm sorry," she says. Entrapta’s eyes widen. "I owe you the biggest apology, I'm sorry for what I did. You were right, the portal wasn't ready to be activated, and I didn't want to listen." She squeezes her own arm. "I'm sorry for sending you here."

“I forgive you,” Entrapta says.

“You—you what?” Catra asks, looking up, meeting her eyes.

"It was wrong, what you did," she acknowledges. "You weren't acting like yourself, I know you were scared. And Adora... Adora was my friend, too. She doesn't deserve to be trapped between realities. If I can help fix it, I will."

"I'm really glad you're okay," Catra says.

Entrapta nods. "We'll take off to reach the mainland in the morning. I'm assuming you brought a transport?"

"A skiff, yeah," Catra answers. "And it's yours to mess with."

That gets Entrapta to smile, and in turn, she starts rambling about everything she wants to settle before leaving the island.

Later, as Catra tries to sleep, there's a faint trace of the humming sound, but it's not as bad as it was earlier. Still, part of her fantasizes about staying here on the island alone with the humming and the vines of sadness. Maybe the princesses will rescue Adora and Catra will never have to see her again. Maybe it would be better that way.

Chapter End Notes

> sorry for the late update, i've been dealing with loss in my own life so revising this chapter was more emotionally taxing than i expected. i appreciate your patience!!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What I feel for you can't be conveyed in phrasal combinations; it either screams out loud or stays painfully silent but I promise—it beats words. It beats worlds."

— Katherine Mansfield

Twenty minutes away from Beast Island, crammed between three other people on a skiff designed for two, the humming fades into a sudden silence. At first, Catra thinks she imagines it, that she's tricked herself into willing the noise away. But all she can hear is the litany of rolling waves and the uneasy breaths from her fellow passengers. Her eyes remain shut as her mind clears, free from the island's signal for good. She'll never be affected that way again.

Then, there's a scraping sound, a tool against metal. Entrapta.

Without opening her eyes, Catra says, "Please don't mess with this death trap. We're surrounded by nothing but water, and I don't feel like taking an unplanned swim."

"Oh," Entrapta whines. "But I can make the skiff go so much faster."

Catra doesn't doubt it, but she knows there's an equal chance of Entrapta setting the skiff off into an explosion by mistake. Besides, she's still marveling at the fact she made it off Beast Island in one piece. And her sleeved arm feels warm again, like it's finally flesh instead of ice. "Let's not risk it, okay?"

Dejected, Entrapta sighs, but her tinkering stops. Catra opens her eyes and faces Micah on the opposite side of her, lost in thought.

In approximately five and a half hours, he'll be a prisoner of the Horde, a bargaining chip, Catra's greatest gamble. Despite that, she finds herself asking, "You doing all right there?" It comes out more sincere than she expected.

His black eyes meet hers, weary and kind. "I've looked out into the ocean for years," he explains. "I don't think I ever expected to cross it, certainly not with Horde soldiers." He chuckles to himself, undeterred by Catra's stoicism. "I'm not sure if you've heard, but no one has ever left Beast Island before. I'm having a hard time believing this is real."

Catra swallows, diverts her gaze to the ocean: a bright and hopeful blue, less daunting now that they're miles from the island's shore. Beast Island's loathsome shape is obscured at this distance, but not as far away as Catra would like.

"Oh, it's real!" Scorpia says, trying to deafen Catra's left ear. "Bright Moon and your family are waiting for you," she adds innocuously, as if she's personally going to escort Micah to Bright Moon, as if she's completely forgotten Catra's plans.

Micah gasps, and says, "I forgot to bring something for Glimmer! Should we go back so I can catch a bug for her?"

Before Catra has the chance to say *no*, they are *not* going back to that place, Scorpia says, "Nope!" Catra looks to her left as Scorpia adamantly shakes her head. "People do not give giant bugs to people."

Micah looks stunned, and Catra manages to give him half a smile. "What Scorpia means is, just seeing you will be the best gift you can give Glimmer," she assures him.

Micah's shoulders sag down in relief. *It has to be enough*, Catra thinks. Exchanging Micah for the sword will be her best chance. If it came down to it, she knows she could sneak into Bright Moon and steal the sword, but that would involve more planning—she doesn't have a map of the castle, or the faintest clue where the

sword is kept. Besides, she's almost out of time. Hordak allowed her a week, and she can't return to the Fright Zone empty-handed, even if the sword is the very thing that caused all her problems in the first place.

That raw, angry, corrupted self of hers wasn't completely wrong in the portal—if Adora never found the sword, she never would have left. She wouldn't have had to sacrifice herself for Catra's greatest mistake.

Catra never should have returned the sword to Adora that day in the Fright Zone, she should have smashed it into pieces. Her arm grows cold again as the anger surges through her.

*

When they make it to the shore, miles away from the Fright Zone's external storage units, the moons have already started to set, leaving the sky a bloody, rusty red. Scorpia all but literally kisses the ground in relief, and Micah scans the area, looking for something familiar. His face falls as he realizes he's in the Fright Zone, far from home.

He clears his throat. "Thank you for getting me off Beast Island. It means more than I can say. I won't ask anything else of you, I'll be able to find my own way from here."

"About that," Catra says. "There's been a change of plan. Scorpia?"

"Uh," Scorpia says, eyes darting back and forth between Catra and Micah. "Surely there's another way we can go about this?"

"This isn't the time to discuss it," Catra urges, eyes narrowed. Micah has his staff, and she's seen him in a fight. She's not inclined to fight him herself if she can avoid it. "What are you

waiting for?" Catra asks. The question comes out high pitched, almost a shriek.

Micah raises his staff in the air but Scorpia's tail is faster. He collapses on the ground, and Scorpia props him up against a rock.

“Catra,” Entrapta tries, but Catra glares at her.

She doesn't have time to deal with both Entrapta and Scorpia’s impertinence right now. It doesn't make any sense to Catra, Micah is a stranger to them, an enemy.

"The king's going to Bright Moon, just like I promised,” Catra says through her teeth. She picks up his staff off the ground and it buzzes, a warning. Catra tosses it onto the skiff before it zaps her. "Scorpia, bind him and make sure he can't access the staff. Entrapta... just keep Scorpia company. I have to go and get us some better skiffs for crossing land.”

"Oh, are you going back to the Fright Zone? Because there are some things I'd like to—"

"You can't come with me," Catra says quickly. "Hordak can't know that you're back yet."

"Why not?" Entrapta asks, pink eyes wide and sad.

Catra wonders if every princess inherits the "making it almost impossible to say no" gene, or if it's something learned. Adora had mastered it, and Entrapta’s close, but Catra won't give in. It’s for Entrapta's own safety. Ears flat, Catra says, "Hordak might be under the impression that you betrayed the Horde. That you betrayed him by letting the princesses show up to the Fright Zone.”

“But I didn’t betray Hordak,” Entrapta says, confused. “I had nothing to do with princesses that day.”

“You didn’t betray anyone, it was me. I didn’t want Hordak to know what I did,” Catra says tiredly. She busies herself by getting

her bag ready. “Look, right now we just need to worry about returning Bright Moon’s king and retrieving the sword. After we get the sword… I’ll make things right with Hordak, okay? It won't be safe for you in the Fright Zone until then.”

Entrapta nods, looking crestfallen. “Will you get Emily for me?”

“Sure, of course I will,” Catra says, silently pleading that Entrapta won’t mention her new claw marks. That wasn't Catra's best day.

Catra slinks across the outskirts of the Fright Zone, concentrating on keeping her footsteps quiet. Normally she'd have no reason to hide, but she doesn't want anyone to know she's back. Even now, with Shadow Weaver gone, Catra’s position as a commanding officer can't protect her from everything. Hordak is testy and impatient. Rogelio would keep quiet if he saw her, and Lonnie would if Catra threatened her into it first, but that would require energy Catra doesn’t have.

More than anything she wants to go to her room and shower, to forget everything she's seen on Beast Island, and wash the grime and memory off her. But it's too much of a risk, and even though she grew up learning how to hide in and out of shadow, she was rarely successful. Shadow Weaver always knew how to find her and somehow, Adora did too.

Outside the storage unit, navigating two skiffs tied to each other, Catra spots Emily scampering behind the building. Once she notices Catra's presence, she ducks, trying to find cover.

"Hey," Catra says with downcast eyes, slowly walking towards her. "I'm... sorry about the other day when I... yeah." Catra doesn’t think she’ll ever get used to apologizing in general, but Catra can’t even tell if Emily registers what she’s saying. Entrapta always spoke to Emily as if she were a person, not a robot. "Look,” she continues. “Entrapta's here. I went and got her off Beast Island, I brought her back home." *Home* she catches herself saying, as if the Fright Zone has offered that kind of refuge.

Emily beeps at her in response, loudly. Her upside-down trapezoid flashes in purple like a code.

"Keep it down, will you? If you don't want to end up as scrap, you need to keep quiet and come with me.” She winces as Emily teeters backwards, trying to get away. "I'm sorry I said that, you won't be scrap. Will you please come with me? I told Entrapta I'd bring you back to her."

Emily appears to nod, and she follows Catra, keeping her distance.

Back near the water’s edge, she finds that Micah is still knocked out, and his hands are tied just as she asked.

“Emily, I missed you so much!” Entrapta half-yells as she stretches her arms out and hugs her.

“We need get out of here without drawing any attention to ourselves!" Catra hisses, jaw tight.

“Sorry,” Entrapta says unapologetically.

“Let’s just get moving, okay?”

“Um,” Scorpia says. “Are you sure going through the Whispering Woods at night is a good idea?”

Entering the woods at night has never worked out for Catra, real world or portal. And it’s been a long day of traveling already, Catra’s legs are sore from sitting on the skiff, and she can’t remember the last time she got a decent hour of sleep. But she knows they need to keep pressing forward.

“It’s too risky with a prisoner and Entrapta to stay in the Fright Zone any longer,” Catra decides. “Besides. We’ll make camp once we get to Bright Moon. I want to get this over with, we’ll give a message to the princesses first thing in the morning, is that clear?”

“It’s clear,” Scorpia concedes.

“Do you think we’ll ever get this thing to work?” Glimmer asks Bow the next morning.

Mara’s ship is empty, save for the two of them. Glimmer teleported them both some breakfast from Bright Moon’s kitchens, and they’ve been eating while working, not wanting to waste any more time.

Bow raises an eyebrow. “You mean, do you think *I’ll* ever get this thing to work?” he teases. Without Entrapta on their side, he’s the one most familiar with First Ones’ tech. If anyone has a chance to make the ship functional and to restore Mara’s hologram, it’ll be Bow.

Glimmer, for the most part, has been admiring the view—she didn’t wake up early to help run diagnostics. It’s not her fault Bow has abs.

“Hey!” Glimmer protests. “I’ve been cataloguing parts. That counts as something.”

“Sure it does,” Bow says with a grin. “Can you hand me that screwdriver?"

“Sure,” Glimmer says. She hands it to him but doesn't release her grip.

"Hey," he says, grin growing fuller.

Glimmer's heart skips a beat, it's the most carefree she's felt in a while, and she suspects it's the same for him. She can't remember the last time a day started out this bright and perfect and exciting.

The spell breaks once her communicator's emergency alarm starts blaring. Feeling as if they were caught, as if being this close together, being this happy was a crime, she teleports away from Bow to the other side of the room, pulling out the device. "Mom?" Glimmer asks.

"It's the Horde!" Angella says, panicked. *"Glimmer, they're here in Bright Moon."*

"What? Mom, how did they—"

"Please get over here immediately," Angella says and hangs up.

"The Horde's in Bright Moon?" Bow asks. "But why would they—" he pauses, looking at the interior of the ship around them. "Oh."

"I was so stupid," Glimmer says. "Of course they would retaliate once they figured out we stole the ship—they're the *Horde*!"

"The Horde has no right to keep Mara's ship," Bow reminds her. "We didn't have a choice. We needed to take it from them."

"Ha," Glimmer says. "You were against me yesterday."

"I'm always on your side," Bow tells her. "I was just a little concerned about you moving the whole thing by yourself. And I was right—it was dangerous. You passed out as soon as you got to the woods."

"I was hoping you wouldn't mention that," she mumbles. "What do we do now? If the Horde has invaded—"

"We're not going to lose the ship," Bow says. "And we're not going to lose Bright Moon, either. Do you have enough energy to fight after yesterday?"

"Trust me," Glimmer says, calling forth her staff with one simple motion. "I have plenty."

*

Glimmer teleports the two of them to the Moonstone first. There’s no sign of tanks or Horde flags in the valley, there's no sign of an attack at all. Even stranger, once they're in the castle, there’s no sign of anyone. The war room is empty, and so are the gardens. It's only once they enter the throne room that they're met with commotion. Usually, the throne room is a serene and silent place, the most movement being moonbeams reflecting against the gold.

Today it's filled with a crowd of people. Glimmer scans the room: there is a single Horde soldier, but it’s just Scorpia, and Perfuma has bound her arms with vines. Glimmer knows Scorpia is powerful, and can be deceptively nice at first glance, but she looks afraid. To her right, Mermista and Sea Hawk bicker with each other. To her left, Perfuma groans at whatever Swift Wind is saying to her. Off to the side, Frosta looks bored, which Glimmer has learned means something is going to break, or someone becomes a living ice sculpture. Finally, Glimmer spots her mother, standing near her throne and shaking her head.

Glimmer glances at Bow and he nods. She teleports herself next to Angella. "What happened?" she asks. "I thought we were being attacked."

"It seems I was mistaken," Angella says. "Scorpia has wandered onto castle grounds, but she made it all the way to the war room unnoticed."

"It won't happen again, Your Majesty," Juliet says, slowly approaching the throne. "You have my word."

"Good." Angella offers Glimmer a wry smile. "I won't ask why you and Bow never came back last night, but—" ("*Mom*, it wasn't like *that*.) "—I believe it's prudent that we all stay together in the future, in case the Horde does ambush us with a real attack."

"Don't worry, I'll be here," Glimmer promises. "But what was Scorpia doing in the first place? Is she alone?"

"She claims to be," Juliet says. “I’ve sent out a patrol to search for others, but we haven't found anyone yet."

Angella says, "Scorpia told us that she's here under a ceasefire with a message from Catra."

"And you believe her?"

"Why do you think we asked for Perfuma's help?" Juliet says, gesturing to the latest addition of vines.

“I don’t think this is how you’re supposed to treat someone who called a truce,” Scorpia complains.

Glimmer winces. Scorpia doesn't look comfortable and questioning her in front of an audience will likely make things more tense. “We should clear the room out,” Glimmer tells Angella. “So you and I can talk to her privately."

Angella nods in approval and gives Juliet the order.

Glimmer catches Bow's eyes before he leaves. She remembers the way they eavesdropped together in the portal; she wonders if he'll do the same now. She doubts it, considering she was the one who pushed him into it in the first place.

Once the room is empty, Glimmer approaches Scorpia, gripping her staff tightly as she does so. "So, Scorpia," she says, trying to sound braver than she feels. "What exactly are you doing marching onto Bright Moon's territory?"

"I have a message from Force Captain Catra."

Glimmer looks behind to face Angella, who gives her a slow nod, telling her to proceed. "And what message warrants trespassing?"

"Technically it's not so much a truce as it is an exchange?" Scorpia asks, nervous.

It's absurd. Glimmer could laugh. There's nothing the Horde could offer that’s more valuable than Mara's ship, though she appreciates that Catra made a peaceful attempt for once. She must be getting desperate. Or she sent Scorpia as a distraction.

"Go on then," Glimmer says. "Name the terms, but I should go ahead and tell you that the ship belongs to She-Ra, meaning it belongs to the Rebellion. It was never yours to take."

“Wait, you have the spaceship?” Scorpia asks, paling. “Oh no, nope. Catra will not be happy when she finds out about that.”

Glimmer stills. “Then what is this all about? If you’re not here for the ship?”

Scorpia takes a deep breath, and then exhales just as slowly. With pinched eyebrows, she says, “Catra wants to exchange King Micah for the Sword of Power.”

Glimmer can’t speak, think, or breathe for a minute. Her shock morphs into spite once it occurs to her that Catra would have no qualms using her dead father to get what she wants.

“My father’s been dead for years,” Glimmer says, the same time Angella says, “How dare you insinuate that my husband is still alive!”

Scorpia looks back and forth between them. “He was never killed in battle. We just brought him back from Beast Island.”

Glimmer flinches at the name. Beast Island is abandoned, monstrous, a cross between a fable and certain death. Glimmer was never even sure it existed in the first place.

"No one has ever come back from Beast Island," says Angella.

“That’s what Micah was saying!” Scorpia says excitedly, but the enthusiasm drops once Angella takes a step closer to her. “We took a skiff there and back. The Horde’s been sending prisoners there for years. Hordak nearly sent Shadow Weaver there, and then Catra sent Entrapta there—”

“Wait,” Glimmer says. This information puzzles her, she had assumed Entrapta’s just been busy with her lab. “Entrapta’s been on Beast Island this whole time?”

“Yeah,” Scorpia answers sullenly. “But she’s okay! I traveled there with Catra to rescue her, and that’s how we found King Micah.” There's a pause. "Look, I know you probably don't believe me, but —"

"You're right, I don't believe you," Glimmer says. "But the good news is, I don't have to." She starts drawing a rune, it’s never been easy under pressure, but she keeps her hand steady. “I’ve been meaning to practice my truth spell, and I can’t promise that it won’t hurt.”

“Is that ethical?” Scorpia asks. “I thought the princesses were supposed to be… I don’t know… nicer?”

“This is a war, Scorpia,” Glimmer says, pausing for a moment. She never quite considered the ethics of casting a truth spell, but the portal version of her father had no issues using it with Adora, and neither did Angella, who doesn’t stop her now.

"I'm unarmed!" Scorpia protests as the rune gets closer to her.

“I’m pretty sure that tail of yours still counts as a weapon,” Glimmer points out. The spell passes through Scorpia smoothly. "Now tell me truth about my father."

"King Micah is alive," Scorpia says. "And Catra will release him once you hand her the sword."

"This cannot be," Angella says with finality. She calls for Juliet and commands, “Escort Scorpia to the prison cell.”

“Shadow Weaver is already occupying the cell, Your Majesty,” Juliet says.

“Then find another one,” Angella orders.

“Wait,” Scorpia says. “There’s more I have to tell you! You can't—”

“I think you’ve said enough,” Angella says flatly, lower than Glimmer has ever heard her. Angella waves her arm, and Juliet leads Scorpia away.

“Why did you send her away?” Glimmer asks. "I don’t think I messed the spell up, but I could have tried again.”

"I was serious when I said that no one has ever come back from Beast Island," Angella says. "But She-Ra was supposed to be a legend, and we know that she's real." Her gaze is far-off, an ocean of possibilities she never let herself believe. Disapprovingly, she says, "I know Shadow Weaver taught you a location spell. I want you to use it to find your father, that's the only way we'll be able to verify if the truth spell worked on Scorpia."

"Okay," Glimmer says. "I'll collect all the ingredients."

*

The rose petals smell too sweet, lurking the pool of water as if they already know what’s to come. The spell is ready to be cast, but Glimmer's afraid of what she and Angella will find. "If Scorpia was telling the truth..." she begins.

"Then it means Micah has been alive all this time," Angella says. “And I’ve lost faith in him.”

"No," Glimmer says, shaking her head. "You've been blaming yourself for his death for years. Whether or not Scorpia was

lying… what happened to Dad wasn't your fault." Angella nods, silent as tears brim her eyes. Glimmer realizes she's crying too. After she recites the words Shadow Weaver taught her, she can't tell whose tears are landing on Micah's reflection in the water.

Hidden underneath the edge of the Whispering Woods, Catra waits for Scorpia outside of Bright Moon's valley. Catra trusts Scorpia, she knows she'll relay her message. Catra would have gone herself if she didn't think she'd be attacked on sight.

She sighs. Neither Entrapta nor Micah make very good company. Since Scorpia left, Entrapta's only spoken to Emily, whose beeps resemble little chirps, like a bird. Micah remains silent, Catra expected more anger from him, but he hasn't bothered to try to free himself from his restraints. It's possible he's accepted that this is some Beast Island hallucination, or he knows there's no way his family won't come for him. Either way, Catra can't look directly at him for very long.

"We need to stay alert," she tells Entrapta, as another twenty minutes pass. "And be prepared for anything."

"I thought this was a truce," Entrapta replies. "That there wouldn't be any fighting."

"If there's fighting today, I won't be the one who starts it," Catra insists. "But I know better than to believe that a princess can keep her word," she adds. Every promise Adora broke scrapes her thoughts, but Adora wasn't the only one who broke their promise. It's irreparable, what Catra did. Turns out she hasn't been good at looking out for Adora, either.

As the day grows brighter, Bright Moon shines golden and lovely. In some ways, Catra can understand why Adora would prefer this world, something filled with light, absent of shadows and

questionable food. Adora had offered for Catra to come with her here, not once, not twice, but three separate times. Catra always turned her down. Catra isn't meant for a world this soft, maybe she wasn't meant for the world at all. She'll certainly never belong to a place like this.

She glances at Micah, looking longingly at Bright Moon. Noticing her attention, he shifts his focus to her, eyes narrow and cold.

Catra finds herself saying, "I'm not sorry for this," even though she doesn't owe him an explanation. "I know your family. They would give *anything* to have you back. All things considered, I'm being generous. I'm only asking for a single sword."

"Do you really think you'll get your friend back on your own?" Micah asks.

"What do you know about that?" she asks, voice low.

"Just what I heard Entrapta and Scorpia talk about at the base," he says.

"So you know it's my fault," Catra says.

That seems to throw Micah off. "I didn't—"

"You understand then why it has to be me who brings her back," Catra says. "And I can't do that without the sword."

"And what will happen once she comes back and you're on opposite sides again?"

"I don't see how that's your concern," Catra says, before walking away.

Entrapta is still buffing up Emily, seemingly unbothered by their current situation.

"Something's wrong," Catra tells Entrapta. "It shouldn't be taking this long."

“I’m sure it’s fine, Scorpia knows what she’s doing,” Entrapta says.

But Catra’s breathing almost feels strangled. The heaviness on her chest lingers, intensifying as she hears the faintest sound of something shimmery, like tiny little bells chiming. Catra knows that sound.

Glimmer appears in the valley alone, carrying Adora’s sword.

“Stay quiet,” Catra warns Micah. “All of you,” she adds, staring at Entrapta for good measure.

“Hey, princess,” Catra says as she emerges from the woods. “You bring me everything I need?”

Glimmer’s glare is stern, resilient, and if Catra didn’t know any better, afraid. “Where’s my father?”

The sword claims Catra’s gaze: it glints in the light. It looks like authentic, but Catra doesn’t trust appearances. “You’ll get your little family reunion after I have Entrapta verify that’s the real sword,” Catra says.

Astounded, Glimmer asks, "You really think I wouldn't bring you the real thing?"

“Entrapta,” Catra calls. “Please make sure this is the First Ones’ tech that we need.”

Entrapta walks out of the woods and scans the sword. There’s a chiming sound, and Entrapta nods at her.

“Good,” Catra says. “Your Majesty,” she calls, tauntingly.

Glimmer gasps as she sees her dad, and Micah falters.

“Now, hand me the sword,” says Catra.

“Not till you release him,” demands Glimmer.

“Fine,” Catra concedes. “I can allow that.” She swipes at his bindings with her claws, and he rushes over to her. “Not so fast,” Catra says. “The sword.” Glimmer hands it to her, and Catra nearly drops it. She’s held it many times, but it’s heavier now. Ignoring Glimmer and Micah’s reunion, she asks, “Where’s Scorpia?”

“Sending back Scorpia wasn’t a part of the agreement you made,” Glimmer says, mouth upturned in her triumph.

Catra raises an eyebrow. “I suppose it wasn’t, but I’m surprised you would hold her as a prisoner.”

“Don’t worry,” Glimmer says. “You’ll see her soon.” With the repulsive sound of magic, Glimmer and Micah disappear before Catra’s eyes.

Just as fast, Glimmer returns with Scorpia, who apologizes and motions towards her. That’s when everything goes dark.

*

Catra wakes up freezing, her entire body shivers, not just her arm. It doesn't make sense; it was so *warm* earlier. That's when she remembers—it's the second time she's been stung by scorpioni venom in three days, her body must be taking longer to recover this time.

Adora. Shadow Weaver. Entrapta. *Scorpia*. Betrayal is synonymous with caring about someone, apparently. Perhaps it’s something she should be used to. Maybe she should have seen it coming—Scorpia was concerned about Micah on the island, but she was worried about Catra too. Maybe she grew tired of it. Maybe princesses only care when it's convenient for them, when they can do something about it to make themselves looks good.

When Catra opens her eyes, she’s met with vibrant blue walls, exaggerated by walls of ice. The ice doesn't make sense to her until she spots Frosta, making ice change shapes with her hand. A diamond, a sphere, a fist. Catra bites back a hopeless laugh. As if being held as a prisoner of the Rebellion wasn't embarrassing enough—she’s being guarded by a thirteen-year-old. Someone who hasn’t even noticed that she’s awake. It would be easy to get out of here unscathed. So easy, that Catra wonders if that’s the point, if it’s a test, to see how far Catra will go.

Who knows how many guards lie beyond that door anyway.

To Catra’s right, there's a table with maps and what appears to be the Rebellion's war plans, or a very elaborate game. When her eyes scan over SHE-RA in big letters, Catra looks away, no longer interested in reading the rest of it. Of course *She-Ra* is their priority, not Adora.

“Are you sure it’s such a good idea to keep me in your war room?” Catra asks, startling Frosta. She drops her ice cube onto the ground.

Surprisingly, Frosta keeps a level head. “This is temporary, we’re running low on holding cells at the moment.” But Frosta leaves her post to turn off the projection. Not that it makes much of a difference, there was nothing useful Catra could have gleamed from it.

“Sounds like you all could learn from the Horde,” Catra says. “We have plenty of space for prisoners, and too many vacancies.”

“We have proper holdings in the Kingdom of Snows,” Frosta admits. “But Bright Moon—”

“Bright Moon is different?” Catra supplies.

"That's enough talking," Frosta says, glare cold, aware she’s on the verge of saying too much.

Catra has to give the kid some credit, she has a threatening manner. That will come in handy some day. "Fair enough," she says evenly, wanting nothing more than to rub her hands against her arms for friction, for warmth. But her bindings are too tight, and she doesn't think she's flexible enough to claw herself out of them. Not yet at least. Besides, she wouldn't want to give Frosta the satisfaction, even though her teeth are verging on chattering. It's unfair, she thinks, the way Frosta wears layers of warm clothes.

"I need to talk to Scorpia," she ends up saying.

"You're in no place to make demands, now, Horde scum," Frosta snaps. "Besides, Scorpia's under our protection now."

"Your protection? Are you kidding me? She's the one who attacked me, what can I do while you have me bound?" Frosta answers by making more ice appear. "She's a force captain too you know," Catra adds. Ex-force captain, now. But there's nothing she can say to change Frosta's mind.

*

"Is this necessary?" Bow asks, an hour later, as he switches spots with Frosta. He's holding a tray of food.

"*She's* the one who opened the portal," Frosta says.

"And I'm the one who has to stay with her for the next few hours," Bow says, pointing to his uncovered stomach. "Can you get rid of the ice, please?"

"Fine," Frosta groans. Catra's not sure how her magic works, but as soon as the ice leaves, the room warms up. "But I'll have you know it made her much more cooperative."

"We don't freeze prisoners in Bright Moon, Frosta," Bow insists.

"Have it your way," Frosta says, giving Catra one last glare before she leaves the room.

"Sorry about that," Bow says. "She was the first to volunteer and —"

"No one's keen on keeping an eye on me, got it," Catra finishes for him.

Unsure of how to respond, Bow says, "I brought you some food, if you're hungry."

It's nothing Catra recognizes. She's sure it's edible, she's sure it's *good*, maybe not by Bright Moon standards, but anything would beat ration bars. Still, she lies. "I'm not hungry."

"Let me know if you change your mind, okay?" For whatever reason, he sounds sincere, like he cares. And he shouldn't, not after everything she's done. It reminds Catra of when Glimmer and Bow captured her what, a year ago? Two years ago? Is that how long this has been going on?

"Shouldn't you be out celebrating?" Catra asks.

"Celebrating what?" Bow asks.

"I don't know, it's not every day you keep a captive force captain in Bright Moon. Or find out a missing king's still alive."

"You can drop the act now, you know," Bow says gently. "It's just me."

"Right, because the two of us have always been such great friends," she drawls.

His expression hardens. "Glimmer told me you saw Adora in the portal. I was wondering if you could tell me what happened."

“What difference does that make?” Catra asks. She can’t face him, she presses her back against the wall and curls up into the corner. “Adora’s gone. It doesn’t matter if we fought or not in the portal, she’s still stuck there and I’m—I’m still stuck here with you.”

Bow sighs, she didn’t think it was possible for him to sound this exasperated. “I think,” he says, “if you showed that you were willing, we could all work together to help bring Adora back.”

Catra can’t bite back her laughter this time. “And why would I do that? The Horde is winning, and once Hordak finds out you’re keeping me here, he’ll send out reinforcements to retrieve me. If I don’t get out of here myself first, that is.”

There’s a beat of silence.

“I don’t believe you,” he says.

“Look, Arrow Boy,” she says.

“It’s Bow,” he reminds her.

“You don’t know me and you don’t know what I’ve been through.”

“But Adora—”

“She’s gone,” she says, and her voice cracks. “And if—if there is a way to bring her back, she’s not going to want to see me again, so you should just get rid of me or execute me by then.”

“That’s not how the Rebellion handles things, Catra.”

“Well, that’s a shame,” she says. "And that's why the Rebellion is going to lose."

Bow must be shocked into silence, but she doesn’t take it back. He doesn't speak another word to her, doesn't even say goodbye once he's replaced by a guard Catra doesn't recognize.

Seeing Micah in the portal felt more real than whatever Glimmer is experiencing right now. Her father is there before her eyes, grayer and gruffer than her memory serves, but he’s here in the throne room. It's dreamlike. He hasn't commented on the solitary throne —there were two in the portal, Glimmer remembers that now— and she wonders if the single throne is strange for him, how strange this all must be for him.

Glimmer supposes most kids get tired of hearing their parents say pet names to each other, but with every “darling” spoken tenderly by Micah or Angella, Glimmer’s heart warms up so fast it threatens to burst. And every time he says, "Glimmer," her name comes out half-broken, all fond. That's how Glimmer feels, too. All these years, she had accepted that he was gone, it was devastating to find him in the portal, only to lose him once more.

Even Castaspella has transformed before her eyes. Glimmer doesn't think she's ever heard Castaspella laugh so loudly, and she's always laughing at something, usually her own jokes.

“I can’t believe you’re all grown up," he tells Glimmer.

“I know,” she says, with a small laugh.

“Please, my love,” Angella says. “You must tell me what’s happened. I’ve never heard of anyone surviving the perils of Beast Island.”

So he tells them.

It’s hours later when Juliet tentatively disturbs them, asking what steps to take next with their three newly acquired Horde prisoners.

“I’ll take care of it,” Glimmer says, surprising herself. “If that’s okay,” she adds. Her parents have been apart from each other for over a decade, the least she can do is give them some privacy.

Besides, Juliet is right, they have urgent matters to deal with. "You guys need to eat," she says. "Dad needs some real food."

Angella smiles at her gratefully. “She’s quite the leader, you know," Angella tells Micah as Glimmer starts to teleport away.

“I heard she’s a great fighter too,” Micah adds.

Glimmer can't stop smiling, she can't remember the last time she's been this happy. Not since Adora—

The smile vanishes once Glimmer teleports to the war room. The guard watching the door straightens up in Glimmer's presence. Glimmer knows she's due to face Catra, to question her, but she doesn't have the energy, and Catra is exhausting. She'll deal with her tomorrow. She makes orders to find a more appropriate room for her, they’re going to need the war room during the next few days.

The designated room for both Entrapta and Scorpia is a guest bedroom with an excess of pillows, superfluous even by Bright Moon standards.

Scorpia’s no longer bound by vines, distractedly comparing two pillows. “I didn’t know pillows could *be* this soft,” Scorpia tells Perfuma, who appears to be listening to Scorpia a little too intently.

Mermista sits in a corner, looking bored out of her mind as Entrapta wanders across the room.

Glimmer clears her throat. “I’d like to speak to the prisoners alone,” she says.

“Finally,” Mermista says, as Perfuma asks, “Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.”

Once they exit the room, Scorpia asks, “Are we really still prisoners? I thought we had an understanding when I told you

about the Heart of Etheria.”

Scorpia explained it to Glimmer frantically, telling her that Catra wouldn’t hesitate to use it once she got the sword, and that made Scorpia afraid.

“It’s complicated,” Glimmer says. She believes Scorpia is earnest to do the right thing, but Entrapta was their ally once, before she joined the Horde. Whether or not she was on Beast Island for months, Glimmer doesn’t know if she can trust her. "The two of you can't automatically become our allies, but I don't want to hold you in here against your will, either."

Entrapta shrugs. "That makes sense to me," she says.

Glimmer waits for a moment, curious to see if Entrapta will denounce the Horde, or give any indication that she's no longer on their side. Maybe Glimmer will never be able to pin where her loyalties lie.

Interrupting her thoughts, Scorpia asks, “Where’s Catra?”

“She’s by herself, for now,” Glimmer says. “I thought it might be best to keep you separate from her, for the time-being."

"Because I betrayed her," Scorpia says sullenly. "Don't get me wrong," she adds, catching Glimmer's eye, "I don't regret what I did but, I know it's going to be hard on her. First Adora left the Horde and she says she got over it, but frankly I don't think she did. And then Shadow Weaver—"

"Look," Glimmer says. "I know things are convoluted right now, but we need to talk about why you did it. Entrapta, you know more about the Heart of the Etheria. Scorpia told me it's a weapon capable of destroying all of Etheria, is that true?"

"Oh yes, it’s fascinating work,” Entrapta says. Met with silence, she continues, "But it is dangerous. The First Ones couldn’t control it. It can't be accessed until the planet is balanced, but I'm not sure if it can be activated without She-Ra."

"And Catra doesn't know that it's a weapon?"

"That's correct!" Entrapta says. “She wanted to open another portal, but I didn’t tell her what the Heart’s capable of. She has a tendency not to listen to my warnings.”

Glimmer doesn’t think there’s a single person Catra would listen to. She rolls her eyes. "You're telling me that after everything, Catra still wants to open another portal? To invite the rest of the Horde army through?"

"To see if she could bring Adora back," Scorpia says.

*

“So what now?” Bow asks her, in her room that night. They’re sitting on her bench by the window.

“I don’t know,” Glimmer says. “I do believe that Entrapta and Scorpia want to help us, but I know it won’t be easy convincing everybody else.”

“And Catra?”

Glimmer rubs her arm. “I’m not sure. Scorpia said she did all this to try to bring Adora back, but she was pretty awful to my dad,” she says.

“I can’t believe he was on Beast Island this whole time,” Bow says. “How is he?”

“He’s okay, he’s still adjusting. I think he’s going to be adjusting for a while.”

How are *you* doing?” Bow tries.

Glimmer doesn't have an immediate answer for him, it's been strange all her life, to miss someone she never knew. Now she has the chance to know him. "I'm still in shock, if I'm being honest," Glimmer says, leaning her head on his shoulder. "I thought Scorpia was lying at first, that Catra somehow found out about my father's death and was trying to trick us into getting the sword. But it's good to see him, again. After the portal I never thought I'd have a chance."

"I think that might explain part of the portal," Bow says. "It felt so natural that he was there. And it wasn't because the portal brought a dead person back to life—it's because he was still out there. It was almost life as it should have been."

Glimmer considers this. It was dreamy, before Adora showed up in that world, before they had to leave. Before Adora had to stay behind.

"*Except you don't remember the Horde because the Fright Zone disappeared,"* Adora had said to them. She was worried about Bright Moon disappearing the same way.

"Bow," Glimmer says. "Do you really think it was a perfect world for us in the portal?"

"I mean, it wasn't a *perfect* world," Bow replies. "I wasn't wearing a crop top," he says with a smile. But the smile fades quickly. "And Adora wasn't there with us, not until she chose to find us."

"Exactly," Glimmer says. "And we know Catra saw her in the portal before the Fright Zone disappeared."

"About that," Bow begins. "When I asked Catra what happened, she sort of shut down?"

"What, no lashing out?"

"There was a little of that, but she still seemed… off today. During the whole visit. But I know it couldn't have been easy, to have Scorpia switch sides on her like that. And there's only so much we

can resolve without Adora, here." He sighs. "I know it's going to sound strange, but I'm worried about her."

Glimmer nods. It's not that strange, Bow's always been caring, and despite how Glimmer feels about Catra, she meant something to Adora. "I'll visit her myself, first thing in the morning. We have to come to some understanding with her, right? If we want to get Adora back." She swallows. "Bow, what if we can't? The Heart of Etheria… it might not be something we're equipped to handle. If Entrapta's current hypothesis is correct, we can't open a functional portal without putting everyone else at risk."

"We don't know for sure, though. If anyone can figure out how to work with First Ones tech, it's Entrapta. I'm glad she's on our side again."

"I think it's a little more complicated than that," Glimmer says. "But I'm glad she's safe and not on Beast Island. I can't believe we didn't know she was there."

"We never really got the chance to apologize to her," Bow says. "Maybe now we can start making our own amends."

"You're right," Glimmer says. "We will." She yawns.

"You tired?" Bow asks.

"Yeah, but… I'm sort of afraid that I'll fall asleep and my dad will be gone again," she admits. "And I know it's messed up, to be this happy when Adora's still missing, but…"

"Don't do that," Bow says. "Adora would want you to be happy. I'm sure she'd be thrilled he's alive."

"Thanks, Bow."

They move Catra to a smaller room, one with a window—too small for her to climb out of. She's left alone. She knows she's not really alone, that there's at least one guard standing right outside her door, but at least they gave her some privacy.

Not that she's going to sleep a wink. There's a cot for her, with a matching lavender pillow and blanket set. Catra touches the fabric, it's soft, but it's pointless. She's not going to feel safe sleeping here.

She walks towards the window, peers through it curiously. She figures there can't be a bad view in this place, but she sucks in a breath, seeing an outline that resembles She-Ra. "Adora?" she asks, almost a plea. The outline is still. Catra squints at it: it's made of ice. The Horde doesn't memorialize lost ones this way, but something cracks underneath her ribs. This dedication is for She-Ra, not Adora.

Dizzy, she sits down. She should have eaten when Bow gave her the chance. She's tempted to shred the blanket, but she shivers at the thought of earlier today, with Frosta's freezing technique, so she decides against it.

It's ironic, how badly Adora had wanted Catra to come to Bright Moon. "Well, here I am," she says to the statue. "I know it's not the way you wanted." She could apologize to the statue, but she doesn't see what good it will do. Even if she were speaking to Adora, she probably wouldn't accept it, she'd probably be glad Catra's trapped in this room, too numb to plan an escape.

There's no point in trying. Bow believed her bluff, but Hordak won't come for her. Scorpia's the one who got herself in this mess in the first place, and as for Entrapta, if she wanted to help Catra escape, she would have done so already. Catra doubts there's much animosity between them, but there's not devotion there, either.

Even if she could escape by some miracle, it won't matter unless she can get her hands on the sword again and convince Scorpia

to come back with her. But Scorpia left her. It's a pattern Catra doesn't know how to break. Catra can't return to the Fright Zone with nothing but her failure, she'd rather go to the Crimson Waste again than risk that. As temporary as it was, she was happy there. She wonders if she'll know that fleeting happiness again.

The room darkens, and the hair on the back of her neck rises. She knew Shadow Weaver was in Bright Moon, that she has some sort of agreement with Glimmer, but Catra didn't think Shadow Weaver would go out of her way to find her.

She lurks in the doorway, tall and sinister as ever.

"Here to rub it in my face now that I'm the prisoner this time?" Catra asks. Taunting Shadow Weaver in her Horde cell never felt as good as she wanted it to, but Shadow Weaver must be savoring every moment of this.

"If you must now, I'm as much a prisoner here as you are," Shadow Weaver says. "They keep me under a tight watch these days."

"Should I be flattered then, that you went out of your way to visit me?" She considers the levels of guards she must have gone through. "What happened to the guards?"

"They'll be fine by morning," Shadow Weaver says.

"So it's that kind of visit," Catra says, bracing herself. She knows Shadow Weaver isn't strong enough to fight her physically, she lost power when Catra severed her connection to the Black Garnet. Shadow Weaver's speech is the most dangerous thing about her, and Catra may have been deceived by her once, but she won't be deceived by her again.

"You've been careless," Shadow Weaver admonishes. "I always knew you were a threat to Adora's future, but I never expected you would be the reason she no longer exists."

"She still exists," Catra says defensively. "We just can't reach her."

“Like I said,” Shadow Weaver says. “Careless.”

“Adora’s going to come back,” says Catra.

“Doubtful,” replies Shadow Weaver. “With the Heart of Etheria getting in the way.”

“What do you mean? Once we balance the planet, we can create a functional portal.”

“So they didn’t tell you?” Shadow Weaver asks.

“Tell me what?” Catra asks feebly, wishing she wasn’t trapped in this room with nowhere to run.

Shadow Weaver’s gaze pierces through her. “Oh, if you’re not already aware it makes no difference now. You’re of no use to the Rebellion locked up in here, I wonder how long they’ll keep you around.”

“Probably longer than you,” Catra manages to say.

“I remember being kinder to you in the portal, you know.”

Catra feels like she could throw up. “I don’t see the point of mentioning it,” Catra says. “What happened in the portal wasn’t real. You’ve never cared about me.”

“Are you saying that none of what happened in the portal was real? Because I seem to recall Adora being quite… friendly with you. Of course, she didn’t remember the choices you made that brought her there in the first place.”

Catra bites her tongue so abruptly it bleeds. Even when Adora did remember, she still tried to save her. It didn’t work.

“Besides,” Shadow Weaver intones, “if I didn’t care about you, would I be helping you escape?”

“What?” Catra croaks. Catra’s hands are curled up on her sides, her nails scratch at her skin. “Why would you do anything to help me?” she asks.

“Because we both know that it’s best you’re not here once Adora’s pulled through.”

“So the princesses’ plan will work,” Catra says. “Entrapta’s going to balance the planet and open a portal?”

“You know I wouldn’t dare give you the specifics. I can’t have you running back to Hordak with them.”

“We both know there’s not much damage Hordak can do at present,” Catra says. She swears Shadow Weaver smiles at that, with the same manner as a snake.

“The farthest I can take you is the Whispering Woods,” Shadow Weaver warns. She crouches down to draw a rune on the ground.

“No,” Catra says. “I’m through with portals and magic. Let me walk through that door and I’ll leave.”

“If you insist,” Shadow Weaver says.

It feels almost like cheating, it’s so easy. Catra resents that this is possible only because of Shadow Weaver, but she decides to see it as a debt repaid. Besides, there’s nothing here for her in Bright Moon, and Catra’s never handled imprisonment well. She doesn’t know the next time she’ll get a chance like this.

So she runs.

Chapter End Notes

thank you for all your kind comments, and your condolences!! i deeply, deeply appreciate it.

we are officially halfway through this fic!! i'm sorry for posting this chapter a little late but i will be updating again next week

because we are finally getting adora's pov next and i've been waiting so long to share it!!

thank you for your patience!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Do you think that you are the stars, perhaps? And that I am the moon? I thought you were the moon. But I have been absent too, you know. I think I have been absent all this time."

— Naomi Alderman

The sword was always lighter in She-Ra's hands; but now it's weighed down by fear and something that feels like regret. It's not a new emotion for Adora, but she's not used to its heaviness. As she gives the sword to Angella, Adora realizes it's the last time she'll ever hold it. If Angella speaks, the humming noise surrounding her blocks it out. Everything becomes a piercing white, as if she's been swallowed by a star. Without She-Ra's magic, it's too bright for her human eyes, so she closes them. Her palms press against tears; she didn't realize she'd been crying.

*

Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods and she doesn't remember dying. What she does remember hardly makes sense: the Fright Zone disappearing, Catra falling, Catra etched in shadow—her yellow eye gone.

But Catra is *here*, perched above her; Adora's eyes meet a worried yellow and blue. There's a swell of anger and there's an ebb of relief at the sight of them. Adora can't place the dissonance, it's always been complicated with Catra, but there's a burn inside her

and she doesn't know why. Something feels off, and it's more than the fact that the two of them are in the woods. They're only cadets, this area is forbidden. Anything beyond the Fright Zone is off-limits.

“Catra?” Adora asks. “What happened?”

"You fell out of the skiff after you drove it into a tree,” Catra says without any hesitation. As if that's what really happened.

The burn licks at Adora's throat. “No,” Adora begins, but she falters. She’s had this conversation before, correcting Catra. Catra pushed Adora and Adora pushed back, seconds before Catra drove them into a tree. Catra made the first attack, she clawed Adora’s cheek, clawed her back. Catra pulled the switch.

Adora shoves Catra off her, dizzy as she stands. Her back is sore, and her head won’t stop spinning. She focuses on inhaling the scent of grass and lilacs. It’s then she realizes the earth is still, no longer shaking beneath her feet. The trees surrounding them stand tall, hushed.

"It stopped moving," Adora says.

"What stopped moving?" Catra asks.

"The ground!" Adora shouts. She remembers the way the tremors felt, how her heart lurched when—

"Great, you're brain damaged," Catra says. "Shadow Weaver's going to kill me. I knew we shouldn't have come out here, and before you give me a hard time, this was all *your* idea."

“I’m not brain damaged,” Adora protests. Perturbed, she takes Catra in: she's standing in her usual pose with a single hand resting on her hip. But instead of her feigned nonchalance, her eyes are wide, unwavering. It's unsettling, the way she feels like she's been in this exact spot before. She found something, something Catra didn’t care for. "I think I lost something in the fall. Will you help me look for it?”

“What are you talking about? You didn't even bring a weapon with you, dummy. So, can we just get going already? If we’re not back before Shadow Weaver finds out we’re missing—”

“Shadow Weaver isn’t going to find out!” Adora blurts. Saying her name out loud feels different, like she's summoning the shadows herself. Adora knows it’s best to avoid them. “And if she does… I’ll take all the blame, I promise.”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “That's never made a difference before,” she says, skeptical.

Adora can’t tell if she means the blame or the promise. Before Adora can argue, she's reminded with a pang, that she’s never been the one punished.

“Fine,” Catra says, waving both her hands up. Adora can hear the agitation in her voice. “But this is only because I think there’s a small chance you’re brain damaged and I don’t want to make it worse. What is it you’re looking for, exactly?”

“I’m not sure,” Adora admits. “But I’ll know it when I see it, trust me.”

"Helpful," Catra teases. Catra grabs her hand, and it's everything Adora can do not to jolt back. Catra’s always been warm, but her hand is cold as ice. "Lead the way."

Adora grips Catra’s hand tight anyway, and Catra follows her as she walks along the brambles, looking for something that glows. Something powerful.

Ten minutes pass before Catra asks, “Are you sure you know where you’re going?”

“How would I know?” Adora asks. “I’ve never left the Fright Zone before. You know that.” It feels like a lie, but Adora has no memory of ever leaving. She squeezes Catra’s hand tighter.

(*"Because you left me,"* Catra said, a reminder of—) But Adora would never.

"It's getting dark," Catra complains.

"You can see at night better than I can," Adora points out.

"Exactly! That's why I'm suggesting we hop back on the skiff and get out of here. You need medical attention."

"I don't need medical attention," Adora snaps. Catra stops walking, Adora lets their hands part. She rubs hers together for warmth, there's no reason Catra's hand should have been that cold. "I don't understand," Adora says, exasperated. "It's supposed to be here, I can't save us if we can't find it. This isn't how this is supposed to happen."

"This isn't how what's supposed to happen?" Catra asks. "Adora?"

There's a flash of violent white light. When Adora turns around, Catra is gone.

"Wait," Adora says, reaching out towards the spot she stood, as if she could still bring her back. "Catra!" she calls, and she runs. She doesn't stop running until she finds a clearing, revealing the stars in the night sky, like they never left. They blink down at her, almost tauntingly.

It hits Adora then, that the traversing hasn't stopped. She's alone, somewhere between the reality the sword created and the world she knows. That's what Entrapta said, anyway. *"Possibly forever,"* she had mentioned. Adora hopes not, but she doesn't regret her choice. Not if it means that she fixed things, that's what She-Ra is supposed to do, isn't she?

But she supposes she's not She-Ra anymore, or rather, she can't be She-Ra again, not without the sword. It's gone, there's not a trace of magic around her, no trace of magic within her. Adora can't sense anything, she's not even sure where in the Whispering Woods she is. She's never been good at navigating, not like Catra.

“Is this what you wanted?” Adora asks, as if Catra can still answer. How many times did Catra say she wanted to get rid of her, that she’d be better off without her? If Catra feels any remorse, it's because she didn't end Adora with her own two hands; she’s probably savoring the taste of victory, thrilled at the Rebellion’s loss.

The Rebellion—Adora never had a chance to say goodbye. Glimmer, Bow, Swift Wind. Adora hopes Angella passes along her message, she hopes they understand why she had to be the one to fix it.

*

Adora is eight and Catra teaches her how to make a paper skiff in class. As Adora struggles to fold hers, Catra throws one at Octavia, and she misses.

“Are you trying to get her other eye?” Adora jokes, but she’s secretly impressed.

“Something like that,” Catra says.

Adora is twenty and Catra turns to face her and her yellow eye is gone.

*

Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods and Glimmer sleeps next to her, snoring slightly.

Next to their dying campfire, Bow works on an arrow, adding a magnifying glass to it. Adora has seen this act countless times: Bow lost in concentration, brow narrowed as he focuses. It makes her heart heavy. She doesn't know why.

Adora sits up, putting her blanket over Glimmer.

"Oh," Bow says, brightening as she walks towards him. "You're awake! I was starting to get worried, usually you're the early riser."

"Right," she drawls. She's used to waking early; the Fright Zone never gave her a choice with their automated alarms for the first eighteen years of her life. (Save for the time she and Catra dismantled them. It only lasted two days before the technicians made them functional again.) Adora stretches her arms, unable to shake the feeling that she's lost too much time sleeping in. There's something she needs to do.

"Are you doing okay?" Bow asks, attentive as ever.

"Yeah," Adora says, frowning. "I'm fine. I just feel like I'm forgetting something."

"Hm," he says. "Well hopefully it will come back to you. Do you think it's time to wake up Glimmer? We should probably get a move on if we want to get to Plumeria by lunch."

That doesn't sound accurate, it doesn't take very long to get from Bright Moon to Plumeria, but Adora's never been the best at geography, and Bow's more familiar with the woods than she is.

"We can let her sleep a little bit longer," Adora says, but she blinks, and suddenly she's in in motion, walking between Glimmer and Bow, laughing at something Bow said. She can't remember what was so funny.

"The woods still scare me," Glimmer confesses as they march forward.

“They’re not so bad once you get used to them,” Bow says.

“That’s because you grew up in them. I grew up with nothing but bad stories about them. I’m not sure why. The woods have always been a part of Bright Moon, they never belonged to the Horde.”

“I grew up with bad stories about them too,” Adora says. Confident, she adds, “But there’s nothing to be afraid of.” There are no monsters in the woods, the mechanical spiders don’t count, they were made by the First Ones. And she’s never seen a tree move on its own. No, the most dangerous thing Adora’s ever seen in the woods has been Catra and the sudden disregard for her own safety.

(Catra laughed at her and it was harsh, unfamiliar, not the way she used to sound.)

“If you say so,” Glimmer says.

And Adora must still be exhausted because she spaces out again. When she comes to, she finds herself seated underneath the falling leaves of the Heart Blossom tree. *Autumn,* Perfuma called it. They never experienced seasons in the Horde, only the occasional toxic rainfall.

Next to Adora, Glimmer is braiding Mermista’s hair, the latter stretching across Perfuma’s handmade pillows lazily.

Perfuma holds a flower: Adora can’t remember the name. It’s white, and ends with -y. A lily maybe, or a daisy.

“He loves you,” Perfuma says, as she plucks one of its petals. Adora’s never seen anyone do this, but then again, she’s never seen a living flower till a few months ago. “He loves you not.” She repeats this until she gets to the last remaining petal. “That’s not right,” Perfuma says, and a single petal blooms again. “He loves you.”

“That’s cheating,” Glimmer says. “You can’t just grow another petal because you don’t like the result.”

“Why not?” Perfuma asks. And she hums.

“Wait, who were you doing that one for?” Mermista asks.

“Don’t be silly,” Perfuma says. “The last one was yours. I know Sea Hawk was your plus one for Princess Prom.”

“Do you have to bring that up?” Mermista deadpans.

“It’s not like any of us could forget it,” Adora teases.

“Do you know what was really unforgettable about Princess Prom?” Mermista asks, shooting Adora a smirk.

“You mean, aside from the Horde ruining it?” Glimmer asks.

“Obviously,” Mermista says. “But for someone who claims Catra is her enemy, she sure had no problem dancing with her.”

“That’s because I was trying to keep an eye on her,” Adora insists.

“Sure it does,” Mermista says. “Perfuma, make another flower for me.” Perfuma does so, and as she hands it to Mermista, she winks at Adora. As Adora glances towards Glimmer for help, she only shrugs, returning her attention to Mermista’s hair.

“She loves you,” Mermista says. “She loves you not.”

“Wait,” Adora says, shoulders tensing. “This is two days after Princess Prom, isn’t it? This isn’t what happened that day.”

The Rebellion broke apart, temporarily, mourning Entrapta, giving up on their cause. Adora hasn’t been to Plumeria since they first recruited Perfuma. She had meant to change that.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Mermista says. “Anyway. She loves you, she loves you not.”

(*"I won't let you win,"* Catra said. A promise. A curse.)

Adora is angry with Catra, Adora misses Catra. Both things are true. Both have gone on for long enough. But it doesn't matter, by opening the portal in the first place, Catra ensured that Adora will never see her again.

"I don't need a flower to tell me the answer," Adora says.

*

Adora is twelve and Catra bandages her wrist. "You need to be more careful," Catra tells her.

No.

Adora is fifteen and she's bandaging Catra's wrist. "How did this happen?" Adora asks. Catra doesn't answer.

No.

The two of them are eighteen and Catra's the one drawing blood.

*

Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods and her head is in Catra's lap. This is nothing new, Adora always wakes up near Catra. Back in the Fright Zone, Catra slept on the bunk directly above her if she didn't share Adora's. Or, on days when they were lucky, when they could get away, Catra's shoulder served as a pillow when Adora napped on the roof.

Of course even out here in uncharted territory Adora wakes up with Catra watching over her, one of her hands resting on Adora's

cheek like it belongs there. Adora would welcome the touch if her fingers didn't feel like ice.

Softly, Catra says, “You fell asleep, dummy.” As if Adora fell asleep on Catra every day.

“Sorry,” Adora says, stifling a yawn.

Catra laughs knowingly. “Go back to sleep. I’ll be here when you wake up.”

“You promise?” Adora asks, feeling a little dizzy.

“I’ll carry you back to the ship if I have to. Wouldn’t be the first time.”

“What do you mean? You’ve never carried me anywhere, not since we were kids.”

“Remember that time we defeated Tung Lashor?”

“Uh,” Adora says. She doesn't remember that fight, but that sounds correct. She and Catra make a good team.

“Exactly. You passed out in the heat and I had to carry your ass all the way out to the ship."

Adora must have fallen asleep again, because the next thing she knows, she’s in the abandoned First Ones’ ship. It’s strange to call it that, there was a name that came with it, but Adora’s forgotten. She doesn’t know why her memory is failing her.

"Home sweet home," Catra says, comfortably sitting in the pilot’s seat.

“Wait, we live here?” Adora asks, getting a better look at the ship’s interior. She knows that the last time she saw the ship, it was empty. And there was something that glowed, something that had information for her.

"Adora, are you feeling okay? We've stayed here ever since we fought Tung Lashor. Huntara says since we found it, it’s ours. Don’t you remember?”

Hearing Huntara's name hurts Adora for some reason. “I need some air,” Adora says. And as she walks outside, she gasps. Night in the Crimson Waste is beautiful. And cold. Adora forgot, Catra didn't.

“I brought you a jacket,” Catra says. It’s black leather.

“Thanks,” Adora says, accepting it graciously. She doesn’t know what happened to her red jacket, and her white sleeves aren’t enough for the desert at night.

As Adora puts it on, Catra’s gaze lingers on her, like stars over earth. Adora's breath gets caught with it. But as Catra leans forward, she’s too close; Adora’s instinct to fight kicks in. The last time Catra was this close, she didn't hesitate to strike at her—Adora remembers now, and she presses her fingers against Catra's frozen lips.

“No,” Adora says, firm. “This isn’t how—”

“What’s going on with you?” Catra asks.

“I’m not supposed to be here, none of this is right,” Adora answers, wincing as Catra takes a step back, wrapping her tail around herself.

Weakly, Catra asks, “Why not?”

“I’m mad at you.”

Catra half-laughs. “Aren’t you always mad at me?”

“Not like this,” Adora says. Catra's the reason she's here. Catra's the reason she's here stuck in a simulation, tortured by being near a version of Catra who cares about her. It feels like she's intruding on something that doesn't belong to her. The Catra she knows

wouldn't be looking at her like that. The Catra she knows would have left her in the Whispering Woods without a second thought.

She’s done it before.

Adora's temple throbs and she clutches her head. She fixed it, she knows she fixed it, and she’s still here trapped, unable to save herself.

"Hey," Catra says gently. "Talk to me. Please."

"It doesn't matter, I can't stay," Adora says. She doesn't think she'd want to, even if she had a choice. (*"This isn't real, Catra."*) Adora swallows back the words.

"Why not?"

"Can you stop acting like you care about me?" Adora snaps.

“What are you talking about? Of course I care."

“Since when?” Adora asks.

“Since always,” Catra says. “Why do you think we left the Fright Zone? Adora—”

There is a flash. Both Catra and the ship are gone, leaving Adora stranded in the desert underneath a cluster of stars.

*

“You must let go,” says Light Hope.

“Let go,” echo the stars.

“I thought I did,” says Adora.

*

Force Captain Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods on a skiff. It's parked, thankfully, but Adora doesn't remember falling asleep. And she shouldn't be alone, her squadron should be nearby.

No. She had sent Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio ahead without her. She's used to the woods, they don't scare her. She's a force captain, fear is beneath her.

When she arrives at the Fright Zone, it's dark, and Shadow Weaver is there to lecture her. But something is off. Adora's used to the Fright Zone being a place in motion: machines humming, pipes creaking, footsteps echoing. There is no smoke, there's no sound at all save for Adora's own breath and her irregular heartbeat.

"You're late, Force Captain," Shadow Weaver says. Adora tries to apologize, but it doesn't matter. Shadow Weaver continues, "But I am impressed with your success at Plumeria today."

"The Horde will be in complete charge of the Whispering Woods any day now," Adora says, automatic.

Shadow Weaver nods in approval.

Adora marches across the Fright Zone, eager to shower and sleep in her bed, she's stiff after sleeping in the cramped space of the skiff.

It's only as Adora passes the door to the backway of the locker room that she freezes. It had disappeared once, she remembers that, but it couldn't have, not when it's right in front of her. She puts her palm against it. There's the echo of a laugh in the back of her mind, but she can't place who it belonged too. Laughter has always been rare in the Fright Zone.

In the locker room, the lights are on, but it’s empty. There aren’t any clothes on the ground, there’s no sign that it’s been used.

(*“I can’t believe you like me,”* Adora said, smug and giddy.) Adora rarely jokes, and that thought sobers her up.

Adora goes to the barracks. She hasn't slept in them for a year now, not since she was promoted to Force Captain, but she feels like she's missing something. She goes to her childhood bunk. It’s still made up, blankets tucked neatly.

The wall next to it is blank. As Adora remembers what used to be there, she puts her hand over her mouth, concealing a gasp.

“Uh, Force Captain?” Lonnie asks, startling Adora. “What are you doing in here?”

“There was something I needed to check,” Adora says. "Sorry," she adds, even though the apology isn't entirely for Lonnie. She’s not sorry for leaving, not sorry for becoming She-Ra. She didn’t mean to leave Catra behind, but she had apologized for that already.

I'm sorry for what we've become, she thinks. Adora had never imagined their friendship could sever. Now she knows what Catra is capable of, and she knows what she’s capable of herself.

Adora exits the Fright Zone without looking back, walking underneath a muted purple morning sky. She’s never seen it quite like this before, she and Catra only saw the sky a deep and dusty red. It’s not all bad, these portal worlds. Adora hates the temporary memory loss, hates being confused, but she adjusts, she adapts, like she always has.

In some ways, Adora likes the quiet. There’s no world to be saved anymore, the only person at risk of danger is herself, and she’s fine. She has to be. Maybe Adora was never meant to be a hero in the first place. If she had stayed in the planet where she came from, she might never have had a destiny at all. Part of her

wishes the portal took her back to that beginning. She might have been free from She-Ra, free from everything.

Guilt eats away at her immediately. If the portal never brought her to Etheria, she never would have met Glimmer or Bow or Swift Wind. Or Catra—if this version of reality was any indicator, it was no life to have lived.

*

Adora is eight and she can't stop giggling. "Catra, what are you doing?"

"Drawing your stupid hair poof."

"It's not stupid!" Adora says. "Wow," she says, admiring Catra's drawing once it's finished. "You should draw yourself, too."

"Why?" Catra asks.

"So that we're together!" Adora says. "Like we promised!"

Adora is twenty and asks Catra what happens if they don't stay together.

*

Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods, and she's in a bed. It's soft and warm, smelling like spices and berries. She opens her eyes and gasps—she's in Razz's cottage. She's alone, but the fire is going. Adora closes her eyes and cozies up in the bed, it's been too long since she's slept in an actual bed—she doesn't want to leave it if she has any say. So she drifts back to sleep.

The next time she wakes, it's because Razz is poking her side with a broom. “Mara, Dearie, you can’t sleep in other people’s beds!” she chides.

“Sorry, Razz,” Adora says. “I didn’t mean to.” She sits up, and she remembers, which is strange. She’s lost count of all the times she’s woken up in the woods, briefly living a lie, in a world that doesn’t exist. “Razz, I’m stuck here,” Adora whispers. She’s close to crying, she thinks if she speaks any louder, the tears will escape her.

Razz peers down at her through her glasses, and then she laughs. “Don’t worry, Dearie, I’m stuck here, too. Till the pie is done. Would you like some?”

Adora’s stomach grumbles, she can’t recall the last time she ate decent food. Sometimes, when the flashes cease for a bit, she manages to find fresh berries and eat poorly cooked unseasoned fish. “Pie sounds great, Razz.”

“Good,” Razz says. “It should be done soon.”

“Let’s hope I can eat some before the light takes me away again,” Adora says. "I always end up waking up in the Whispering Woods, it doesn't matter what I do."

“Ah,” Razz says. “Has it been slowing down?”

Now that Adora thinks about it, it does feel like each reality lasts a little longer than the previous one. “Does that mean anything?” Adora asks.

“It was speeding up before, no?”

When the first portal world was made, the chaos followed her, speeding up everywhere she went. If it’s slowing down now, that must mean things are starting to settle. “Does that mean once the flashing stops, I could be back in my world?”

“How should I know? This hasn’t happened before.”

Adora considers this. “Am I in my world or yours?”

“Ah,” Razz says, and she pats Adora’s head. “Who’s to say they’re different? But maybe you should ask Swift Wind. He was looking for you earlier.”

"Wait, Swift Wind was here?” Adora asks. She runs out of the cottage. “Swift Wind!” she calls, desperate. There’s no sign of him, only the faintest pulse of his presence. It vanishes after half a second.

"Razz,” Adora says as she enters the cottage. “Are you—”

Razz is gone and the fire out. It’s only now that Adora realizes Razz’s hand was warm.

“Adora?” someone asks behind her. Adora turns around, face to face with Mara. She’s donned in blue, and her braid is loose, strands of her hair poke out. “Oh, you’re here!” There’s a tenderness in her voice, a quality missing from the hologram on the ship. "I need your help, something's wrong with Light Hope."

“What?” Adora asks, stunned. Mara is beautiful. Adora didn’t really have time to notice it before, or process what that means. But she doesn’t have time for that now, either.

"I'm worried about her," Mara explains. "She's never done this before."

“Light Hope is here?” Adora asks.

“She’s back in the castle. Come on.” Mara takes her wrist—cold and urgent—and suddenly the two of them are on the ship. Through the windows, Adora notices that even in daylight, there are stars out, and Etheria is brighter than Adora’s ever seen it.

“Adora,” says Light Hope, as stern as her robotic voice will allow her. “I told you to let go.”

“She keeps repeating herself,” Mara says. “She wouldn’t even acknowledge me.”

Adora glances back between the two of them. Light Hope shimmers in place, a glitch. “This isn’t right.”

Mara laughs good naturedly. “That’s what I’m saying. Do you think you can fix her? You have the touch.”

"No," Adora says. "Mara, the two of us have never met. And I'm so sorry, I got part of your message about the portal but—"

There is a flash, and with it, Mara is gone.

*

Catra stands before her, her skin covered with scars from where the portal touched her. "Nice place you have here," she says.

"Place?" Adora asks, confused.

"The whole world," she says. "It's yours now."

“It’s not something I conquered, Catra,” Adora says sadly. “It’s something I wandered into. No—it’s something I was forced into. Thanks for that, by the way.”

"Any time," Catra says. She doesn't smile.

“I’m still mad at you,” Adora says.

“At least it means I’m on your mind,” says Catra, as if she's never on Adora's mind.

“Why did you do it?” Adora asks.

“Why do you think?”

“That’s what I can’t figure out.”

“You’ve got all the time in the world to think about it.”

“You really can’t just tell me?”

Catra tilts her head. “Now where’s the fun in that?” Adora doesn’t say anything. “Well, what are you waiting for?” Catra asks. "If you want to fight me, have at it."

Adora presses her forehead against Catra’s instead, closing her eyes.

“I thought you were mad at me,” Catra says. Adora can tell she’s smiling as she says it.

“I miss you more than anything,” Adora says. “Don’t let it get to your head. I’m alone out here, left with memories and portal simulations and—”

"Is that all I am to you?" Catra asks. "A memory?"

"A scar," Adora answers.

She kisses Catra's forehead. And after, Catra disappears.

Chapter End Notes

the line "like stars over earth" comes from sarah diemer's *twixt* if you want a good slightly scary sapphic read, check it out!!

the idea of "this isn't how it happens," comes from tamsyn muir's *harrow the ninth*.

this chapter took me a little longer to finalize bc i was stuck on which "aus" adora gets stuck in while in the portal. there are so many potential aus for canon, some that i didn't include here i might write as one-shots if i can manage the time.

the next chapter will be both catra's and glimmer's pov, but adora's pov will return before too long!

thank you for your kind comments and patience!!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"But there's this space between us, always this space between us."

— Richard Siken

Eighteen hours until the portal goes off

The scariest thing about the Whispering Woods is the sheer size of them. Compared to Beast Island, the Whispering Woods at night aren't anything, Catra knows she can handle whatever creature crosses her path.

What she can't handle is traveling through the woods on foot. Not with her current state of exhaustion.

Catra searches for one of the skiffs she brought here. There should still be supplies with it. Of course, as Catra makes her way to the same area of the valley she had brought Micah to, there's no sign of the skiff or any of her bags. She's not surprised, the princesses must have confiscated everything. She would have done the same if she were them.

She looks back at Bright Moon—it's still beautiful, serene, even at night. The sky isn't very dark, even here it's brighter than the night sky in the Fright Zone. The waterfall glistens. For a moment, she almost considers turning back, even though she has no desire to be a prisoner of the Rebellion, leaving feels wrong. It's puzzling. She hadn't planned on escaping, but she couldn't stay near Shadow Weaver any longer, not when she was siding with the princesses. No, Catra's biggest concern is how to relay any of her recently obtained information to Hordak: that the Rebellion has everything they needed to open a portal to retrieve Adora.

Their missing piece was Scorpia, and Catra had hand delivered her.

The news would anger Hordak, but he would have a field day coming up with a new punishment for her, or he might just execute her. That would be a better fate than returning to Beast Island.

It's clear to Catra, she can't go back to Fright Zone, and she can't stay in Bright Moon; there's nothing for her there anyway, with or without Adora. Shadow Weaver was right, and that leaves a bitter feeling in her bones. For once Shadow Weaver didn't deceive her, Catra has made it to the Whispering Woods unnoticed, the princesses aren't aware she's left, and they won't know she's fled till morning. So she has to keep running.

The only place left for her is a place that shouldn't even exist, home to outlaws and ex Horde soldiers. The Crimson Waste will still be risky, but maybe Catra could learn how to stay out of trouble for once, learn how to keep herself small. There was some satisfaction in knowing she was capable of running the place, but she doesn't need that sort of power now. All it's ever done was make things worse.

Solemnly, she glances towards the woods. There are several hidden Horde bases within them, but she thinks the closest one is eight miles away. That's a hard journey to make on foot, but she doesn't have a better choice. She's not going to risk going back into Bright Moon and become a prisoner again, but she needs transport to make it to the Crimson Waste. If she finds a skiff, she can sell its parts once she gets there.

Catra decides to run, for now, to build more distance between herself and Bright Moon while she can. Even with her sight, it's harder to see in the Whispering Woods as she travels deeper. It's as she runs around a large tree that she trips over an equally large root.

“Shit,” she mutters under her breath. She stands up, brushes the dirt off her knees, and freezes once she hears a bush rustle. She can take one of those giant spiders, but she would prefer not to. She needs to save her energy, not waste it on fighting.

She extends a claw, and gasps when she spies a short, elderly woman emerge from the woods instead. Her hair is white, her face is wrinkled, but kind. The strangest thing is, she doesn't look surprised to see Catra—a Horde officer—in the woods. The woman smiles at Catra and shakes her head, as if she's in on a joke that Catra missed.

“Catra,” she chides. “Don’t you know better than to run in the woods at night?”

Catra retracts her claws, stands still. The scariest thing in the Whispering Woods isn’t their size, or the unknown monsters that lurk within them. The scariest thing in the Whispering Woods is an old woman who knows Catra’s name. She doesn’t look like much of a threat, she doesn’t even appear to be disturbed by the Horde uniform Catra wears. Still, Catra knows better than to let her guard down. “How do you know my name?” she asks.

The woman peers at her through her glasses. “Is this the first time?”

“That we met? I’m going to go with yes,” Catra says, flexing her hand, bracing herself to extend her claws again if needed. “Now if you’ll excuse me, I need to keep moving.”

“Ah,” the woman says. “And where are you going, Dearie?”

“It’s none of your business,” Catra snaps.

The woman shakes her head. “What happens to Adora’s friends is Madame Razz’s business.”

That gets Catra’s attention. “You knew Adora?” she asks weakly.

“Of course I know Adora,” Razz tells her. “She ate three pieces of my pie yesterday.”

Catra doesn't know what a pie is, but it sounds like Razz is familiar with Adora's appetite. This doesn't bring Catra any hope, though. Razz must be senile, or something. But Catra doesn’t have the heart to tell her that Adora’s gone, that it’s her fault she’s gone.

“I wouldn’t continue running on like that. Come, come. I still have pie. Stay the night.”

“I really need to keep on moving.”

Razz shakes her head. “You and Mara, always moving forward, never taking the time to breathe.”

“You knew Mara, too?” Catra asks. That shouldn’t be possible, Catra’s not sure how long ago Mara was around, and Razz is old, but she can’t be *that* old.

“Of course,” Razz says.

Catra gives her a quizzical glance. She should keep moving, get as far as she can in the woods tonight before she passes out from exhaustion. But Razz is connected to She-Ra, somehow, and Catra knows that she should find out why.

“Fine, I’ll stay the night. But you have to answer my questions.”

“Save them for the morning,” Razz says.

Catra reluctantly agrees.

Ten hours until the portal goes off

It’s Angella who delivers the news of Catra’s escape. It doesn’t surprise Glimmer, but it still alarms her. She thought she gave Catra enough security, but maybe she should have stayed up all night herself to ensure this wouldn’t happen.

“Of course Catra ran away,” Glimmer cries, aggravated. “Why would she ever make anything easy for us?” Looking at Juliet, Glimmer asks, “How did this happen? Who was on patrol last night?”

Juliet shakes her head. “We kept a guard outside her door, and two others on both ends of the hallway. There’s no way she could have escaped without anyone noticing that something was off.”

“This is Catra we’re talking about,” Glimmer says flatly. “Adora always said we shouldn’t underestimate her, and she was right. Look where we are now.” She clenches a fist, shuts her eyes, and inhales slowly, trying to collect herself. It doesn't work. “Not a single guard noticed anything was amiss?” she asks, meeting Juliet’s concerned gaze.

“There wasn’t anything strange to report, Glimmer. I'm sorry."

Angella says, "I don't understand how that's possible." She rubs her brow, parts her mouth to continue that train of thought, but she stops. Micah walks down the hall, alive and well and *here*. He's dressed in clothing similar to what Glimmer saw him wear in the portal.

"Hi Dad," Glimmer says, wishing she was talking to him under happier circumstances. “Have you heard about Catra?” she asks. He nods. “What are we supposed to do now? Catra’s clearly going to run back to the Horde and attack us before we have a chance to open another portal!”

“If I may,” Micah says, after kissing Angella's cheek. “I have a feeling that Catra might not be in such a hurry to go back to that place. Back on Beast Island, and even yesterday she seemed a little… conflicted.”

“Dad,” Glimmer says curtly, and stops herself. He only just arrived safely home to Bright Moon yesterday. She doesn’t want to fracture their relationship by arguing with him. “I know you met Catra under unusual circumstances, but I can’t believe that she’s changed that much. Yesterday Scorpia told me that Catra just wants to bring Adora back, and if that were true, she wouldn't have run away.” She sighs. “We just can’t predict what she’ll do.” To Juliet, she says, “Are you sure she’s exited the premises?”

“There’s no sign of her,” Juliet confirms. “I’ve had a team searching all morning. Catra left Bright Moon.”

“The good news is,” Glimmer says, “we still have Scorpia and Entrapta on our side. And the Sword of Protection—Catra left it behind. We can proceed as planned. Entrapta will figure out how we can open a new portal without activating the Heart. As long as we have both Entrapta and the sword, we have to use them to our advantage.”

“And you’re sure Entrapta is here to support our cause?” Angella asks.

Glimmer nods. “I know her allegiance to the Rebellion is complicated, but I can tell she feels awful creating the first portal. She says she wants to bring Adora back, and I believe her.”

“And what about the other one?” Micah asks.

“Scorpia betrayed Catra to help us. She won’t be able to remain loyal to the Horde anymore. Catra would imprison her if she tried to return, or worse. When the time comes, I’ll teleport the two of us so Scorpia can reconnect with the Black Garnet, but I have to wait for Entrapta to tell us when it's ready.”

Eight hours until the portal goes off

Catra wakes up feeling rested, for once. She can't remember the last time she got this much sleep that wasn't scorpioni venom induced.

“You are skin and bone,” Razz tells her once Catra climbs out of bed. She gestures to the table, where there’s fresh bread and several bowls of berries.

Catra shrugs and takes a seat. “Been a rough couple of weeks.” More like years. But she’s grateful for food that’s not ration bars, something that actually fills her hunger. The pie Razz offered her last night was good, but Catra was surprised to wake up this morning still hungry. She wonders if she can take some of this food with her when she leaves. She’s lost her head-start and the cover of darkness to make it to the Crimson Waste unnoticed, but she doubts the princesses will search for her here. If she can wait till nightfall, she’ll likely have a better chance at making it out of the woods and continuing her journey.

“Now," Catra says. "Last night you agreed to talking to me about Adora and Mara—”

There’s the sound of something heavy landing on the ground, and then footsteps, and then a, “Sorry I’m late, Razz, you would not believe how crazy things have been in Bright Moon lately—” and it's the flying horse.

Catra should have known. There's not a single place in Etheria that's safe from the princesses and their allies.

The horse glares at her. Catra still has no idea how he can *talk*. "What are you doing in Madame Razz’s house?”

“Me?” Catra asks. “What are *you* doing here?”

“I’m not the Horde commander who ran away from—you know what? It doesn’t matter. You need to get away from her.”

“Swift Wind,” Razz says, unbothered by the news of a Horde commander seated at her kitchen table. “Don’t be rude to my

guests!”

“But she’s evil!” Swift Wind—and that's really the dumbest name Catra's ever heard—says. “I need to protect you!”

“Evil! Hah!” Razz laughs. “Nonsense. Would an evil person sit down and have pie with me for breakfast?”

“But—”

Razz shushes him, so Catra smirks at him.

“Okay, Razz. I really, really do not want to leave you alone with her. So if you're not going to kick Catra out, I'm going to have to fly back to Bright Moon and—”

“Wait—” Catra says. She hadn’t expected that. Even if she runs now, she doesn’t have much of a shot of getting to the Horde base before they'd find her. “Please. I’m not trying to cause any more harm.”

“Sure you’re not,” Swift Wind says.

“I mean it,” she says.

“Then why did you run away?”

“I didn’t—it’s complicated,” Catra stammers. “Razz says she knows both Mara and Adora… I was just trying to figure out—”

“Razz is just like that,” Swift Wind says.

“Adora,” Razz says. For a second, Catra thinks she’s proving Swift Wind’s point, but then she adds, “Mara has a message for Adora.”

And then Catra’s heart sinks. “Yeah. Mara told Adora not to open the portal. It’s a little too late for that.”

Razz hums, and then she says, “No, that’s not all of it. I remember now.”

"What do you remember?" Catra asks.

"That I need to make another pie!" Razz jumps up with more energy than Catra expected, and runs out the front door.

“Where is she going?” Catra asks Swift Wind.

“No idea. She’s just like that.”

“I’m going to follow her,” Catra says.

Swift Wind groans. “Why can’t you just run away again?”

“Because whatever’s happening here is more important,” replies Catra. She bolts out of the cottage, curious to see where Razz will take her, and afraid that Razz is wrong.

Seven hours until the portal goes off

The war room has become Entrapta’s designated makeshift lab. It’s covered with more screens and cords and unidentifiable tools than Mara's ship; Glimmer doesn’t want to know where Entrapta got all the equipment.

There’s a loud humming sound coming from the sword, it's suspended in the air. It looks like electricity runs through it. But when Entrapta notices Glimmer, she drops her control pad, and the sword also falls onto the ground.

“Is it working?” Glimmer asks.

Entrapta uses her hair to pick up the keypad, and it starts typing for her. “Not in the way that I’ve hoped,” she explains. “I’m trying to create a forcefield for the sword, so that once we’ve channeled

all the energy we need from it with a one way access point, the forcefield will prevent the sword from releasing anything else.”

“Do you think that will work?” Glimmer asks.

“We won’t know for sure until Scorpia connects to the Black Garnet,” says Entrapta.

"How soon do you think she'll be able to try?"

Entrapta hums. "Could be today, could be tomorrow, I'm still conducting some smaller tests first."

Glimmer nods, but Entrapta doesn't see it, her focus is on getting the sword set up again. "Right," she says. This whole thing is a risk, she knows that, but if it’s the only way they can bring Adora back. "Did you get any sleep last night?"

"I didn't need it. Opening a second portal is more important than sleep!" Entrapta says, sounding earnest. Before Glimmer can voice any concern about that, Entrapta adds, "But there is one thing I'm worried about, something I can't test out in here. It's kind of big."

“And what’s that?”

“It might not be possible to turn the forcefield off without the weapon activating, which means that even once Adora gets pulled through, Adora won’t be able to access the sword without setting the Heart off.”

“You mean, she won’t be able to transform into She-Ra?” Glimmer asks, astounded. For half a second she doubts Entrapta, a situation where Adora can't turn into She-Ra sounds like a plan Catra would try to set in motion. She tries to swallow that doubt down, she knows Entrapta is sincere about trying to bring Adora back.

“I’m not sure, yet,” Entrapta says. “I was able to create the first portal with just the sword, and She-Ra’s needed to activate the

weapon, so as long as she doesn’t touch it, the weapon shouldn’t activate. The forcefield is just a precaution.”

Glimmer has to think about it. “I don’t like the idea of Adora not having access to She-Ra when she's not even here to agree to it. But if that’s the best way we can bring her back, I say we go for it. Let me know when you're ready for me to take Scorpia to the Black Garnet. I just want to get this over with."

"Affirmative," Entrapta says.

Six hours until the portal goes off

Catra and Swift Wind don't say a single word to each other, both anxious to follow Razz through the woods, which is a lot more difficult than Catra expected. Razz is fast in her old age, and it's easy to lose track of her until she starts speaking to herself again.

When Razz leads them to an old First Ones' ruin, Catra isn't that surprised. These things seem to be buried all over Etheria. The startling thing is, there's a collossal She-Ra statue, or rather, she used to be one. The statue's head is on the ground, severed from her body. There are several slashes on her face, probably the result of a sword. They look like claw marks. Catra presses her hand against them, an apology. But Catra can't figure out why a First One would have destroyed the statue.

"Razz," Swift Wind says. "What are we doing here, exactly?"

"I need to make a pie, and I need more sugar to make that happen," Razz reminds him, as if this is the obvious place to look for ingredients.

"Adora can't be in there somewhere, can she?" Catra asks, motioning towards the old building.

Behind her, Swift Wind scoffs. "If Adora were in a First Ones' ruin, if Adora was on Etheria at all, I would know. I can sense her."

“You can *what*?” Catra asks, turning back to face him.

“We have a magical bond, or at least, we used to,” Swift Wind explains, his wings sinking down. "I'm in tune with her emotions, we're stronger when we fight together, you know, the usual stuff."

"Right," Catra says, amazed by the continual insistence of magical princess bullshit.

“Found it!” Razz says excitedly, pulling up a worn down looking box that looks like it had been sitting out in the rain for centuries. It probably has.

"I'm not sure that's edible," Catra says, but Razz pays her no mind, pattering off with her prize in her hands. That's when Catra spots it: something shiny, glinting in the light of day, wedged between more sugar boxes. Catra grabs it, it's cool to the touch. It's old, but not rusted, and Catra would recognize functional First Ones' technology anywhere. "Razz, did Mara used to live here?"

"Mara would help me make pies," Razz says, confirming Catra's suspicions.

Mara's message for Adora was on a loop, it can't be a coincidence that Razz has led them here. "Swift Wind," Catra says. "This is the rest of Mara’s recording for Adora. I need you to take me back to the Fright Zone so we can play it.”

“Why would I take you back to the Fright Zone?” Swift Wind asks.

“That's where Mara's ship is, that's the only way we'll be able to hear it."

“You know that the rebellion stole the ship back two days ago, right?” Swift Wind asks, and Catra gapes. “Judging by the look on your face, I’m going to go with ‘no.’”

“What did you do with the ship?” Catra asks.

Swift Wind shoots her a glare. "It's in a lot better care than it was in your hands, trust me. We moved it to the Whispering Woods. It's not that far from Razz's cottage, actually."

“Oh,” Catra says.

“Do you still want me to take you there?”

It's not an immediate yes. Catra is closer to a Horde base out here, she could still make it to the Crimson Waste before nightfall. But the piece of First Ones’ tech in her hands is her last connection to Adora, and it might even help her escape the portal. “Yeah,” Catra says. “Show me the way.”

Five hours until the portal goes off

Glimmer teleports Bow back to Mara's ship. He insisted on going back, wanting to spend his time doing something useful. Entrapta doesn't need a lab assistant, and since he's not a princess, there's nothing he can do with a runestone to make a difference once the planet is balanced.

She tries to explain everything Entrapta said about the portal, but it's not easy, especially when she admits there's a chance Adora won't be able to access the sword again.

“I think it’s the best chance we have at opening another portal,” Glimmer says. “But it’s still risky. If it doesn’t work, well, obviously we might ruin the chance of ever opening a portal again, and

losing Adora for good, but we might lose more than her if we fail. I just don’t know what other option we have, considering we still can’t reach Light Hope.”

“I think we have to try,” Bow says.

"But it's not our sacrifice to make," Glimmer says, fixing her gaze on the toolbox in Bow's hand. "I don't want Adora to hate us—to hate me—for being the reason she can't transform into She-Ra."

"We don't know for sure that that's the case," Bow says. "It might not the decision we should be making, but we don't really have another option if we want to try to bring Adora back. I'm sure she would understand if that ends up being the cost. But maybe with Adora around again, we could finally speak to Light Hope, and she might know what to do. I trust Entrapta, and I trust your judgment.”

“I don’t know if I earn that,” Glimmer says. “I lost Catra.”

“That’s not your fault,” Bow says.

“Isn’t it? I could have ordered more security, or I could have stayed to watch her door myself. Or I could have at least talked to her, Bow! But I put it off and now she's gone.” She laughs, it sounds harsh. "Now I’ll never have the chance.”

“Something tells me she’s not gone for good,” Bow says.

Glimmer meets his eyes, they're warm, hopeful, the opposite of how Glimmer feels. “I know, but I’m tired of meeting Catra on the battlefield.”

“I hope it doesn’t come to that,” Bow says.

“That’s Catra’s choice, not mine,” Glimmer reminds him. "Anyways, I should get going. My parents and I are going to have our first ever ‘royal meeting.’ Not sure how different it’s going to be from our regular ones, but I’m excited that my dad's going to be there.”

“Me, too,” Bow says. "And good luck with the Black Garnet."

"Thanks," Glimmer says. "I'll need it."

Four hours until the portal goes off

They end up walking Razz back to her cabin, and they part ways. Razz makes Catra promise to come and visit her soon. Catra says she will, but doesn’t know when, or if it's even a good idea to stay in contact with Razz.

She grips the piece of First Ones' tech tightly, staring awkwardly at Swift Wind, unsure of what to say.

“Well,” Swift Wind says, equally reluctant and nervous. “You can get on me, I guess. It’ll be faster that way.”

Catra’s surprised by the offer, but the thought of flying makes her a little queasy. “I’d rather walk.”

And they do walk, but it’s not in silence, like Catra would prefer. After giving up on making conversation with Catra, Swift Wind has taken to singing. Their walk lasts longer than Catra expected, and she assumes that being a horse, Swift Wind doesn't think of distance the same way. As they get farther into the woods, Catra can’t take Swift Wind's singing and awful rhymes anymore. But she doesn’t yell at him to shut up, like she wants to. Instead, she asks: “Why did you believe me?”

Swift Wind says, “It’s not about me believing *you.*” Stubbornly he adds, “Which I *don't*."

"Good call," Catra says, but her ears flatten anyway.

"But Adora cared about you, and if you say you want to help her, I owe it to her to listen to you."

"You know, people keep saying she cared about me, but she had a funny way of showing it," she says.

"So did you," Swift Wind says.

A beat passes. "Yeah, I guess that's a good point."

"Remember, I was in tune with her emotions," Swift Wind says. "I know how complicated it was between you two."

"No," Catra says. "You really don't."

"I'd say I know more than most," Swift Wind says. "She thought about you a lot, even when she didn't want to talk about it. She rarely wanted to talk about it."

"Thanks, Swift Wind," Catra says. "That makes me feel a lot better."

"Sorry," Swift Wind says. "It's been hard with her gone."

"No, I'm sorry," Catra says. "I wanted to win, and when I pulled the switch, I didn't care what would happen. I didn't know Adora would have to stay behind."

Swift Wind considers this. "You're making up for it now," he tells her.

"And I'll keep trying," she tells him. Wanting to change the subject, she asks, "How exactly did the rebellion manage to steal an entire First Ones' ship from the Fright Zone?"

"Glimmer teleported it all by herself."

Catra snickers. "Right."

"No, I'm serious," Swift Wind says. "She went through this whole thing with her mom and the Moonstone and now her powers are

almost limitless.”

“Ah,” Catra says, remembering the confidence from Glimmer in the valley yesterday. “Remind me not to get in a fight with her again.”

“You don’t have to fight Glimmer, you know,” Swift Wind tells her. “You’re on the same side.”

“No one’s on my side,” Catra quickly tells him. Adora used to be, and she thought Scorpia was, but she’s wrong. She's always been on her own. The only thing she can do now is make sure that Adora's no longer on her own in the portal.

Three hours until the portal goes off

Entrapta interrupts the meeting to tell Glimmer that the sword is ready. "Well," Entrapta corrects herself, "as ready as it can be until Scorpia connects to the Black Garnet."

"And you're sure this is the best course of action, Glimmer?" Angella asks.

"It has to be," she says.

"Be careful," Micah tells her. "I still don't like the idea of only the two of you going to the Fright Zone. If you want me to go with you—"

"You can't," Glimmer says. "It's dangerous enough for me and Scorpia, but it will be safer with just the two of us. That way we can make a quick escape if we need to. Besides, Scorpia says with Shadow Weaver gone, no one will be around the Black Garnet Chamber. It should be empty aside from us."

Micah flinched at the mention of Shadow Weaver, Glimmer noticed, but he doesn't make another protest. Glimmer hugs both her parents goodbye, and then she teleports to Scorpia.

*

"You know, I don't think I'm ready for this after all," Scorpia tells Glimmer.

Perfuma had taken Scorpia to the gardens, and even now, she hasn't left her side. Perfuma nods in agreement, as if Scorpia's reluctance wasn't partly her idea. With a faux-calmness, Perfuma says, "Connecting to one's runestone is a delicate process. We shouldn't rush Scorpia if she doesn't feel ready yet."

"We don't have time, Perfuma," Glimmer says. "Catra's out there on the loose, and Adora is still missing. The only way we have a chance of bringing her back is with Scorpia's help."

"She's right," Scorpia says solemnly. "I'm a princess, technically. I can do this."

"You can do this," Glimmer affirms, giving Perfuma a look.

Perfuma sighs, but she gives in. "Of course Scorpia can do this," Perfuma says. "But you need to be careful. Every time we go to the Fright Zone—"

"Every time we go to the Fright Zone, something awful happens," Glimmer finishes for her. "But that's not the case today. Today, our mission will be successful. We're going to get Adora back."

Two hours until the portal goes off

They stand outside of the ship. Catra still has a hard time believing that it's here, but she's grateful she didn't have to trek across the Whispering Woods back to the Fright Zone for it. Her time with Hordak has expired, and she wouldn't have had a good excuse for Swift Wind's presence.

"This is the plan," Catra says. "We watch Mara's message together, then you go tell the Rebellion whatever it says."

"And what will you do?" Swift Wind asks. "Go back to the Fright Zone?"

"No," Catra says. "I'm done with the Horde, I'm done with all of this. Just knowing that you're going to help get Adora back is enough for me. I don't want any part of it." She's terrified, but she doesn't want a talking horse to know that. Swift Wind could sense Adora's emotions, she hopes he can't sense hers.

"And you think I trust you enough to believe that?" Swift Wind asks.

"I don't think you could stop me, either way."

Swift Wind sighs. "Fine. I don't agree with this, but Mara's message is more important."

They step onto the ship, and Catra freezes. She hadn't expected that anyone else would be here, but there Bow stands, holding a handful of cables.

Bow promptly drops the cables. "Catra?" he asks, and his voice cracks. "You came here with… Swift Wind?"

"Not ideal," Catra says, the same moment, Swift Wind says, "Not to worry, this is all part of my plan!"

Bow's eyes dart back and forth between them. "What's going on? Catra, you didn't run away?"

“I did,” she says. “Sort of. It's complicated. I changed my mind. I met Razz, and she told me that Mara left a message for Adora.”

Bow still looks at her skeptically. “That’s what Glimmer said, but Mara’s message is—"

“On a loop, yeah,” Catra finishes for him. She tosses the First Ones’ crystal to him. “That’s supposed to be the rest of it. I’m out of here.”

“Wait,” Bow says. “You won’t stay? Aren’t you curious about what’s on there?”

Catra is, but she can’t admit it. It would have been hard enough to make an escape to the Crimson Waste with Swift Wind alone, but she has less of a chance with Bow. “It’s not like I’ll be of much help. I already got the tech for you. You guys have the sword. You don't need me to make a portal. I did all the hard work for you."

Bow stares at her, and she stays tense. “It wasn’t your idea to run away, was it? Someone else made you leave.”

“I’ll give you one guess whose idea it was,” Catra says.

Bow frowns. “Stay and listen to Mara’s message with me and Swift Wind. And then we’ll talk.”

Catra crosses her arms. “Just like that?”

“Just like that,” Bow confirms, and he walks over to the slot for the crystal, inserts it.

Mara appears instantly, sad and blue and beautiful. But Mara isn’t alone. Catra’s heard Adora mention Light Hope in the past, but she never planned on meeting her herself. Or at least, she didn't plan on intruding on a holographic message. Light Hope looks angry, speaks coolly towards Mara, nothing about her says *ally*. There's a pause in the recording, and Catra's disappointment grows. "What are we supposed to do with that?" Catra asks.

Bow starts to reply, but he freezes as Mara's hologram appears again.

"*Adora?"* Mara's hologram asks. "*I know you're there. Razz said you would be there."* Mara steps forward, holds her hand up for Adora to touch, but Adora isn't here. Something in the action breaks Catra's heart.

"She was supposed to be here," Catra says, quiet. "I'm sorry that she's not."

But full recording or not, Mara is still a hologram. She can't hear Catra, can't respond. The message for Adora continues. She talks about the Heart of Etheria project, how She-Ra herself is the key. It makes Catra feel sick.

"Oh, no," Bow says, once the recording stops. He looks terrified.

"Entrapta's already working with the sword to create another portal, isn't she?" Catra asks. "She didn't tell me that Etheria itself was a super-weapon."

"She didn't want you to abuse it," Bow says.

Catra half-laughs. "Sounds like Entrapta. But that means we're screwed."

"It's not too late," Bow tells her. "I'll tell Glimmer—I'll show her the message. If we can't open another portal with the sword—"

"There has to be another way to bring Adora back. Even if it's another broken portal, if we can open the same one that trapped Adora in the first place—I'll stay behind. We can't risk setting off the Heart. Adora would never forgive us."

Bow nods. He pulls out a communicator. "Glimmer," he says. "Please pick up. You can't go to the Black Garnet Chamber. Scorpia can't connect to her runestone. Do you copy?"

There's no response, just the crinkling of static.

"Swift Wind, you need to fly us to Bright Moon, now!" Bow says, climbing on Swift Wind's back, looking eagerly at Catra. "Come on!" he urges.

Catra shakes her head. "Go without me, it'll be faster. Besides, I think I need to make a visit to the Crystal Castle."

"We haven't gotten Light Hope to talk to any of us since Adora left," Swift Wind says.

"But—"

"Catra, please," Bow says. "It's important that we stay together."

(*"As long as we stay together,"* Adora had once told her.) That settles it.

"Okay," Catra says shakily. "I'll come with you."

One hour until the portal goes off

Glimmer gets them to the Fright Zone easily, but even though she has the Black Garnet in mind, it takes her a few tries to get the exact location right.

“Do you feel anything?” Glimmer whispers, once they're in the runestone's chamber. “Aside from being nervous.”

Scorpia shakes her head. “Is there something specific I’m supposed to feel? What’s it like with the Moonstone?”

“I’ve always been connected to it, ever since I was born,” Glimmer says. “It kind of feels like home.”

“Yeah, this rock *definitely* doesn’t feel like home to me,” Scorpia says. The Black Garnet shines a little, as if it’s offended. “I don't

know that anywhere feels like home for me," she admits, and something about the honesty moves Glimmer. "Well, here goes nothing," Scorpia says, gently pressing her claw against the garnet.

At first there's nothing. Then, there's a spark, a bright red flash. It's powerful, Glimmer understands now why Shadow Weaver was so drawn to it, even though it was wrong for her to manipulate a runestone, to keep it from its person.

Lighting dances around Scorpia. She reaches forward, and summons a blast. It breaks the wall.

"It worked!" Scorpia says incredulously.

"It worked!" Glimmer repeats gladly. She can feel herself grow stronger, as if she's right next to the Moonstone. She glows pink, and Scorpia glows red. She hears commotion from the hall. "We'd better get back to Bright Moon before they catch us," Glimmer says.

"That sounds like a smart move," Scorpia says.

The teleport barely drains her at all. Glimmer wonders if Angella's stronger now, too. She hopes so. If she isn't, she might be able to give Angella some of her magic back. With the planet balanced, Glimmer feels stronger than she's ever felt before. But something happens, something glitches. She and Scorpia land somewhere in the middle of the Whispering Woods.

"What was that?" Scorpia asks. She stands, but nearly stumbles forward, clutching her waist in pain.

"I don't know," Glimmer says. Where the magic once lay within her, the pain spreads rapidly. "Something's wrong!"

Scorpia is covered with First Ones' writing, Glimmer looks at her hands and finds that she is, too. But she can't read it. She doesn't know if they're close enough to George and Lance's library for

them to help decipher it. She doesn't know if it matters anyway, understanding what's written won't get rid of the pain.

"What do we do?" Scorpia asks. Her voice shakes.

"I don't know," Glimmer says, with a gasp. "I don't think I can teleport us anywhere like this."

"I don't—" Scorpia heaves. "I don't expect you to."

The pain only gets worse. Glimmer half wonders if because the planet has been rebalanced, if they're all more sensitive to each other's pain somehow.

"I don't understand," Glimmer says. "It was working—we were more powerful, at first. The planet was balanced!"

Part of the ground begins to glow in large lines, the light reminds her of the way the portal was glowing. She doesn't doubt that they're First Ones' sigils, etched deeply into the ground.

"What does it mean?" Scorpia asks.

"I think, I think something is happening with the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer says. "But it shouldn't be activated—not unless She-Ra is back. We have to get back to Bright Moon and find Entrapta."

"I'm not sure I can walk like this," Scorpia admits.

Glimmer frowns. It hurts, still but she thinks she could manage, but she can't leave Scorpia alone. That wouldn't be right either.

"We'll stay together," Glimmer says slowly, processing everything. "We'll wait it out."

Suddenly everything is bright and blinding. When it settles, the pain is gone, and neither she nor Scorpia are glowing anymore.

Scorpia looks up at the sky and gasps. "What are those?" she asks.

“Stars,” Glimmer answers.

"But how?" Scorpia asks.

"It means," Glimmer whispers, "that a portal has been set off."

"Does that mean it worked? That we got Adora back?"

"I'm not sure," Glimmer says. "We won't know anything till we get back to Bright Moon."

Chapter End Notes

thank you all for your patience!!

we get more of adora's pov next chapter <3

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> y'all have waited patiently for over 50k words for catra and adora to interact... i sincerely hope it will be worth it!! <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This is the girl, here, this girl with a ruined look who touches me and whom I love."

— Jean-Paul Sartre, translated by Lloyd Alexander

When Catra wakes, her ears ring, repetitive and violent. For a moment, she thinks she's back on Beast Island, that the signals are messing with her again. Maybe she really never left, maybe Beast Island has kept her in its clutches, leaving her with nothing but delusions. Something similar happened to Micah, didn't it?

The sound of someone groaning next to her brings Catra to the present: she's not alone. Opening a single eye, she startles at the sight of Bow, lying on the floor, hard and cerulean and cold. The Crystal Castle. That's not right. They shouldn't be in here—they should be—

Catra sits up and winces, sore all over. Her head hurts as memory floods through her: riding on Swift Wind with Bow to Bright Moon where they saw First Ones' sigils glowing in the ground fire-bright, a sign of danger. After hearing the rest of Mara's message, Catra and Bow were trying to warn Glimmer and Scorpia against balancing the planet, but neither answered their communicators. By the time they got to Bright Moon, they were too late. The three of them were met with a frantic Micah and Angella, who urged them to take one of Catra's confiscated skiffs back to the Fright Zone, as fast as they could.

That was when Entrapta found them. *"The sword is gone,"* she had said, even more panicked than she was when she tried to warn Catra about setting off the first portal. Entrapta told them that before every light in her makeshift lab went off, she saw a figure—someone barely more visible than a flash of blue. When the lights came back on, the sword and the equipment Entrapta had it connected to were gone.

Catra had feared the worst, if they lost control of the sword, they couldn't prevent the Heart of Etheria from being activated.

It was Swift Wind who suggested that the blue flash was Light Hope herself. If he was right about Light Hope trying to use the sword for her own motives, it meant they still had time to retrieve it before it was too late.

Swift Wind offered to fly Bow and Catra to the Crystal Castle, and Micah was going to see if he could reach Glimmer through magic. Swift Wind brought them to the Crystal Castle quickly, and opted to stand guard outside, no doubt afraid of facing Light Hope. Upon entering, there was a blinding light reminiscent of the portal's hostility, knocking both her and Bow out.

Considering her head is still throbbing, Catra is starting to think Swift Wind made the right choice to stay outside.

"Hey," Catra says, nudging Bow awake. "You need to wake up. We still need to find the sword."

Bow groans but he rises, rubbing the back of his head. "Did you see Light Hope at all?"

"No," Catra says, frowning. If the message Mara left for Adora was any indicator, Catra's probably better off without meeting the hologram. But Catra won't be that easily discouraged, not after everything she's been through. The sword has to be here, somewhere. Catra won't let Light Hope use it.

Catra stands up first and offers Bow her hand. He accepts it.

There’s a loud thud and something that sounds like stone cracking. Catra braces herself for fighting some mechanical spiders, grateful that Bow has all of his arrows, but it’s just Swift Wind.

“Guys,” he says, looking impossibly grim for a creature with rainbow wings. “We’re too late.”

“What do you mean?” asks Bow.

“I think you need to come see for yourself,” Swift Wind says.

The two follow Swift Wind outside the castle. Catra gasps. There are stars in the sky, thousands of them, more than she ever saw in the portal. *The portal wasn't real*, she reminds herself. But this is. She supposes stars are meant to be beautiful, something to be awed at, but presently, she's terrified.

"Those aren’t supposed to be here,” she says.

“No,” Bow agrees, mournful. “The stars are meant to be here, but we're not.”

Catra tries to process that, but she fails, having no clue what Bow means. “What are you talking about?”

“It means Glimmer’s plan worked. The planet’s balanced, which means portals are functional again. Light Hope didn’t take the sword to activate the weapon, she took it so she could make a portal big enough for us to leave Despondos. Etheria was never supposed to be there in the first place.”

Catra’s heart sinks. “It means Prime is that much closer to us,” she says. *And Adora still hasn’t been found*, she keeps the thought to herself, though she doesn’t doubt Bow’s worries are identical.

Bow looks towards Swift Wind hopefully. “Can you sense Adora at all?”

Swift Wind shakes his head. “The sword’s in there,” he says, tilting his head toward the castle. “But there’s no sign of Adora.”

“So Light Hope’s going to hide the sword from us,” Catra grumbles to herself.

Bow meets her eyes. “We’ll retrieve it together. But we’ll need help from the princesses. According to Entrapta, they should collectively be stronger now that the planet is balanced.”

“Great,” Catra says. As if Glimmer’s newfound powers weren’t bad enough. She can't imagine what it's going to look like if all the princesses are that much more powerful.

Bow gives her a look, hiding a smile, as if he knows what she’s thinking. “Let’s go back to Bright Moon. We can reconvene with Glimmer, if she's back. If she's not..."

"We'll get her back from the Fright Zone," Catra finishes for him. "If the rest of the Horde's army is on their way now, that's the last place she needs to be."

Bow offers a grateful smile. "Swift Wind, can you get us back to Bright Moon?"

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The flight back to Bright Moon is urgent, leaving Catra's stomach flipping, desperate not to let go of Swift Wind's mane. Things go from bad to worse when Swift Wind stops dead in his tracks and nearly drops them.

"Something's wrong," Swift Wind says drifting towards the ground at an alarming pace.

Catra and Bow each ask Swift Wind what he's doing, but he makes no reply. As soon as Swift Wind's hooves touch the earth, Catra wastes no time scrambling off of his back. It's settled. She's never going to sit on a flying, talking horse again, even in emergencies.

"Swiftie?" Bow asks, as Swift Wind keeps prancing around in circles, looking lost.

"I thought I could sense Adora," he says, shaken.

It’s still hard concept for Catra to grasp: a stupid, sacred, She-Ra bond. But if he's sincere, if that kind of magic can help them find her, Catra has no choice but to accept it. Her heart pounds in her chest as she watches Swift Wind pace back and forth, standing tall and alert, his horn almost glowing.

“Are you sure about this?” asks Bow, sounding as anxious as Catra feels.

“I think... I think she really might be here somewhere in the woods, I promise! I'm not making this up!”

“Let me guess,” Catra drawls, even though this is good news. “You can’t point out an exact location.”

“That doesn’t matter,” Swift Wind insists, stamping a hoof on the ground. “Not if she’s actually here. Now be quiet, I need to concentrate.”

Catra supposes that he’s right, and wonders if whatever he senses could really be Adora. She stands still, arms crossed, her tail swishing back and forth involuntarily. Magic bond powers should work faster.

“One of us needs to go to Bright Moon,” Bow whispers. “Explain what’s going on, find out what happened to Glimmer and Scorpia. The other one needs to stay with Swift Wind.”

“You’re right,” Catra agrees, strained. Both options are unfavorable to her, she wants to see Adora for herself, just to really make sure she’s back, but she doesn't know how Adora will react to seeing her. On the other hand, if she goes to Bright Moon, she’s likely to be ambushed. Catra doesn’t want to test out Entrapta's theory about the princesses becoming stronger by herself. Still, she supposes that’s better than startling an unsuspecting Adora. “You should stay, I’ll go.”

“Oh,” Bow says, surprised. “I’d figure you rather stay for Adora’s sake.”

Catra rubs her sleeved arm out of habit. It hasn’t ached at all today, and it almost feels normal now. “It’s for Adora’s sake that I can’t. If she’s really back—I shouldn’t be the first person she sees.”

Bow frowns, but he nods. “You’re probably right.”

Coming from Bow, that stings, but Catra knows it’s the only choice. “I’ll tell everyone that Swift Wind sensed her. You keep your communicator on in case Glimmer reaches out to you, that way she can find you.” *If she’s back*, Catra thinks but keeps to herself, remembering the sigils in the ground. Whatever Glimmer and Scorpia did to balance the planet worked, but that doesn’t mean that either of them are safe from harm.

*

The second Catra arrives at Bright Moon's castle, she’s escorted to the war room. It’s there she’s met with the king and queen, Sea Hawk, and every princess, including both Glimmer and Scorpia. They've not been stranded in the Fright Zone like Catra had feared.

“You’re back,” Catra manages to get out, before Glimmer points her scepter towards her and firmly asks, “Where’s Bow?”

The sternness doesn’t surprise Catra, neither does the glare in Glimmer’s eye. Catra swallows. Her hands aren’t bound at the moment, but Catra wouldn’t be surprised if that was Glimmer’s next acting command, even if there’s no point. Catra couldn’t take every princess in a fight at once, even without their new powers from the planet’s balance. Catra knows when she’s outnumbered. Her only saving grace is the fact that Shadow Weaver isn't anywhere in sight.

“Bow is with Swift Wind in the Whispering Woods,” Catra answers.

Before Catra can say anything else, Glimmer cuts in, “Why? Entrapta said you were supposed to go to the Crystal Castle to look for the sword. I see that you don’t have it.”

“We couldn’t find it,” Catra says. “Light Hope hasn’t shown herself to anyone.”

“Then why did you come back alone? Why hasn’t Bow been answering his communicator?”

“You’ve been trying to reach him?” Catra asks. The gaze of every single princess, no doubt ready to fight, makes her sweat. “Bow’s been trying to reach you, too. Maybe something’s wrong with the communicators because of the portal.”

“That is possible,” Entrapta chimes in. “I haven’t had time to see if the frequencies on Etheria changed at all.”

Glimmer gives Entrapta a curious look, before her anger towards Catra resurfaces again. “Why didn’t Bow come back with you? What did you do to him?”

“Look." Catra raises her hands in the air, slowly. “Think whatever you want of me, but I didn’t betray you. Swift Wind said he sensed Adora—out there in the woods—and Bow stayed with him

to help look for her. I only came back to pass along the message."

"I think she might be telling the truth," Perfuma says quietly.

"You're saying that when the new portal opened, it brought Adora back?" Mermista asks.

"It seems that way," Catra says, meeting Glimmer's eyes, hoping she believes her.

"Escort Catra back to her room," Glimmer orders.

Catra doesn't protest. It wouldn't do any good. As she leaves the room, Catra listens to Glimmer carry out a new plan, splitting people up into teams to search the Whispering Woods. Adora isn't the only one they're searching for, it's obvious Glimmer didn't believe the truth about Bow and Swift Wind. She supposes she hasn't earned Glimmer's trust yet, and she won't fight her on that.

At this point, the only thing Catra has any energy for is the slightest bit of hope that Adora has returned to them alive.

Adora is eighteen, admiring the Kingdom of Snow's beauty. It's a little more chilly than Adora would like, but that's on her for not wearing a dress with longer sleeves. No one else seems to have a problem with the palace, but then again, Adora supposes everyone has been here before, and they're more used to wearing formalwear than she is. Glimmer and Bow are slow dancing together, near Spinny and Netossa, while Mermista and Sea Hawk are dancing in the corner. It almost makes Adora laugh, everyone knows about their relationship, there's no sense in hiding it, but Adora isn't exactly one to talk.

"Hey, Adora," Catra says from behind her. "Did no one ask you to dance with them?"

Adora turns to face her, raising an eyebrow. She suppresses the smile that always threatens to expose itself when Catra is around. She can't help it, it's always been like that. Adora shrugs. "It's fine. I'm not really one for dancing, you know that."

"That's a shame."

"It is," Adora replies. She waits. It's Catra who gives in first by smiling.

"Come on. I found a place."

A light flashes, and they're there, standing at the base of a gorgeous frosty cliff.

"You want me to climb up there?"

"The view's worth it." Catra flashes a grin. "I promise."

"If you say so," Adora says.

There's another bright flash, but it doesn't leave Adora with a headache this time, so she doesn't mention it to Catra. She doesn't want to worry her.

Wordlessly, Catra extends her hand, and Adora takes it. Like everything else in the Kingdom of Snows, Catra's hand is cold. Adora hopes it warms up eventually.

The music from the ballroom is faint out here, but still loud enough for the two of them to sway along to it. At some point, the song fades into silence, and Catra takes the opportunity to take off her jacket and drape it around Adora's shoulders.

"You were looking cold," she explains.

"Thanks," Adora says.

There's frost on Catra's eyelashes. Adora nearly comments on it, but Catra leans closer, her eyes fluttering shut. Something about it shatters everything.

"This isn't how it happened," Adora says.

Catra merely tilts her head. "Do you wish it was?"

"I don't know," Adora answers, wishing this simulation would end already so she doesn't have to find out.

*

Adora wakes up in the Whispering Woods, used to the ache in her back by now. She's given up on getting a good night's sleep in an actual bed. In some ways, the ache reminds her of when she stayed transformed as She-Ra for too long, stumbling around in her feet, overestimating her strength once she became herself again. Adora sits, takes off her dirty grass-stained boots and rubs the soles of her feet. She had a dream of being She-Ra recently, tall, confident, triumphant, unafraid. Everything Adora can no longer be. She can't transform into She-Ra without the sword, and she's not been able to guess how long she's been in the portal. The simulations distort any concrete sense of time.

You chose this, a small voice reminds her. She gave the sword to Angella willingly, knowing what it cost.

A new voice echoes in her mind. This time, it belongs to Light Hope, steely and cool. *"Adora, you must find the sword. Use it, and you will be able to escape the portal and return to your friends."*

A few simulations ago—three, five, ten? Adora's lost track—Adora followed Mara to her ship. Mara said Light Hope was malfunctioning, but Light Hope seemed to be the only thing in any

of these realities to make sense. Adora still doesn't know if that was the real Light Hope, unsure if Light Hope's programming was strong enough to help She-Ra at this distance. But unlike any version of Bow, Glimmer, and even Catra, Light Hope knew something was wrong, knew that Adora didn't belong here.

"I have used all my remaining strength to bring the sword inside the portal," Light Hope said. *"Use it, and you can still be the hero Etheria needs."*

The logic behind it made sense, the sword was the key to creating the portal in the first place, it might be enough to bring her back to Etheria.

So far, Adora's had no luck. She's searched for the sword within every passing simulation. By this point, she knows the woods better than anyone, maybe even more than Madame Razz. But the sword is never in the woods, never in the Crystal Castle, never anywhere.

Presently, Adora knows she's not far from Razz's cottage. That knowledge should bring her some relief, but most times, Razz isn't even there. Sometimes the only thing the cottage is good for is shelter from rain, offering her a nice place to sleep. When Razz, or rather, a simulated version of Razz is there, she only speaks to Adora in the same confusing riddles that didn't make sense in her own reality. These days, Adora has been too tired to question her any further, not bothering to put the pieces together. Last time, Razz kept insisting she had just seen Catra, that Catra was looking for her. The thought hurt, but not as bad as the fact that Catra has never met Razz, and she doesn't care about Adora enough to look for her now.

Adora opts to move forward instead, to make her way to the Crystal Castle. Even if the sword's not there, she would just be relieved to see Light Hope again. Light Hope might be able to guide Adora to the sword, wherever it is. It's the only chance she has.

As soon as Adora stands, her stomach growls. She ignores it. She always wakes up hungry in the woods, no matter how many berries she eats or the number of fish she catches. She devours the pies Razz makes her, but she's not sure if they're real, if they're enough to sustain her. But she's alive, somehow, so she presses on.

It's nighttime in the Whispering Woods. Late, from the looks of it.

Adora had gotten used to waking up at odd hours a long time ago, but the strange thing is the sheer amount of stars above her, decorating the Crystal Castle which shines underneath them. This isn't the first time she's come across stars in a simulation. Stars will appear to her, auspicious enough, but indifferent towards her suffering. Adora doesn't waste any more of her time looking at them. They'll disappear and reappear and it will have no impact on Adora's mission to find the sword, to go back to the starless world she loves.

But she's starting to believe she'll never come across the sword here, that she'll be trapped between two worlds for the rest of her life.

And then, there's the sound of a hundred tiny bells. Adora stands still—the sound used to be a comfort to her, but now, all it does is remind her who she's left behind.

When Glimmer emerges, she's holding Bow's hand, touching Swift Wind's side with the other. They gape at the sight of her, eyes wide, as if Adora is the ghost, not the other way around.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks, her voice shaking. "Is that really you?"

Adora doesn't know how to answer that. Most versions of her friends she comes across aren't surprised to see her, and she doesn't know how to tell Glimmer, even a fake version of her, that it should be Adora asking Glimmer that question instead.

"You made it out of the portal?" Bow asks, a confirmation of the portal's latest insidious trick. Of course the portal wants her to

believe she’s home. Light Hope warned her that the portal doesn’t want Adora to leave, that it will try to keep her in it, not allow her to get close to the sword.

Adora laughs roughly in response, laughs until it hurts, laughs until she’s sure she’s not about to cry from frustration. Her friends only stare at her, startled, unsure. “Yeah, I totally made it out of the portal. Isn't it obvious?” Adora points up. “The stars are here, I’m here. Everything makes sense.”

Glimmer and Bow give each other a worried look, while Swift Wind kicks at the ground. Adora almost feels bad. If these were her real friends, she wouldn't give them this exasperation. But they aren’t real, this isn’t real, so it doesn’t matter.

“Now if you’ll excuse me,” Adora says, “I need to enter the Crystal Castle. Alone.”

Swift Wind whinnies nervously. “I don’t think that’s such a good idea."

“And why not?” Adora asks, keeping her guard up. In the portal, there have been times Catra where had been friend, not foe, it's possible for the reverse to happen with her friends. “It’s not like I’ve never done that before.”

It’s Bow who tries next. “Adora, it really is us. You’re back, you’re home.”

Adora wants to believe him. She’s been dreaming of nothing more, and she suspects the portal knows that. Adora eyes Glimmer a little more carefully. It’s not the first time she’s seen Glimmer wearing different clothes—once she woke up and was dragged to another version of Princess Prom—but this outfit seems different, as if it’s something Glimmer would actually wear. The portal, Adora suspects, is getting far too convincing. “I want to believe that, but I need to keep moving. You know, so I can actually find the real you.”

Glimmer says, “Adora, please! I can explain everything. Another portal did go off—we were able to balance Etheria! Scorpia connected to the Black Garnet and it set off—it set off the new portal. I know it’s a lot to take in, but Etheria moved. We’re not in Despondos anymore. That’s why there are stars again.”

Adora coughs into her fist to stop the upcoming laughing fit. “That’s good, that’s new. Probably the most realistic simulation yet. But it's not good enough.”

“Please,” Bow says. “I know this is a lot to process—“

“No, you wouldn’t!” Adora snaps. “You wouldn’t know, so please don’t try. Please leave me alone.” Bow looks hurt, rightfully so. But Adora has to shake it off. “I’m sorry, Bow. But this isn't personal.”

“Adora,” Glimmer says, voice low. “I don’t want to get in your way, but I can’t let you go in the Crystal Castle. Please come back with us back to Bright Moon.”

“I’m not going with you.” The words sound strange leaving her mouth, they remind her of someone else.

“You don’t have a choice,” Glimmer says, sterner than Adora remembers.

Since Catra was brought back to her room, she's heard nothing save for the echo of her own heartbeat, pounding rapidly within her chest like a caged thing. Either Swift Wind was right, and Adora is out there in the woods, or was wrong, and Adora is still gone. Catra doesn't know how she'll cope if Swift Wind was mistaken, and Catra doesn't know how she'll handle knowing that Adora really has been found. Is that why everything is so quiet—are all the princesses still searching for Adora? Or has she been

found already? Brought back to Bright Moon, their lost hero, now found?

Catra paces back and forth in her room. There hasn't been a guard change, no quiet whispering for Catra to do her best to eavesdrop. And outside the window, there's been nothing but starlight shining back at her, and the outline of She-Ra's statue.

An hour passes, and then another.

Still no guard change, still no word.

Eventually, Catra lies down on her bed, but she doesn't sleep. She can't sleep, not until she knows whether or not Swift Wind really sensed Adora. She rests her eyes and tries to picture it: a world where Adora has returned unscathed.

The sound of footsteps makes her right ear twitch. They stop right outside the door, hesitant. Catra waits for the door to open before she opens her eyes, landing on a grimacing Glimmer.

Glimmer is alone, which is a bad sign. Glimmer isn't smiling, which is even worse. If Adora had been found she wouldn't look so grim —unless it was only Adora's body that had been found.

“Sorry if I woke you,” Glimmer says quietly.

Catra sits up, clenches the sheets with her hands. “I wasn’t sleeping," she replies. She inhales and stands up, so she's taller than Glimmer, if only by an inch. She eyes her warily.

Glimmer meets her eyes equally cautious, almost guiltily. “Has anyone… has anyone talked to you?”

Since you locked me up again? Catra wants to ask. Instead, she shakes her head. "Did you find her?"

There's a pause, a stillness, and then a slight smile. "Yeah, we found her, Adora's back in Bright Moon. She's asleep."

Catra's legs give out, and she sits on the bed. She exhales heavily before saying, "Oh." Swift Wind was right. Adora is here. Adora is *here*. "So she's okay?"

Gently, Glimmer says, “Physically, it seems so. We’re going to have our physicians give her an exam tomorrow.” Glimmer steps closer, and that's when Catra notices the blooming bruise on Glimmer's face. "Adora didn't... she refused to come to Bright Moon willingly. She tried to fight me, but it didn't go well. We had to use a sleep spell on her."

Catra narrows her eyes. "Why did she try to fight *you*?" If Adora thought Glimmer wasn't on her side, well, Catra doubts she'd be able to get through to her.

"Can I sit down?" Glimmer asks.

Catra shrugs. "It's your prison," she points out.

Glimmer doesn't take the bait, but she sits down next to Catra anyway. "As far as we can tell, Adora's just really disoriented. It must have been a shock for her, leaving the portal world and re-entering ours so abruptly. As a consequence, I don't think Adora thinks any of this is real. She kept acting like we didn't know her."

Catra tries to process that. She remembers the way the Crystal Castle exposed them to all sorts of projections. The Crystal Castle was First Ones' tech, and the portal was created through the power of First Ones' tech, both of them malicious. “It was already hard to tell what was real and what wasn’t, back in the portal,” she says. “If Adora’s been there this whole time… maybe Adora can’t believe she’s here because the portal brought her back to Bright Moon more than once.” Catra rubs her arm. "Maybe our reality is back to normal, has been this whole time, but hers might never have stopped. It makes sense she'd be confused.”

“We’re going to have to be careful with her," Glimmer says in response.

“We?” Catra asks. Her face stiffens, trying to mask her nervousness.

"We," Glimmer repeats, her voice firm. "I know we have our differences, and I'm sorry I didn't believe you when you said Bow was with Swift Wind looking for Adora. Bow told me everything that happened, that you came back to help and tried to stop me from balancing Etheria. Which is why..." Glimmer pauses to meet Catra's eye. "Which is why I'm going to dismiss your guards." She shifts in her seat, clearly still trying to grapple with her decision. "As soon as I leave, you’ll be free to go—wherever, I guess. But I would like you to stay. Now that we’re out of Despondos, the Rebellion could really use your help if the Horde army is on its way.”

Too shocked to say anything, Catra stands up and walks over to the window, looking at the She-Ra statue still standing tall in the distance. She didn't expect to be invited to join the Rebellion, by Glimmer, no less. "If you want me to help you, you must be desperate."

"We are," Glimmer says, and her voice wavers as she says, "Adora can't transform into She-Ra anymore—not without the sword. Even if she has time to recover—"

"The Rebellion no longer has access to their most powerful weapon." Catra turns to face Glimmer now, annoyed and afraid. "The Horde army is on their way, it's not a matter of if, it's only a matter of when. As long as I'm still here in Bright Moon, I can't help you. I need to get back to the Fright Zone and find out what Hordak's planning. He wasn't expecting Prime to show up before Etheria was fully conquered."

"Wait," Glimmer says. "You want to go back to the Fright Zone? Under cover?"

At this, Catra has to smile. "You don't trust me." Glimmer's sudden silence confirms this. "I'm not offended. You'd be an idiot to trust me, but you don't have a choice."

“Okay,” Glimmer says shakily. “You've already proven to us that you want to make up for what you did. The choice to stay with us or leave is yours, even if that means going back to the Fright Zone for intel. But stay with us another day, please. Tell us everything you can, and I'll personally teleport you to the Fright Zone."

"I stay, tell you all I know, and you'll take me back?"

"You have my word," Glimmer says.

Catra has had enough of princesses and their promises, but she's tired. "Okay. It's a deal, then."

Adora is fifteen in the Fright Zone, standing outside, looking at their rooftop from the ground. Everything is slick after the morning’s toxic rainfall, so Catra tests it out first, being the better climber. She makes it look easy. Catra makes everything look easy, effortless.

Adora grows impatient, the building is clearly not that slippery, so she climbs up as well.

“What are you doing?” Catra asks. “Climb back down! It was hard for me to get this far, I don’t want you breaking your neck trying to get to the dumb roof.”

But it’s not a dumb roof, and they both know it.

"I've made it this far!" Adora insists.

"Climb back down, please!"

The word please from Catra is rare, but Adora can tell she means it, so she steps back down, slowly. She nearly loses her footing, but she catches herself just in time.

Adora is nineteen and Catra lets herself fall through the portal on purpose.

*

Adora wakes up and for the first time, she’s not shivering somewhere in the Whispering Woods. She’s warm all over, covered in blankets. It’s not even just the warmth, it’s the comfort that she savors; there’s no ache in her back, no grass pressing into her hair. She opens her eyes, surprised by the daylight entering her Bright Moon bedroom. It feels fake, like the light filtering past her curtains isn’t real.

It probably isn’t. But the warmth is real, as far as Adora can tell. She lies there for a moment, waiting for the portal to glitch, waiting for the white flash to emerge, taking her back to a different glimpse of reality. But it doesn’t, not yet.

She does what she can to assess her surroundings—it looks like her room, without any obvious difference. As far as she can tell, she’s alone. She glares at the door to her room. She was brought here to Bright Moon against her will, Glimmer knocked her out. If her bedroom door isn’t guarded, the hallway certainly is. Adora knows better than to trust the people in this simulation, so she decides to escape from her balcony instead. It’s not easy, but it will be doable, and she can make it to the Crystal Castle on foot from here.

She won't waste any time, not when she's already been bound within the portal for weeks, if not months.

Adora wobbles on her feet when she first stands up—weak, fatigued. Her head spins and she closes her eyes. She can't remember the last time she ate. It doesn't matter. She can find food once she leaves Bright Moon.

She squints as she approaches her balcony. Was Bright Moon always this bright, or is it just the portal warping her perception? Her eyes struggle to adjust, but she pushes forward.

As soon as she swings one leg over the balcony's ledge, she’s greeted with a gust of wind big enough to push her back. She falls onto her marble bedroom floor gracelessly.

“Ow,” Adora says, rubbing the side of her head. “What was that?” She gets herself back up and leans over the balcony, scanning the area until her eyes meet Spinnerella’s.

“I’m sorry,” Spinny calls out to her. “But I can’t let you escape that easily.”

“Of course,” Adora mutters to herself. It makes sense they’d keep someone from the Rebellion stationed outside. She startles at the sound of someone knocking. “What do you want?”

“It’s just me,” says Glimmer. Not Glimmer, Adora corrects herself. The person standing outside her door isn't real, she's only another projection that the portal created. Adora knows that, she just needs to keep reminding herself.

"Like I said, what do you want?"

Glimmer teleports in. "I was just checking on you."

"You mean, you realized I tried to escape and wanted to make sure your plan was working okay?"

"Adora," Glimmer says. “Spinnerella is out there for your own protection, that's all. I don't want to keep you locked in here."

"Then don't," Adora says.

Glimmer is still, silent for a moment. "You know I can't do that. Not yet. Adora, I promise you won't have to stay in here for that much longer, but—"

"Give me one good reason I should believe you. You kidnapped me and trapped me in here!"

"You tried to fight me and Bow! Were you going to fight Swift Wind next?"

"If he tried to get in my way, then yes."

"Get in the way of what?" Glimmer asks, but Adora won't answer her. The sword is in the Crystal Castle, and Glimmer refused to let Adora near it. The portal won't let her near it, but that will change, soon.

"It doesn't matter," Adora says.

"Adora," Glimmer says. Her eyes are wide and a little wet. "You really are back home, I promise."

"I want to believe you," Adora finds herself saying, before remembering her resolve. "But I can't." Her stomach growls, loud enough for a small smile to tug at Glimmer's lips.

"I'll be right back." Glimmer vanishes, and reappears within seconds, along with a big cart of food. It's filled with Adora's favorite breakfast food and notes—of love and wishes, no doubt. Adora won't read the notes, and she doesn't want to touch the food, but her stomach says otherwise. "I'll give you some privacy," Glimmer adds, before she teleports out of the room again.

As soon as Glimmer disappears, Adora digs in. As a necessity only, of course. Adora's going to need her strength before she figures out how to make another escape attempt.

It's not as easy as Adora thought it would be, getting rid of this version of Glimmer. Not long after Adora had her fill of food,

Glimmer returned, undoubtedly to keep a close eye on her. She's been prattling on about how her father is alive—he's been on Beast Island this whole time, which Adora knows is impossible. Beast Island was known to be home to all sorts of monsters, razor teeth and razor claws. There's no way Micah could have survived out there for over a decade in any reality.

Eventually, Glimmer decides to put her focus on Adora. "Well, that's basically everything that's happened here. Can I ask what it was like being in the portal?"

Cold, lonely, illusory. Wherever Adora went, something was wrong. The same way something is wrong now, only Adora is having a hard time placing it. “I don’t want to talk about it,” Adora says.

“Yeah, of course,” Glimmer replies understandingly. “But if you want to talk about it, I'm here. So is Bow, Swift Wind, Catra—anyone really. We've all missed you.” Glimmer sounds sincere—she always does, in these realities. That’s what makes it so much harder.

“How… how long have I been gone?”

“A little more than two months,” Glimmer answers.

Adora shuts her eyes, trying to see if that adds up. It’s been impossible to tell. Ever since the portal went off, Adora’s had no concrete way to measure time. Even now, she can’t tell. It’s not real, but oh, how badly part of her wants it to be. To be out of the portal, with everyone she cares about on the same side of the war.

"Wait," Adora says. "Did you say Catra was here?"

"It's complicated," Glimmer says. "Like it always was with Catra, so that's nothing new."

"Nothing new," Adora repeats. "Right."

Light Hope had told her to let go once, and in the portal, she reminded Adora of how she failed to let go. Adora tried. Her dreams stopped revolving around Catra, and in most of these simulated realities, Catra’s been nowhere to be found. But now she’s here, and Adora has no desire to face her. "I need some rest," she lies, hoping she sounds convincing. What she needs is to get out of here.

"Oh," Glimmer says. "Of course."

A knock comes later, from Bow most likely, considering it's quieter, tentative. But if Adora's not permitted to leave the room, she's not going to permit anyone else to enter. She has until nightfall to come up with a good escape plan, one that will actually work.

It was Glimmer's idea for Catra to be involved in their meeting early that afternoon. Catra was reluctant to agree to it—true, she's no longer a prisoner of Bright Moon, but the looks Mermista keeps throwing her way say otherwise. Not that Catra blames her. At least Mermista acknowledges her presence in the room—for the past ten minutes, Scorpia's been avoiding looking in Catra's direction. Seated between Frosta and Perfuma at the table, Scorpia actually looks like she could belong here. She's a princess, after all. And the way Frosta and Perfuma smile back at her make it look like they know her, like she’s one of them.

Catra leaves herself with plenty of distance from the table, leaning against the wall. It only does so much to stop the stares from the princesses, but at least no one has spoken to her yet, not even Swift Wind.

Finally, Glimmer teleports into the room with Bow at her side.

"How's Adora?" Swift Wind asks.

Aside from Glimmer, no one has said a word to Adora since last night. Apparently Adora has refused to see both Bow and Swift Wind, which Catra has a hard time believing. If Adora refuses to see the people from the Rebellion she was closest to, it means she definitely won't want to see Catra before she slinks back to the Fright Zone, lying to Hordak to gather all the information she can. If she begs hard enough, Hordak might listen. Catra can't dwell on the alternative.

"She's okay," Glimmer says unconvincingly, avoiding Catra's eyes.

"Wait," Frosta says. "Adora's not joining us?"

"Adora needs a bit more time to get adjusted to being back," Bow explains.

It's not a good enough answer for Frosta. "But Prime's on his way!"

Bow tries to speak, but Mermista cuts him off. “You’re telling me Adora’s still locked in her room while Catra is joining us for our war meeting?” Mermista snaps. "How does that make sense?"

"Catra says she's here to help and I believe her," Glimmer says. She raises her hand up to stop the noise that erupts from the rest of the princesses. "Adora's not here for the meeting right now because... because she doesn't believe she's really back in our reality. Throwing her in the middle of this *mess* isn't going to do her any good."

"That and the fact she doesn't want to see anyone," Bow mutters to himself, sounding hurt.

Quizzical glances are exchanged between everyone. Only now does Scorpia glance at Catra, concern etched on her face, but it doesn't last long.

“Guys,” Bow says, over everyone's whispers. “Obviously this isn’t ideal. But until Adora realizes that she’s back, that she’s safe—”

“Are any of us really safe?” Catra asks. "When the rest of the Horde army comes through, what's your plan?"

"We don't have one," Glimmer says. "And that's why we need you. So please, tell us everything you can."

*

Catra does her best, but Bright Moon and its neighboring kingdoms are severely underprepared for Prime and his army. Many of the smaller villages are still recovering from the attacks that she led, so she does everything she can to rectify it.

Members of the Rebellion come and go, some take turns to keep an eye on Adora, others leave for ten minutes and come back with an insane amount of sugary food, and a guy comes back smelling suspiciously of smoke wearing a shit-eating grin. Catra overhears him tell Mermista that he needed to set something on fire to "cope," which results with a huge eye roll followed by a smile. Catra recognizes that smile, and she can't help but smile a bit herself. When Mermista accidentally makes eye contact with her, both their smiles dissipate, and they each pretend it didn't happen.

Eventually, everyone else leaves the war room until only Catra, Bow, and Glimmer are left. There isn't anything else they can do tonight.

"Are you still planning on leaving tomorrow?" Glimmer asks, once they finally call it quits.

Catra nods. "If you're still willing to teleport me back to the Fright Zone."

"I am. It's best if we do it early."

The implication is clear: the other princesses would put up a fight if they knew what Catra's plan consists of. They wouldn't trust her, even though she has nothing to gain from siding with the Horde anymore.

The three of them part, or rather, Catra goes down a different corridor from Glimmer and Bow. She wonders if they're going to the same place. It must be nice to have someone like that. It's been a long time since Catra did.

Bright Moon’s halls are quiet at night. No doubt that helped Shadow Weaver sneak around, she likely mastered silence before she mastered her shadow magic. But even at night, the darkness isn’t really that dark, the light from the moons keeps everything a lovely purple. Its dreaminess is about to give Catra a headache.

Catra follows the corridor to the right, and then she freezes. Adora is awake, standing right there in front of her, walking in the opposite direction. Even from this distance, she can tell Adora lost weight. She looks almost frail, and a pit forms in Catra's stomach. Frail isn't a word Catra ever expected to associate with Adora. Even when they were children, Adora always had enough to eat, never falling into a scrawny frame like Catra did.

Catra ducks behind the corner quickly, just in case Adora notices she's not alone and turns around. Adora’s not supposed to be out—her chambers have been guarded all day for a reason. Catra doesn't know how Adora snuck out in this state, but it's clear her mission is to leave Bright Moon, and that can't happen, not under Catra's watch.

Catra has a good hunch where Adora’s headed. She has time now to find Glimmer, or to find a guard, or anyone else whose goals have recently aligned with Catra's. But if they didn’t stop Adora before, they might still have a hard time now.

So Catra seeks Adora out on her own.

*

It's as Catra had anticipated, Adora enters the Whispering Woods without once looking back. Catra shakes her head in disappointment. It's the same recklessness Adora displayed in their practice fights with the Horde. Adora was never cautious enough, never suspected that anyone could sneak up on her, even though Catra was always able to, catching her by surprise. Adora dismissed it each time, saying that it was fine, because Catra was on her team anyway. Look where that got her.

Starlight—something Catra is still getting used to—seeps down between branches, making Adora almost glow. It's been so long since Catra's seen her, she's still having a difficult time believing that this really is Adora. Maybe it won't be real till she looks her in the eye. Maybe it won't be real at all. Catra could blink, and Adora could vanish into thin air—a shadow apparition, or a magic trick, to test Catra's true loyalty.

But Adora doesn't vanish. Adora is *here*, standing twenty feet in front of her, very determinedly walking towards the Crystal Castle. Bright Moon's security wasn't enough to hold her, and Catra decides she made the right decision to stay for one more day. The Rebellion could have lost Adora so easily on their own, it's incredible they made it this far, incredible Catra hasn't already defeated them by this point.

She waits until they're farther in the Whispering Woods to speak, watches as that blonde ponytail bobs back and forth, before saying, "Hey, Adora."

Adora got lucky she made it out of Bright Moon's castle unnoticed, even luckier that she made it into the Whispering Woods without

disturbing anyone. She’s close to the sword now, she can tell. This reality might not be real, but the sword certainly is. It calls to her—beckoning, loud, certain as her own heartbeat. Her pace quickens, the sooner she finds the sword, the sooner she can leave the portal, the sooner she'll be *home*.

That's all she cares about now. No more simulations, no more white flashes, no more gaps in time. Light Hope promised her as much, that her destiny as She-Ra was far from over. It was a relief, at first. There's a small, secret part of Adora whose guilt eats at her—she'll miss the quiet, she'll miss not being needed, not playing the hero, as Catra would have put it. But going back to her Etheria is more important, and so is helping her friends.

Adora walks on, one-track minded. It's been so long since she's held her sword, so long since she's pledged herself to Grayskull, that she worries the sword will reject her, despite what Light Hope had said.

It's lost in thought that Adora nearly stumbles over a tree root. She catches herself, only enjoying her steady balance for a few seconds until a voice calls out from behind her: “Hey, Adora.”

Adora plants her feet firmly to the ground. She knows that voice, that phrase, the way it would greet her on a bright day or taunt her at her lowest. The way it used to make her cheeks heat up, leaving her feeling warm in the frigidity of the Fright Zone.

She holds her breath and refuses to turn around. It's possible she imagined Catra's voice, it was barely louder than the sound of the wind blowing. It’s been some time since she’s been in a simulation with Catra in it. If she keeps walking forward, maybe she won’t have to face a projected version of Catra. Maybe she can just keep walking and never admit to anyone that this happened.

“What are you doing out here in the woods?” Catra asks.

So much for leaving it up to imagination. Adora's hands itch for the sword she doesn't have, the sword she's trying to find, itch for

any excuse she has not to face Catra. Slowly, she starts walking forward, and it's not enough.

This was how all the simulations started, wasn't it? Adora on a mission, with Catra in the woods. Catra standing beneath starlight, Catra searching for the sword, Catra saying her name as if it was the simplest thing. Adora doesn't have time for it anymore.

Catra, however, has other plans. "You're really going to pretend I'm not here, huh? When has that ever worked for you?"

Adora knows that Catra could easily catch up to her, but she doesn't. Still, her voice isn't that far away, and for whatever reason, she chooses to walk the same slow pace as Adora, several feet behind her. Adora gives in. “Can you just leave me alone, please? This really isn’t any of your concern.” What she wouldn't give for a portal flash right now, even if it meant starting in the Whispering Woods all over again. It wouldn't be ideal, but at least it would mean this version of Catra wouldn't be around to bother her.

But Catra has a tendency not to listen to Adora, regardless of their reality. “Actually, anything that might happen to you is my concern. I—I’m working with the princesses now, and they say you’re not supposed to leave Bright Moon.”

Adora scoffs. She didn't buy it when Glimmer mentioned it earlier, and she doesn't buy it now. “You expect me to believe *you’re* with the Rebellion now? Just like that?”

“A lot’s changed since you left.”

“And whose fault is that?” Adora retorts.

“Is that why you won’t look at me?” Catra asks. A beat passes, and Adora can hear Catra step closer. “Or are you afraid that if you look at me, you’ll realize you really are outside of the portal?”

Adora’s never been one to turn down a challenge, so she turns to face Catra, unflinching. Catra steps closer, and Adora does her best to stare her down. Catra's donning all black clothing, and her hair is unlike any style Catra's ever worn. It's smooth, straight. It doesn't look like Catra, and Adora panics for a moment, forgetting if Catra's right eye really was the blue one, if it was possible she had forgotten, or if the portal is just messing with her memory again. *It doesn't matter*, she tells herself. *This isn't her.*

Catra's gaze is wide, expectant. Adora doesn't think she's strong enough to turn around and go back to ignoring her, and she doubts Catra would let her. “Your hair is different,” is all Adora says. She still doesn’t know what to make of it, the Catra she knew wasn't interested in changing it. “And I’m not afraid to leave the portal, I’m afraid that I *won’t* be able to leave. If you keep me here, I’ll be trapped.”

Catra’s eyes soften at that. “Adora, I’m not trying to trap you. I just want to make sure that you’re safe.” She sounds just like Glimmer, she doesn't sound like Catra at all.

“You never cared before,” Adora tells her. Catra winces, and in reaction, Adora shuts her eyes. “Correction: after a certain point, you stopped caring.” Her eyes open, meet Catra’s—whose eyes do match Adora’s memory of them, she can remember now. “But the sword is calling me. It’s here, and I need to find it. It's important. Please, Catra. You have to let me go.”

Catra shakes her head. “I can’t let you do that.”

Adora rolls her eyes. The sooner she can get out of this reality, the better.

“I’m serious," Catra continues. "The planet is balanced, Adora. I still don't know exactly what that means but I do know that the sword activates a weapon. If you find it, it will lead to nothing but destruction. That’s what Mara said.”

Nothing about this sways Adora. The real Catra doesn’t even know how important Mara is, she interrupted her message without a second thought. “You, of all people, are really going to try to stop me? You set off the portal not caring about what would happen, why do you care if I set off another weapon? That doesn’t make any sense.”

Catra takes a step back, now, and grips her arm, the strange one with the sleeve. "I made a mistake," she says.

"Which time?" Adora asks.

"I've made a lot of mistakes. I'm sorry I—"

"A reality where you actually apologize to me, that's new." The words bite, but Catra merely frowns.

"So Glimmer was telling the truth. You really don't believe you're back."

"You really think I wouldn’t be able to tell the second I got out of the portal?" Adora asks. “You have no idea what I’ve been through.”

“How can I,” Catra begins, “if you’re just going to leave me behind again?” Adora stills. Catra looks surprised at her words, but she doesn’t take them back.

“I didn’t pull the switch,” Adora says.

“But you still chose to stay in the portal."

“I didn’t have a choice. No thanks to you.”

“You’re right,” Catra says, after enough time has passed for Adora to wonder if the Catra simulation had malfunctioned, if the portal has started to glitch. “I’m sorry,” she adds. A whisper. That’s two apologies from Catra in one night.

“If you mean it, you’ll let me go.”

“That’s not fair.”

“I mean it, Catra. Let me go. I need to make it to the Crystal Castle, and I need to make it there alone.”

When Adora used to speak bravely, her entire body was full of conviction. There was a light in her eyes, electric and unwavering. Catra always noticed it, even when they were enemies. Especially when they were enemies. Catra had seen it enough times in the Fright Zone to prepare to be on the other side of it when Adora faced her.

Adora’s gaze now is hollow, the bags under her eyes are heavy. There's no spark, no anything. Adora doesn't need to go into the Crystal Castle, she needs to sleep. Was she able to get any sleep in the portal, or was she just skipping through time in a daze? Either way, it's Catra's fault Adora is going through this. All Catra can do is try to make things better for her, and Adora accessing the sword will only make everything even worse.

"I won't let you go in there," Catra tells her. "And I would prefer not to fight you." Catra would win, but it would be an unfair fight, and she doesn't want Adora to strain herself if she doesn't have to.

Adora just stays still, but she doesn’t look at Catra as if she’s searching for something good in her anymore, she’s looking at her like she's waiting for Catra to disappear, as if she's really not here. It's unsettling. "The Catra I know would love the chance to fight me."

It hits Catra like a slap, even though she knows there's truth in those words, but she doesn't have it in her to fight anymore. Catra extends her claws anyway. “Do you really think you’re in any shape to fight me?” Adora parts her mouth open, and shuts it. “I

heard you try to fight Glimmer, when she first found you. You and I both know if you’re not a match for her, you’re not a match for me.”

Adora sighs. “Why are you making this so difficult for me?” Catra doesn't have an answer for that. “Catra,” Adora says. “I need to keep on moving. I hope you understand.”

“Look,” Catra begins, averting her eyes. “I already lost you—when you were in the portal—I thought that you were gone for good, Adora.”

“You already lost me before the portal, Catra. You tried to get rid of me once.”

“I know." Catra shuts her eyes, remembering the way Adora had begged her for help. How she chose to toss the sword into the abyss like it was nothing and walked away. Catra doesn't know how to rank all of her mistakes, but she knows that's one of the biggest ones she's ever made. "That was before," she says weakly.

"Before what?" Adora asks.

Catra opens her eyes, landing on that all too familiar pale-blue she thought she'd never see again. *Before I knew what losing you really meant*, she thinks. "Before... everything. Before I set off the portal, before I switched sides. If I could undo it, I would."

Adora's eyebrows are pinched together as she tries to sort it out. "You mean it," she says, almost as a question.

"Of course I mean it. Adora, I don't care what happens to me. You can have me isolated on Beast Island, you can execute me yourself in Bright Moon, or send me back to Hordak as a traitor. But if you go into the Crystal Castle—if you get your hands on that sword, everyone you do care about will get hurt. I can’t let you do that.”

Something in Adora's expression changes, looking at Catra as if what happens to her does make a difference to Adora, though Catra can't fathom why. Then Adora leans even closer, her mouth inches away. Then she does something Catra doesn’t expect: she kisses her forehead as if marking a blessing. Like its forgiveness itself.

Adora shakes her head suddenly. “This isn’t real Catra,” she says, the same words she told her in the portal, only, it was Catra who didn't want to accept the truth.

Catra merely blinks, stunned. “I’m sorry,” she whispers. “I’m so sorry that it is.”

But Adora's gaze is empty now, and it hits Catra that it doesn't matter what she says, Adora still won't believe that this is real.

"I do believe that you're sorry," Adora says.

"But you don't believe I'm the real me." Catra reaches for Adora’s shoulder, and Adora flinches at the contact. “Sorry,” Catra mutters, losing track of how many times she's said it tonight, but Adora doesn’t step away. “Let me take you back to Bright Moon. Even if I’m not real, what’s the harm in coming with me?” Catra asks. “Just for tonight.”

Adora’s mouth twists.

“We don't have to go back to the castle," Catra clarifies. “Just let me show you the rest of Mara's message, and then you can decide for yourself."

"How do you have the rest of Mara's message? It was stuck on a loop when I first played it."

"I found the missing piece, it was near a First One's ruin. Madame Razz led me to it."

That catches Adora's attention. "You know Razz?"

"I do now."

Adora bites her lip, considering her options. “Where is the ship? Is it still in the Waste?”

“It’s here in Bright Moon. I, uh, I had a team who helped me take it to the Fright Zone but Glimmer stole it back.”

Adora laughs. “All by herself?”

“Basically,” Catra says.

"And if I come with you to listen to the rest of Mara's message and still don't buy it, you'll let me go?"

"Adora."

"Promise me, Catra."

"Really?" Adora doesn't give in, so Catra sighs. "Sure, I promise." She only hopes she's not making a mistake.

Chapter End Notes

thank you to everyone who had nominated this fic for the she-ra fic awards on twitter way back when, i was very touched considering adora and catra hadn't even interacted in the present yet!!

thank you all for supporting this fic, the final two chapters should both be posted sooner than later. i cannot believe i've spent over a year now working on this project, and i appreciate all of you for reading it and still being here <33

prime isn't here yet because it's my au and i said so. glimmer's pov will return next chapter, but i figured catra and adora can take over this chapter, as a treat

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The big miracle is your power to raise the dead. Love does that. And it raised me, too. How alive do you think I was—before?”

— Kurt Vonnegut

After Adora hears the entirety of Mara’s message for the first time, her mouth goes dry. Everything is silent, save for the anxious way Catra paces back and forth behind her.

Mara’s hologram had held her hand out for Adora knowingly; a calling, a gesture, but Adora stood too far away to touch the empty air. Mara had backed away anyway, too wounded to stand upright for very long.

Adora's heart thrums, her blood flows through her unsteadily. Either this is real and important, or it isn't. Light Hope has always told Adora the truth, or she hasn't. Adora is really back on Etheria, or she's trapped in another simulation. Catra regrets setting off the portal, or she doesn't.

Catra's pacing stops. Adora turns around, eyeing the way Catra has leaned against the ship's wall, almost casually. But she's nervous. Adora waits for Catra to say something, she was always good at figuring something to say, no matter how intense the situation, even if it wasn’t the right thing to say. But Catra offers her no such solace, likely waiting for Adora to speak first. So she does: “Play it again.”

Catra doesn’t argue, she simply presses the button and Mara’s ship is filled with the echo of Mara’s voice once more.

"Again," Adora says when it's over. She stands closer to where the hologram appears, but she doesn't extend her hand towards Mara, scared that if she does, that will make this real.

The fourth time Adora listens to the message, she keeps her eyes shut.

Eventually, Adora loses count of how many times she listens to Mara's warning. She had taken over the controls, pressing the start button repeatedly until she had gotten her nauseating fill. As she powers down the ship entirely, she realizes that Catra has left her alone, which suits her just fine. Adora doesn't know what to think, what to believe. Her pulse hasn't slowed down since she first heard Mara's words. She knows Light Hope was never the warmest, but she meant well, didn't she? She promised Adora she would help her escape the portal, but what if that was another trick orchestrated by the portal? Or worse, what if it wasn't a trick, what if the portal didn't care? What every simulation was purely random?

"Have you heard enough?" Catra asks her. Adora startles, she hadn't noticed that Catra came back. "Or did that thing finally stop working? I know it's old."

Adora can't wrap her mind around everything she's seen, everything she's heard. So she doesn't try to. She can't accept the possibility that the hologram is real, that the real Light Hope lied to her and Mara both.

Earlier, she had agreed to listen to the hologram to decide for herself whether or not she would return to Bright Moon willingly. She needs answers, and going to the Crystal Castle is the only way she can hope to get some. But her head hurts, and she suddenly feels fatigued, weighed down by every possibility, all of them dire.

And on the off chance that this is real, that Light Hope is her enemy, Adora needs time before she faces her.

“I want to go back home, now,” Adora says, taking in Catra’s crestfallen gaze.

“That’s all you have to say?” Catra asks. Adora doesn’t understand why Catra looks so sad at her disinterest, she’s never cared about anything She-Ra related before.

Adora avoids her eyes and nods. “That’s all.”

Surprisingly, Catra doesn’t push the issue. “Okay.”

They walk back to Bright Moon in silence, the same way they came. Catra offers no snide remarks, asks no questions, so Adora doesn’t say anything either. Their shoulders nearly touch, and their footfall is in sync. Adora could break it at any moment, but she doesn’t.

It’s when they approach the castle that Catra stops walking. “How did you get past the guards in the first place?”

Adora should know better than to answer, should know better than to return to Bright Moon as little more than a prisoner. If she gives Catra her secret, she’ll have a hard time sneaking out again. But if Catra wants to help her, this version of Catra who is desperate to make things right, she’ll stay true to her promise and take Adora to the Crystal Castle when she’s ready.

“Was it Shadow Weaver?” Catra asks.

The question surprises Adora, she can’t imagine Shadow Weaver trying to help her do anything. “What? Why would Shadow Weaver help me?”

“Because she’s here in Bright Moon.” Catra frowns. “You didn’t know?”

“How could I have known when I’m not even allowed to leave my room?” Adora snaps. “What is Shadow Weaver doing in Bright Moon?”

“I was hoping *you* could tell *me*! I know she joined your ranks right before I—right before the first portal went off. She teamed up with Sparkles and Arrow Boy and infiltrated the Fright Zone to try and get you back.”

Adora lets that sit in. She had forgotten that Shadow Weaver left the Fright Zone to find her. “I was never okay with her being in Bright Moon. I didn’t know she was still here.”

Catra's expression shifts slightly, into something like relief, maybe, but Adora isn't sure. “Shadow Weaver's a prisoner, but we both know that doesn’t mean she’s incapable of leaving. Especially not with Bright Moon's security lacking.”

“Even so," Adora begins, trying to wrap her head around the question, "why did you think Shadow Weaver would come to me?”

Catra shrugs, but it’s weighted, dismissive.

"Catra?"

"She helped *me* escape," Catra says quietly. "Said it would be better if I wasn't around once the princesses brought you back. I believed her."

"But you came back."

"I ran into Razz and saw Mara's recording. That's when I knew I had to stop Glimmer from balancing the planet."

Adora wants to inquire more, but Catra looks more tired than Adora's ever seen her. "Well, Shadow Weaver didn't help me. I only made it out because Juliet takes smoke breaks when she thinks no one is around to notice.”

“Good to know,” Catra says.

Sneaking back into her room alone would be difficult, but Catra makes it easier. As they scale the side of the castle, Adora’s briefly

reminded of all the times they'd climb up to the roof in the Fright Zone.

"You look tired," Adora eventually says, once they're back in her room, standing six feet apart.

"Yeah? Well, it's been a rough few weeks." Catra pauses, before quickly adding, "I mean, I know it was worse for you. In there."

Catra still hasn't asked her for any details of the portal, and Adora's grateful for it.

"It wasn't all bad," Adora finds herself saying. Catra gives her skeptical glance. "I wasn't—it was disorienting, sure—but I wasn't in danger or anything. Just lost. And in the realities with you—" Catra shrinks back. "Sometimes we weren't even enemies, like now."

"You saw me in there? In the portal? Aside from—" Catra stops herself. "Outside of the fight?"

Adora nods, nervous now. "Outside of the fight." The version of Catra who escaped the Horde with her, the version of Catra as she once knew her, right before she found the sword. "A few times," Adora admits. She doesn't know how to tell Catra, even a strangely sincere portal version of Catra, that there were times when they weren't involved in the war at all, that it was just the two of them. It's not easy, having a soft spot for worlds that Adora knows don't exist outside of the portal, but those were always her favorite. Catra was everything to her before she found the sword, and the portal knows that.

But Catra doesn't press for more information. "I missed you," she says. "And I really am sorry."

"I know," Adora says. She doesn't know if this is real, if this is the same Catra she grew up with, the same Catra she used to fight. But she believes that this version of Catra is honest. "Does this mean you live in Bright Moon now?"

At this, Catra laughs, and Adora finds that her breath is caught in her throat. It’s been so long since she’s heard Catra laugh like that. “I don’t think there’s any reality where I actually live in Bright Moon. Until yesterday, I had a ‘prison cell.’ Now it’s where I sleep willingly. I’m not sure what comes next.”

Adora laughs lightly in agreement. “Bright Moon’s never really had the whole prison cell thing down.” Adora scans the room. Her bed is only big enough for one person, thanks to her request the first week she started living here, but there are enough spare blankets and pillows to make something work. “Do you want to stay here tonight? With me?”

Catra tilts her head. “Are you sure that’s a good idea?”

“Why wouldn’t it be?” There are probably a hundred reasons Adora should retract her offer, but she chooses not to. She could wake up in another reality tomorrow, or in half an hour. But for now, she can pretend this is real. She can pretend there really is a world where Catra switched sides and is fighting alongside her in Bright Moon, even if it will hurt when it dissipates into nothing, leaving Adora with more memories of Catra that never really happened.

“Do you really think this is such a good idea?” Bow asks Glimmer.

It’s early in the morning. Daylight hasn't flooded her room yet, so it's earlier than Glimmer would prefer to wake. But Catra kept her word yesterday, offering as much information about fighting Prime as she was able to. Things aren't ideal for the Rebellion, but with Catra's strategies, they might have a chance. So Glimmer will keep her promise, even if the idea of returning to the Fright Zone, however briefly, fills her with dread. The first time she was there she was brought as a prisoner, the second time she was unable to

prevent Catra from setting off the portal, and the third time, well, created a different catastrophic portal making Etheria more vulnerable than ever. She can only hope this time it will go well.

Glimmer knows that Bow is right to be nervous about this mission. Glimmer saw the way Catra tried to conceal her fear yesterday, focusing on practical tactics, the seemingly endless weapon supply the Horde is equipped with and their storage unit locations, and their current selection of bots. As Catra spoke, Glimmer could see the fear in her eyes. If Catra of all people is afraid of something, Glimmer would be stupid not to take it seriously.

Bow has bags under his eyes—he took one of the night shifts last night outside Adora's room, and he hasn't gotten any sleep since then. He'll probably pass out as soon as she leaves. Selfishly, she wishes she didn't have to go, that the two of them could get a few hours of sleep together.

"Do you have a better alternative?" Glimmer asks, knowing that isn't a fair question. She doesn't doubt that if Bow had teleportation powers, he would offer to take Catra to the Fright Zone in her stead.

"No, but—"

"I was able to get me and Scorpia in and out of the Fright Zone without anyone from the Horde knowing. And I'm not planning on staying for as long this time, I just need to drop off Catra. It will take less than five minutes."

"I know," Bow says, frowning. "And I trust you, and I trust Catra." He pauses to make a face. "That didn't sound right."

"It didn't," Glimmer agrees, laughing softly. She had a hard time believing Bow when she found him in the Whispering Woods the day before yesterday, when his story was the same as Catra's. She knows Bow wouldn't lie to her, but it was still shocking to find him and Swift Wind searching for Adora, realizing that Catra was

indeed telling the truth. That there was a chance Adora was really home after all, only to find a disoriented Adora not long after.

Bow takes her hand and squeezes it. “Should I come with you?”

Glimmer’s touched by the offer, but as strong as her powers are now, she’ll still be able to travel back and forth faster with only one person, not two. She shakes her head. “I’ll be fine. You get some rest, you deserve it. I’ll go find Catra and come back before anyone notices we’ve left.” She kisses Bow’s cheek, and teleports away before she can see his reaction.

*

Glimmer knocks on Catra's door, but after waiting a minute and teleporting in, she finds that her quarters are empty. It catches her off guard. She supposes she and Catra have not technically designated a place for them to meet, but it’s still surprising not to see her here.

Glimmer then teleports out into the hallway, but there’s no one. After visiting the kitchens, the garden, the war room, and Catra’s quarters one more time for good measure, she starts to panic.

In her own bedroom, Bow is snoring softly. Glimmer hates to wake him, but it’s urgent. “Bow,” she says gently, not wanting to alarm him.

Bow offers her a sleepy smile. “Hey, you’re already back!” But his smile fades as he registers the concern on her face. “Did you even leave?”

Glimmer shakes her head. “I can’t find Catra anywhere, and I can’t exactly go to the Fright Zone without her. I don’t understand, Bow. If she wanted to betray us, she would have done so sooner, wouldn’t she? If she wanted to capture me in the

Fright Zone, she could have had a quick and easy ride over there. But to disappear in the middle of the night? Something seems off." But Bow doesn't look panicked, or even remotely surprised by this news. This perplexes Glimmer. "Bow?"

Bow gives her a thoughtful look. "Have you checked Adora's room?" he asks, softly.

"No, I didn't." It hasn't occurred to Glimmer to look there. She hates to admit it, but it makes sense. "Come with me?" she asks.

Bow nods. Glimmer teleports them both outside Adora's room, where they encounter Mermista on guard duty.

"Anything unusual?" Glimmer asks.

"She hasn't tried to leave, yet," Mermista answers. "Not sure about who's keeping watch out back, though."

"We would have heard about something by now," Glimmer assures her. *Wouldn't we?* she thinks. She knocks on Adora's door. There's no answer.

Glimmer teleports in by herself, and has to cover her mouth to conceal her gasp.

The floor by Adora's bed is covered with blankets and pillows that Adora never used, but Glimmer had insisted Adora keep in her drawers just in case she ever changed her mind and wanted to sleep with something more comfortable than "Horde standard."

Adora is half-buried under blankets, sleeping more restfully than Glimmer has ever seen.

But Catra is right by her side, sleeping just as soundly. Glimmer's never seen Catra look so vulnerable, or so relaxed. Glimmer doesn't have the heart to wake either of them up.

Glimmer teleports out, ignores Mermista's questions, grabs Bow, and teleports them both back into Glimmer's room.

“Catra and Adora are both in there together—asleep,” she says, frantic. Saying it out loud does little to soothe her. “I don’t get it. I mean, I get—” she makes motions with her hands that Bow seems to understand.

“There’s a lot we don’t know,” he says.

“But Adora would barely talk to *me*! She wouldn’t even see *you*, or *Swift Wind*, but *Catra* manages to have a sleepover with her? How did she pull that off?” Bow shrugs, making Glimmer frown. Bow was the most hurt yesterday when Adora refused to see anyone aside from Glimmer, and now he’s relatively calm about this? “How come you’re not as upset about this as I am?”

“Because,” Bow intones, “Adora’s been through a lot. More than either of us know. And now she’s really home, but she’s still lost. If Catra was someone she felt like she could put her guard down around, I think that’s a good thing.”

“But Catra—” Glimmer drops it. It’s still unsettling, but Bow has a point. “Okay,” she concedes. “If Catra can help Adora, that’s the important thing.”

Bow yawns, and Glimmer smiles. “Go back to sleep,” she tells him.

“Will you join me?”

Glimmer’s too awake now, too anxious to figure out what’s going to happen next to sleep, but she can’t resist the hopeful look in Bow’s eye.

“Yeah, okay,” she says.

*

Glimmer doesn’t know how long she slept for, but she knows that when she wakes next, she’s alone, with a note on the pillow next to her that Bow left. The note is really nothing more than a doodle, something that would probably be impossible for anyone to decipher aside from her. She smiles.

Glimmer teleports out of her room only to find Catra standing outside her door.

“If it’s all right with you,” Catra begins, “I’d like to wait another day before going back to the Fright Zone.”

“Of course,” Glimmer says. She doesn’t press for details, doesn’t admit to seeing what she saw earlier this morning. Under any other circumstance, Glimmer would demand an explanation, but for now, Catra and Adora can have that secret. Especially when Glimmer's still trying to accept it.

“I caught Adora walking alone in Bright Moon last night,” Catra says.

Glimmer goes still. So much for all their efforts to keep an eye on Adora.

“She was trying to escape to the Crystal Castle, but I was able to convince her to come back, after promising to show her the rest of Mara’s message.”

“I’m grateful you found her,” Glimmer says, and she means it. If Catra wasn’t around, Adora probably would have succeeded. “How is she?”

“She’s still confused. As far as I can tell, Adora doesn’t know what to make of Mara’s warning. But she chose not to go back to the Crystal Castle, she chose to come back to Bright Moon.”

“That’s a relief.”

“If she escapes again, I’m not sure I’ll be able to stop her.”

Glimmer considers that. “I understand. But Adora won't be escaping again."

Catra shrugs. "Tell Juliet to cool it with the smoke breaks."

Ah, that explains it. She makes a mental note to have a good talk with Juliet before she's stationed outside Adora's door again. "I will."

When Catra was waiting for Glimmer to wake up, she had seen Bow walk out of her room. Thankfully, she kept herself hidden, sparing her from dealing with Bow lying about the real reason he was in there.

But Glimmer, Catra found out the hard way, is serious about her beauty sleep. While Catra was waiting, she got hungry. She had made it halfway to the kitchens when she spotted Scorpia and Perfuma being awfully giggly that early in the morning.

So Catra went back to the hallway outside of Glimmer's room, waiting with an empty stomach.

Now that it's been decided Catra won't go back to the Fright Zone until tomorrow, her relief has been overridden with hunger.

Glimmer seems to notice her agitation. "Have you eaten yet?" Catra shakes her head, and Glimmer smiles. "Come have breakfast with me. You deserve a proper Bright Moon breakfast."

The offer feels a little forced, and Catra's not sure what a proper Bright Moon breakfast entails, but she agrees.

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Breakfast with Glimmer comprises of Glimmer, Micah, Angella, Castaspella, and Juliet, and an insane amount of food for six people during war time. Catra mostly stays quiet after an awkward instance of asking what "aunts" are, but the food is so good she doesn't waste her time by talking. Besides, Glimmer's parents and her aunt still have years of catching up to do, full of laughter and inside jokes and annoyed groans from Glimmer, who hasn't stopped smiling all morning.

Glimmer, though, picks up on Catra's disquiet. "You know, you're the reason we're all here together," she whispers.

Catra supposes that's true, even though this happiness wasn't her intention when she rescued Micah from Beast Island. She nods in response. She takes another bite from the pastry she was eating and sets it down.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asks.

And how can Catra answer that question honestly? War with Prime is imminent, and Adora still doesn't believe she's really back on Etheria. In order to save her, Catra will have to leave her, and she's not ready to say goodbye, not so soon. Especially when Adora has been insisting that Catra stays by her side.

"I'm fine," Catra lies, and promptly excuses herself. She doesn't belong at this table. She doesn't belong in Bright Moon.

Beautiful, bright, seemingly untouched by war, Bright Moon.

Catra wanders the gardens by daylight, appreciating how green and alive they are. The Horde could have benefited greatly with gardens of their own. It's not far from the gardens that Catra spots Scorpia, looking uncharacteristically bored.

She's not far from Adora's balcony, Catra realizes, stationed for watch duty.

Catra debates approaching her, but Scorpia notices Catra's presence before she can make up her mind. Catra tenses instinctively, but Scorpia’s shoulders fall slightly, and she motions for Catra to come over.

So Catra does.

“Adora’s awake now,” Scorpia tells her.

“Oh.” That’s probably a good thing, but Catra can’t tell by the way Scorpia is looking at her.

“Swift Wind is in there with her, and she’s been laughing. Laughing—can you believe it? I can hear it all the way out here, and I’ve got to admit it, it’s been getting a little annoying.”

Catra decides not to comment on that. Adora never slept in like that in the Fright Zone, and yesterday, Adora refused to see anyone aside from Glimmer.

“But it’s a good thing that she’s willing to see her friends again,” Scorpia continues. “Right?”

“I hope so." Catra rubs her sleeved arm out of habit, it hasn't ached or felt frozen over at all today. "Look, Scorpia, I just wanted to say… I’m sorry. For everything I did. And I understand why you chose to side with the princesses. I really do. You made the right call.”

Scorpia doesn't look so sure. “Even though by doing so I helped open a second portal?”

“You couldn’t have known that would happen,” Catra assures her. “Bow and I were too late to stop you. I know you wouldn’t have connected with the Black Garnet if you knew the consequences."

Scorpia gives her a half-smile. “I appreciate hearing that, Wild Cat. Seriously. Things have been nice in Bright Moon. And I hope they continue to stay that way.”

“I hope so, too.”

“Are you staying?” Scorpia asks.

That's not the question Catra expected. “In Bright Moon?”

“You know, you’ve been helping the princesses strategize... and I assumed that since Adora is back... you wouldn't be so inclined to leave."

“I’m not sure if I'm staying,” Catra admits. “Even if the war was over, I'm not sure it'd be the right call.”

“Where else would you go?"

Of course Catra's thought about her options: the Whispering Woods, the Crimson Waste, whatever is left of the Fright Zone. But she stops the thoughts. It doesn't matter, the war isn't over. "I've got bigger things to worry about right now. Prime is on his way."

"And what if he isn't?"

Catra blinks, stunned. "Of course he's on his way."

“Okay, but say he isn’t?”

"What's the point, Scorpia?" Catra doesn't even know if she'll make it out of the Fright Zone again. She hasn't been able to contact Hordak. Her communicator is out of range with the Fright Zone, and if Entrapta were to help her, it'd look suspicious. Hordak knows that tech isn't Catra's strong-suit. For all she knows, he thinks she's a traitor, or dead, or a failure. If he catches on to her plan with Glimmer, it'd all be over.

Scorpia raises an eyebrow. "What's really going on?"

"Nothing," Catra says swiftly. Scorpia will be better off not knowing what she’s planning.

But Scorpia purses her lips, clearly not satisfied with that answer. Catra hopes she doesn’t press her, she has a feeling Scorpia wouldn’t approve of her going back to the Fright Zone, no matter the reason.

Thankfully, they’re interrupted before Scorpia inquires anymore.

“Hi, Scorpia, I’ve brought you some snacks!” Perfuma says cheerfully, but the stare she gives Catra is anything but friendly.

“I’ll… I’ll leave the two of you alone,” Catra says, silently hoping that Adora doesn’t try to escape while these two are too busy getting lost in each other’s eyes. But Catra doesn’t think she’s ever seen Scorpia this happy. Catra can only hope that this can last, that it can grow, that Prime might not be able to find Etheria after all or they win against all odds.

Catra walks directly underneath Adora’s balcony. Scorpia was right—Adora is laughing joyfully, at something that *Swift Wind* said! Catra doesn't get Adora's adoration for Swift Wind, but maybe that noble steed talk wasn't all garbage. And it tugs at Catra's heart—she can’t remember the last time she heard Adora laugh at something so carefree. Aside from the portal they were all a part of, that is. If what happened there even counts. It wasn't real, and Catra can't imagine Adora ever smiling at her like that again.

Part of Catra is tempted to go in there, to see Adora laugh for herself. But she knows she shouldn't intrude, not when Adora is excited to see her old friends again.

Mindlessly, Catra walks through the halls of Bright Moon now. There’s a closed door she walks past that leaves her feeling cold immediately, a sensation she grew painfully familiar with as a child. So that’s where Shadow Weaver’s being kept. Catra hopes she stays there and rots. Adora claimed she escaped last night without Shadow Weaver’s help, and if that was the truth, it means there’s a chance Shadow Weaver doesn’t know if Adora’s return. It’s probably best to keep it that way, Adora's better off without Shadow Weaver messing with her head.

Catra leaves the hallway quickly, taking the first exit back outside that she sees. She nearly runs into Bow, who is practicing his archery.

“Hey,” Catra says awkwardly.

“Hey,” Bow says back, not looking too surprised to see her, fishing for his next arrow.

“Stress relief?” Catra asks.

Bow shrugs. “I figured getting some extra training in couldn’t hurt before an intergalactic dictator lands on our planet.”

“Right.” He has a point. Catra should probably make the most of training somewhere Hordak couldn't question.

Bow shoots at his target and hits the bullseye. It’s a normal arrow, for once. Catra wasn't ever sure he carried them.

"So, you held off on your plan?” Bow asks.

“For now. It wasn’t all up to me,” Catra says.

“Adora was able to change your mind?”

“Please. She doesn’t know about the plan. I don’t think hearing about it is in her best interest right now.”

“No, I know, that wasn’t what I meant.”

Arrow Boy, Catra decides right then, is not good at keeping secrets. He’s looking at her almost giddily, which is absolutely not warranted for the situation they’re in.

Catra rolls her eyes. “How do you know?

“How do I know what?” Bow asks, feigning innocence.

“How do you know I stayed with Adora last night?”

“Glimmer went teleporting all over the castle for you earlier this morning. When she couldn’t find you, I *may* have suggested Adora’s room.”

“What made you think I'd be there?”

“It was just a lucky guess. And it turned out I was right.”

“Nothing happened, you know.” Catra blurts, getting a strange look from Bow. “I just… stayed the night.”

“I didn’t mean to suggest anything did,” Bow says. “I’m just happy that Adora seems a little more… settled. You helped her with that. I’m grateful.”

“Oh,” Catra says. She’s not used to being on the other end of gratitude. She’s not used to gratitude in any sense, actually. “I just wish I could do more. It’s my fault she was there in the first place. It’s my fault she’s still like this. Scared and confused—unsure of what's real. I never wanted that for her.”

“Hey,” Bow says. “You’re doing what you can.”

Catra ignores that. Nothing she does will ever be enough. “I’m still going to the Fright Zone tomorrow.”

“If that’s what you think you need to do. But I’m glad you’re here, Catra.” He sounds sincere, in the decreasingly alarming way Bow always sounds sincere. Catra chooses to believe him.

“Thanks, Bow.”

Bow smiles. “You called me by name.”

“Don’t get used to it.”

His smile doesn’t falter. In fact, Catra swears it gets bigger.

Glimmer watches Adora when Swift Wind leaves, after giving Glimmer a look saying, *be mindful*. After her escape attempt last night, it's too risky to leave Adora alone for too long, though Glimmer can't figure out exactly what it was that made Adora want to come back to Bright Moon in the first place, once she had the chance to leave.

But today Adora seems different, and Glimmer can't place it. Her grin—goofy, bright, something Glimmer worried she would never see again—resurfaces upon seeing Glimmer, but only for a moment. It fades after two seconds. Adora might be more relaxed, but she still knows she's a prisoner, and she knows why Glimmer is really here.

"You can babysit me for a bit," Adora begins, in that diplomatic voice of hers, "on the condition that you don't ask me anything else about the portal. Nothing about what happened to me in there, nothing about any of the other realities. Can you agree to that?"

"Of course I can," Glimmer answers, aware she sounds rather defeated. She had hoped to learn more. The sooner they have a better idea of what happened to Adora, the sooner they have a chance at convincing her she's really back home. But if this is what it takes for Adora to stay put, Glimmer will comply.

The pillows and blankets have all been removed from the floor, probably stuffed in one of the drawers somewhere. There's no sign that Catra had stayed the night at all, something Glimmer is still trying to process, something she wouldn't have believed if she hadn't seen it for herself.

Glimmer sits herself down near Adora's balcony. Adora keeps her distance and sits on the bed.

Glimmer clears her throat. "How was your time with Swift Wind?"

“As fine as any time when you’re being held captive by a rainbow alicorn.” A beat passes. “That was supposed to be a joke.” Glimmer doesn’t laugh, and Adora sighs. “It was good, I guess. I’ve missed Swiftie.” Adora bites her lip.

Adora still thinks the real Swift Wind is still out there, missing her.

“Why did you choose to stay?” Glimmer asks.

Betrayal crosses Adora's face for a second. “Catra told you about last night?” Adora shrugs. “That’s too close to the topic of portals. Off-limits.”

Glimmer suppresses a groan. She doesn’t think there has ever been a reason for things to be this tense between them, at least, not since Adora joined the Rebellion.

“Speaking of Catra," Adora says slowly, making Glimmer wish that Catra was an off-limit topic. "There’s something I need to ask you... I find it hard to believe I live in a world where Catra is the one who rescued the king of Bright Moon.” Adora makes a face, shaking her head. “At least, that’s what Swift Wind told me. Is that true?”

Glimmer has to laugh, getting a stare from Adora. “Oh, trust me, it was not that simple. Catra rescued my dad from Beast Island, sure, but she had an ulterior motive. She brought him to Bright Moon as a hostage. She was trying to exchange him for the sword.”

“That sounds more like the Catra I knew,” Adora says, frowning. “But what did Catra want with the sword? She couldn’t use it to get to me, anymore.”

Glimmer looks away from Adora. It’s still not easy to grapple with the truth, that Catra was trying to fix her biggest mistake. “But that’s exactly it, Adora. Catra wanted to rescue you from the portal.”

“Catra wanted to save me? The same Catra who sent me there in the first place? Yeah, sorry. I doubt there’s a world in which the Catra I knew wanted to bring me back.”

“Is it really so hard to believe?” Glimmer asks.

Adora lies flat on her bed, covering her eyes with her arm. “There were a few other warped realities I saw, where Catra and I were on the same side. I’m not saying it’s impossible that the Catra I knew cared, but she’s long gone. She told me herself that the world would have been better off without me. I appreciate the effort, Glimmer. I really do. But I can’t really get back to you until I find the sword, which you won’t let me have. The portal doesn’t want me to leave, and neither do you.”

“How do you know it was the real Light Hope you saw in the portal?” Glimmer asks. “And not just a portal-version of her?”

“That's off-limits," Adora reminds her.

"You're the one who brought up the portal."

"Did I?" Adora sits up, swings her legs back and forth with a puzzled expression. "Sorry, I didn't realize."

"That's okay." Glimmer waits a minute, hoping Adora would answer anyway, but she's apparently decided to drop the subject.

“What’s your plan to fight Prime?” Adora asks, serious now.

Of course Adora’s next interest is battle strategy. “We’re still figuring it out. Catra’s been helping.”

“That’s vague.”

“Do you really think you're in a position to think about war right now?"

Adora glares at her. “When have I ever *not* been in a position to think about war?" It's a fair question, Glimmer has to concede.

Before she can offer a real answer, Adora stands up, walking around the room with raised arms. "Do you really think you can beat him without me? Without—without She-Ra?”

“We’re going to defeat him,” Glimmer says. “We have to.” *And you're in no condition to fight right now*, she wants to say.

Adora's sudden burst of energy has tired her, she seats herself back onto her bed. “What’s with the white sleeve?”

“What? Oh.” Glimmer looks at the sleeve. It hadn’t occurred to her that she could stop wearing it, now that Adora was technically back. “It’s Bright Moon’s color of mourning.”

“Huh,” Adora says, taking a deep interest in fiddling with her hands. “I had forgotten.”

They were lucky, before the portal. There were so few casualties.

“Do you know how I learned that the Fright Zone’s color is black?” Glimmer asks. Adora shakes her head, without meeting Glimmer's eyes. “Because Catra did the same thing—wearing mourning colors, I mean. Even when she was still fighting for the Horde. Looking back, that's how I knew she really felt your loss.”

Adora’s hands go still. “I think it’s time I take a nap.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer says. “Get some rest, Adora.” She teleports out, not surprised to find Catra in the hallway.

“Why did you tell her that?” Catra asks.

“Tell her what?” Glimmer asks.

Catra's eyes narrow, unimpressed with her poor effort to act oblivious. “About the mourning colors.”

“Because she needed to hear it."

“I’m not sure about that,” says Catra. Glimmer merely raises her shoulders. "I mean, I'm not sure that will really help."

"It can't hurt to try," Glimmer insists. "Are you going in there?"

Catra shakes her head. "I'll let her rest, for now. You and I need to go over our plans for tomorrow. Thoroughly."

"Yeah." Glimmer reaches for Catra's shoulder, so she can teleport them to the war room.

Catra immediately shrugs off her hand. "I'd rather walk, thanks."

"If you insist. I'll have to teleport you tomorrow."

"Don't remind me," Catra groans.

It's Netossa guarding Adora's door for the first part of the night shift. She raises an eyebrow as Catra walks closer. "Ordinarily I wouldn't let you in."

"These aren't exactly ordinary circumstances," Catra says, feeling foolish for trying to enter through Adora's bedroom door. She should have just snuck in through the balcony to spare herself from this conversation. But she's been making an effort to be transparent around the princesses, and this is a part of that.

"They sure aren't," Netossa replies. "But in a strange way, I'm glad you can be there for her."

"Thanks," Catra says. "But don't sound so sure, there's a good chance Adora won't let me in." Adora might not want a repeat of last night, and Catra wouldn't blame her.

Netossa laughs at that. "I have a feeling she will."

Uncertain of what to make of that, Catra doesn't reply to Netossa, and instead knocks on Adora's door. "Hey, Adora. It's me."

Adora opens the door and raises an eyebrow. "I'm surprised you came back."

"Why?"

"Because you've been avoiding me all day."

Catra crosses her arms. "I haven't been avoiding you." Adora doesn't look convinced. "I *haven't*," she insists.

"Then why haven't I seen you?"

"War preparations." There's a muffled snicker from Netossa, Catra is sure, and she fights the urge to glare at her.

"Those don't last all day. I know how the Rebellion works, and I know how *you* work." Adora opens the door wider, and steps back. "But you can come in, if you want."

Catra enters without a word. The room has been cleared of the material Catra slept on last night, pristine and shiny and colorful. It fits Adora entirely, more so than the Fright Zone ever could.

Adora stays quiet, clearly waiting for Catra to say something. And Catra doesn't know what to say; she wanted to give Adora space, and it wasn't as if Adora had asked to see her, either. And besides, Adora spent half of the day with Swift Wind, Catra wasn't going to intrude on that if she didn't have to.

Adora sighs, and it comes out as more of a huff. At least she's still stubborn as usual. "Why are you still wearing all black?" It almost sounds accusatory, Catra didn't think Adora would actually bring it up. "I mean," Adora clarifies, looking puzzled. "If you were wearing it for me—"

"That's a big assumption," Catra says, cutting her off, even though it's the truth.

Adora decides to ignore the comment. "I'm back, aren't I? I'm not gone, I'm not dead."

It sounds more like a question, as if Adora is waiting for confirmation, as if she's still waiting for this world to break, to take her somewhere else.

"You don't really believe that you're back," Catra says, eventually. "You're still lost. So I think it's fitting to still wear black, for now. Plus, Prime's going to be here anyway, I've got bigger things to think about than my wardrobe."

"Such as?" Adora asks, stepping closer to Catra, slowly.

It would have been a smooth move, if she and Glimmer hadn't already agreed to keep Adora out of the loop when it comes to strategy right now. Catra takes a step back. "You and I both know I'm not going to tell you the Rebellion's current tactics tonight."

Adora's face falls. "Fine, then. You can see yourself out."

Catra shouldn't be surprised. She didn't want to spend her last night in Bright Moon *away* from Adora, but she'll oblige, if that's what she wants. "Okay," she says, and turns around, heading for the door.

"Wait, Catra!" Adora rushes behind her, grabs Catra's left hand. All words Catra might have had are lost. Usually it's the other way around, Catra grabbing Adora's hand, leading her somewhere. Past the barracks. To the roof. Away from the portal, from the truth. It was always only the two of them, the touch something no one else could see.

"Your hand is warm," Adora says, after a minute of saying nothing. Catra is too stunned to pull away.

"And?" Adora doesn't think this is real, Catra has to remind herself. "What's going on?"

“In the portal, everyone’s skin was cold as ice,” Adora explains. "That’s how I caught on, eventually. That something was wrong. But yours isn’t.”

“Which means?” Catra asks, wanting it to come from Adora herself.

“Which means you really are Catra, or that the portal has gotten more realistic.”

Catra turns to face her, inches away from her face. "When you were gone," she begins, "my arm started to burn, right after the portal. The same spot from where—“ it was corrupted, tainted, wrong. “From when the portal got to me.” Adora’s eyes soften. “At first it burned, and then, it started to freeze. It was always cold. Wearing the sleeve didn’t make much of a difference, but I liked to think it helped.”

“Is it still cold?” Adora asks.

“Not since you came back,” Catra says. There’s a beat, a pulse. It would be a good moment for Catra to apologize again, Adora seems like she’s in a space to listen, but it's strange, not being able to guess what Adora is thinking.

Adora's gaze seems far away. "I'm not sure, anymore." Her hand squeezes Catra's tightly. "It might... it might not be impossible that I'm really back. But there's still so much I don't understand, Catra. Why did you want to save me from the portal in the first place? The last thing you said to me was that you wouldn’t let me win."

"The last thing I said was that this was all your fault," Catra corrects her, removing her hand.

"But was that all you saying that?" Adora asks. "That version of you, she was different."

"I'm not sure."

"You're avoiding the original question."

"It wasn't a fair fight," Catra says. "I couldn't really win the war against the Rebellion if you were still stuck in another reality. That wouldn't count. It'd be too easy, undeserved."

"*Catra*."

"What?"

"You've never cared about the rules. Why did you really try to bring me back?"

Do you really not know? Catra wants to ask. What she says is: "It was awful, when you were gone. I couldn't stand being the reason why. And I'm sorry."

"You don't have to keep apologizing."

"And you're too forgiving."

"Who said I forgive you?"

Catra backs away, wishing she could make herself small. "If you hated me, why am I here?"

"I don't hate you," Adora says. "But that doesn't mean I forgive you."

"Then what does it mean?" Catra asks. But Adora doesn't answer the question. "I'll leave if you want me to."

"I think I want you to stay." She pinches the bridge of her nose. "That's not what I mean. I know I want you to stay. Look." Adora's afraid, Catra realizes, with a pang. "Part of me wants to forgive you. I've missed you for so long, Catra. Ever since I left the Horde." Her voice falters. "But it's *complicated* and I'm not sure it's really you. Don't you see?"

"I do," Catra says, wiping at one of her eyes. She's never heard Adora sound so small before, splintering her own heart into fragments. "But can I ask you something?" Adora nods. “Has it ever occurred to you that Light Hope didn’t want you to believe you were really back so you could activate the Heart?”

Adora meets her eyes blankly. The thought has occurred. But Adora won’t admit it verbally. “If that’s true,” Adora says. “What does that make me?”

“What do you mean?”

“If She-Ra is a weapon…”

“But you’re not She-Ra. You can’t even turn into She-Ra without the sword.”

“She’s still a part of me, Catra. And that’s something you’ve never understood. Not in any reality.”

And the sad thing is, Adora is right.

"I guess there's still things both of us need to accept," Catra says neutrally. "But I'm willing to try."

"Me, too," says Adora, with a watery smile.

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Catra doesn't think she'll ever get used to instances where she wakes up before Adora, and she knows she'll most likely never get the chance again.

They slept inches apart last night, and Catra can still feel the warmth of Adora's breath on her nose. If she were awake, she

could lean in close and kiss Adora goodbye properly. But she refuses to wake Adora.

She still leans over, kisses her forehead, and whispers three words to her she wishes she had the courage to say sooner, but there's no time to look back, now.

Catra quickly makes her way to her rendezvous point with Glimmer, at the garden. "It's time," she tells Glimmer.

Glimmer nods. “Does Adora know what you’re doing?”

“No, she's still asleep."

"Good," Glimmer says, even though she doesn't look too pleased with that, as if she wants to change her mind and let Adora in on the plan after all. “Do you want me to give her a message, when I come back?”

Catra shakes her head. “There’s no point. Adora still doesn’t believe she’s back, and she still thinks I’m just a portal simulation. Maybe it’s better that way, for now. For her own good. She doesn't need anything else to worry about.”

"Right," says Glimmer, unconvinced, but unmotivated to press her. Glimmer extends her hand forward. "Are you ready?"

Catra takes it. "Yeah, I'm ready."

Adora wakes up and she's not in the Whispering Woods, she's in her room in Bright Moon, feeling more at peace than she has in months. She opens her eyes, hoping to tell Catra, but she's alone. It's funny that she's surprised. In this reality, Catra has been an early riser, and Adora should have expected as much this morning, but she didn't.

Yawning, Adora sits up, hoping that Catra is still in here somewhere, her room is rather big, but Catra's currently absent, probably out figuring out more battle tactics that no one will let Adora in on.

Remembering that she's still not permitted to leave her room, Adora lies back down. She can't imagine being kept in her room against her will day long, *again*. Maybe if she calls for Catra, she'll escort her somewhere, like she did with Mara's ship the other night. Anywhere else will do.

But Bow suddenly bursts into her room without knocking.

Adora springs up on her feet to meet him. He looks nervous, which means something's wrong.

“What’s happened?” Adora asks.

“I'm not supposed to—Glimmer told me I couldn't tell you what Catra's plan was, but I think it backfired.”

Adora stills. "What are you talking about? What plan?"

“Glimmer took Catra back to the Fright Zone.”

“What? Why would she do that? Why would she *want* that?” Bow is on the verge of complete hyperventilation, and Adora feels bad for all the questions. "Come on, breathe in with me, just like you taught me."

Bow gives her a grateful look and she hugs him after a few rounds of breathing exercises. Bow is still shaky, but he can concentrate again. "Catra wanted to find out as much about Prime and his current plans as she could. She was going to pretend she was still Hordak's second-in-command. She was going to report back to us so we could plan our next move accordingly."

"Where is Glimmer, then?"

Bow's eyes are wide, afraid. "She hasn't come back yet. It was supposed to be quick. She was just supposed to teleport Catra over there and leave."

"Do Micah and Angella know?"

Bow shakes his head. "No one was supposed to know but me."

"They got caught," Adora says. "That's the only explanation. We have to go and get them. We need to leave *now*."

"And then what happens?"

"We'll improvise!"

"Because that's worked in our favor before? We need to do this right, Adora."

"There isn't time! I'm gonna go find Swift Wind," she says, trying not to panic. She bolts for the door before Bow can stop her. "Swiftie!" she calls, while running to the gardens.

"Adora, wait!" Bow calls from behind her.

She dodges several different net arrows he shoots her way.

But once she finally makes it outside, she trips over an arrow that narrowly missed her feet, lands on her back, looking up at the sky, littered with stars and warships that don't belong. They could be beautiful if they weren't so terrible.

"Oh," she hears Bow say from behind her. "We're too late."

"We can't be," Adora says, forcing herself to stand up, craning her neck up to take it all in.

“Do you still think this is another simulation?” asks Bow.

“I—I don’t know,” Adora whispers. It's not the answer Bow wants to hear, but she continues, “But real or not, I can’t leave Catra and Glimmer in the hands of the enemy. I can’t take that chance.

We have to save them, Bow." She stops looking up, and meets Bow's eyes. "But you have to let me go to the Crystal Castle first. I need to speak to Light Hope."

Chapter End Notes

thank you all again for your kind comments and patience!! <3 just one more chapter left!! i truly did not expect this fic to get as long as it did, and i'm excited to wrap it up!! of course the last chapter has been a little more difficult for me to finish, but it is on its way :)

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The worst thing about love is / I remember it. / I walk around all day / thinking: I'm going to die / in the universe / you loved me in."

— June Gehringer

"I kneel into a dream where I / am good & loved. I am good. / I am loved. My hands have made / some good mistakes. They can always / make better ones."

— Natalie Wee

The Fright Zone doesn't feel like the Fright Zone anymore. That's the first thing Catra notices. The air is too stagnant, too quiet, like none of the machinery wants to work any longer, like every member of the Horde is collectively holding a breath. Catra tries to slow her own breathing to process what has shifted. She has a fear of breathing too loudly, of the two of them getting caught. Catra can't allow that. Glimmer needs to teleport back to Bright Moon. She needs to do it now.

"What are you still doing here?" Catra half-hisses, half-whispers. "You need to go back home."

"And just leave you here?" Glimmer whispers back, as if that's an insane thing to suggest, as if that wasn't already discussed.

"Uh, considering that was the plan in the first place? Yes."

But Glimmer shakes her head. "I don't know the Fright Zone as well as you do, but even I can tell there's something off with this place. I'm not leaving you behind until I know that you're going to be okay."

“That’s not what we agreed on.”

“That’s too bad.”

“*Glimmer.*” Part of Catra is moved that Glimmer is willing to stay by her side after everything they've been through. But moved or not, it's still too dangerous. “If you stay too close, and Hordak finds you—”

“Pretend you’ve taken me as a prisoner,” she suggests. “He would have to believe that. I can just teleport home later, even with my hands bound.”

“Right, because that would do me a lot of favors."

“We might not even have to worry about it. Please, Catra. Just for ten minutes. Then I'll go back to Bright Moon, I swear.”

“Make it five minutes and you have a deal.” Glimmer rolls her eyes at that. “Sparkles,” she says through her teeth. “It really might not be safe.”

“And that’s the risk I’m willing to take. That's the risk you're already taking. I can't let you do it alone.”

Catra’s not thrilled with it, but she gives in. She can’t waste more time by arguing with Glimmer. And it’s true, Glimmer can technically teleport back home whenever she wants. It’s her own neck Catra needs to worry about.

The two walk throughout the Fright Zone wordlessly, Glimmer in the front, Catra in the back. There’s still no visible sign something is amiss, but the lack of Fright Zone soldiers is alarming. Either everyone is slacking at their stations without Catra around to give them orders, or they have somewhere more important to be. Whatever Hordak is up to, it isn't going to be good.

As they turn a corner down to a hallway that will take them to the center of the Fright Zone, Catra’s breath hitches. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio are staring back at her equally surprised.

“Catra?” Lonnie asks. “What are you—what is she?" Her words stutter as her eyes land on Glimmer, unsure of what to do. “What is going on here?”

“It’s complicated,” Catra says, mouth dry. “I need to find Hordak.”

Lonnie takes a step closer, and Glimmer steps back, almost bumping into Catra. “I thought you were gone for good,” Lonnie says.

“Bet you hoped I was.”

Lonnie decides not to comment on that. “*Hordak* thought you were gone for good. You didn't make it back in time. He's been moving on without you."

Of course he has, but Catra can't be mad, that was part of their agreement. If she didn't meet Hordak's deadline, he was going to move forward. "That's not a problem, I was expecting that. But I'm here now. I'm sure Hordak will catch me up to speed."

Lonnie's eyes remain cool, suggesting otherwise. "Is it true that Adora's back? Back from the portal?”

The question takes Catra by surprise. She does her best not to let it show. “You heard about that?”

Lonnie laughs at that. “You think Hordak wouldn’t notice that *another* portal has gone off?”

“What makes you think it had anything to do with Adora?”

Behind Lonnie, Kyle coughs. Rogelio says something to him, but Catra can’t quite catch it.

“Why wouldn’t it have anything to do with Adora?” Lonnie asks, but Catra doesn’t have an answer for her. “Look, Catra. I don’t think Hordak knows or cares that Adora’s come back. He’s just been waiting for Prime to get here, he’s been able to make contact.”

“Prime’s on his way?”

“He’s supposed to be here soon,” Kyle chimes unhelpfully.

“And you’re all ready for that?”

“Should we not be prepared?” Lonnie asks. “You’ve done nothing but have us work ourselves to death to get ready for this moment.” She tilts her head towards Glimmer. “What’s she really doing here? She's obviously not really a prisoner.” Catra stays silent as Lonnie’s eyes narrow. “You helped bring Adora back, didn’t you?”

And there’s no point in lying. Catra and Glimmer can take these three in a fight no problem, if it comes down to it. Catra nods, and Lonnie looks a little more relaxed, but still worried.

“Then why did you come back here? You were *out*, Catra. Hordak couldn’t believe that the Rebellion captured you, that *you* of all people couldn’t handle facing the Rebellion, so he’s been telling us that you were dead.”

“We didn’t believe him,” Kyle says, to which Rogelio nods in agreement.

“No, we didn’t,” Lonnie agrees. “And it might be in your best interest if it stays that way."

“I came back because I owe it to Adora,” Catra says simply. “If I don’t find out what Prime’s plans to conquer Etheria are… well, there’s no point to any of this.”

Lonnie’s eyes widen, and Kyle and Rogelio look equally shocked. “You switched sides for her?”

And Lonnie, after everything, deserves the truth. “Yes.”

Lonnie’s smile is strained, but it’s still a smile. “Then why didn’t you tell us sooner? Things have gone to shit since you left, Catra.”

“I’m sorry about that. I really am. But you should get out. All three of you, and anyone else you don’t want to lose.”

“And you, Catra? You’re staying here? What happens if Prime catches you?”

“It doesn’t matter,” Catra says. “As long as everyone else gets out of here.”

Lonnie nods in understanding. Good. Catra's history with her might be complicated, but it will be better if her fellow Fright Zone members get away from here before Prime arrives. But then Lonnie frowns. “I have one more question. What happened to Scorpia? One day she was here and then she was just gone.”

At this, Catra has to smile. “She’s a princess, didn’t you know?” Lonnie merely stares at her. “She joined the Rebellion. She fits right in. She’s okay, there. She'll be safe. She's already made some friends.”

"She's in good hands," Glimmer agrees.

At this, Lonnie looks relieved.

If things were better, Catra and Lonnie might hug each other goodbye. But Catra simply watches as the three of them get ready to flee the Fright Zone. It's better this way.

*

Prime is scarier than Catra expected. She had anticipated a slightly more capable version of Hordak, one who would be easy to gauge, one who would be easy to lie to. Catra has no problem with lying, she's done it her whole life, mostly to protect Adora. This shouldn't be any different, except it is.

Because now Glimmer is here, roped into this. They stand before him on his ship, his *ship*. A green light had beamed over the two of them while they were searching for answers. And it's stupid. Catra knows that now. She shouldn't have let Glimmer stay with her in the Fright Zone, not when they had no idea where Prime was. Of course he would arrive when he did.

“You need She-Ra to access the weapon,” Catra says, answering Prime's question, trying to sound as dutiful as she can. For now, the threat of She-Ra is their only saving grace, even if She-Ra is gone. Prime doesn’t need to know that. Catra just needs to stall him long enough till she can figure out how to take him out herself. He isn’t getting She-Ra, and he isn’t getting anywhere near Adora.

As long as Adora doesn’t get anywhere near the Crystal Castle, Adora should be safe.

(Please, let Adora be safe.)

“And who is this?” Prime asks, gesturing to Glimmer.

“Oh, her?” Catra tries to sound collected, dares herself to be brave, as if she isn’t more scared than she's ever been. Prime's presence is more terrifying than the realization that it was her fault Adora got trapped inside the portal. “This is the princess of Bright Moon. She's connected to the super-weapon, same as She-Ra.”

The name and title of Bright Moon mean nothing to Prime, judging by his blank expression, but the longer Catra stares at him, the more she’s convinced he doesn’t feel anything, nothing at all, except maybe the pleasure that comes with victory and greed.

“I suppose she can come with us,” Prime says.

And it’s then that Catra knows she miscalculated.

Adora chases a shadow of She-Ra, or rather, a version of She-Ra completely aglow. The essence of She-Ra, perhaps. Adora thought She-Ra was lost to her, and sometimes, especially tonight, it's as if She-Ra is taunting her. "Come back," Adora begs.

But She-Ra doesn't change her path, and she doesn't listen to Adora. She keeps moving forward, an action Adora can't seem to do, not even in her dreams.

*

Adora is back on Etheria. Really *back on Etheria, the one she misses most. There are no more stars in the sky, and she and Catra are on opposite sides of enemy lines. There's a battle going on, her friends are fighting and the air smells like smoke, but Adora can't bring herself to focus on that. All she can focus on is Catra: Catra in her red Horde uniform, her hair as wild as her eyes. Somehow, that familiar sight gives Adora the most relief since the portal went off. It doesn't matter that Catra is her enemy, what matters is that* this *is the Catra she knows, standing right before her.*

"Catra," Adora says. It comes out as a whisper, the battle surrounding them is too loud, even though it feels far away. "Can we talk?"

Catra rolls her eyes and laughs. It's bitter. "You really want to talk to me now? I think it's a little late for that."

"No, this is important, I promise."

Catra flinches as the word, but she considers Adora's words. "Fine, go on then. But make it quick. I have a fight to win."

Adora steps closer to her. "You're not going to believe me, but we don't have to be enemies. I've seen it."

"As long as you're with the Rebellion you will always be my enemy," she replies, devastatingly unmoved by Adora's words.

"But Catra," she pleads, taking Catra's hand the way she's taken it so many times before, but Catra's hand is cold, so cold it burns. And that's not right. Adora knows this isn't right. But she doesn't know why. She's seen versions of Catra in the portal who cared about her, and it's jarring to see the real Catra be so dismissive. "Do you really not feel bad?" Her voice breaks with the question, and Catra laughs at her like it's impossible for her to feel remorse. Like Adora was naive for thinking there could be any other outcome.

"Etheria would be better off if you had stayed in that portal. How many more times do I need to say it before it gets through that thick skull of yours?"

Adora blinks. Once she opens her eyes, the world before her has changed: it's twilight, and there are stars in the sky. Underneath them stands Catra, wearing all black, her hair sleek. "It was me," she says."It was me and you didn't recognize me and now I'm gone."

Adora's eyes grow wet. She was wrong, of course she was wrong. But how could she have known better? She's seen dozens of versions of Catra, each of them appearing as real as the Catra in her memory. "You're not gone. You can't be. Catra, of course I know you. I'm going to get you back."

"We'll see about that," Catra says, before dissolving into smoke.

*

Adora wakes up alone in her tent. She’s dreamed of many things, lately restless in her sleep. But the ones where she sees Catra always result with her waking up with tears on her face and her pillow.

It’s been a week since Glimmer took Catra to the Fright Zone, and there’s been no sign from either of them.

Bow’s been putting on a brave face, insisting that Adora doesn’t need to worry, but Adora can’t seem to do anything but worry. It doesn’t help that they’ve been kicked out of Bright Moon by Prime’s army. So much Catra did to help stop *that* from happening.

“How do you know Catra’s really in the Fright Zone helping us?” Adora had asked him once, feeling rather betrayed by Bow's faith in her former best friend.

“Because Glimmer trusted her,” he had answered. Adora wasn’t satisfied with that. It wouldn't be the first time Glimmer put her trust in the wrong person.

But Adora hasn’t been satisfied, period. The Rebellion has been losing ground. They only found a safe haven because Shadow Weaver was there with her endless supply of secret knowledge.

Shadow Weaver, who managed to escape the castle with them, somehow, and stayed by them.

“*Adora*,” she had crooned one night, reaching for Adora’s face. Adora knew what Shadow Weaver wanted to offer, a mind trick, or magic, something to help Adora forget her time in the portal. Something to bring the old Adora back.

Adora had flinched and took a step back. “Leave me alone,” she said. And Shadow Weaver actually listened to her and gave her space. Adora took it as another reason to believe this is the one reality where everything goes wrong, if even Shadow Weaver wasn't behaving as terrible as usual.

*

Adora wakes up to the sound of her name.

“Adora?” Angella asks. “Are you listening?”

It wasn’t that Adora wasn’t trying to pay attention, it’s that none of their previous meetings have panned out too well. Prime’s control over Etheria has been growing more and more each day. And Adora has still been so exhausted, haunted by her dreams that still blur into reality. If any of it is reality, that is. Adora still isn't convinced.

Bow has still refused to let Adora visit the Crystal Castle, and has been wasting the Rebellion’s very limited resources on making sure someone keeps an eye on her. Meanwhile, Micah and Angella have ruled out any scouting missions in the Fright Zone, even though that’s where their daughter has disappeared.

Part of Adora wants to say, *It doesn’t matter what I say because none of this is real anyway*, but Angella doesn’t deserve that attitude right now. Real or not, Adora knows she’s worried for Glimmer.

“Are you sure we shouldn’t try to infiltrate the Fright Zone? We still haven’t heard a word from Glimmer.”

“If we act too hastily,” Micah says, “we’ll lose the war.”

Angella agrees. “Glimmer knew the risks of this mission. In order for it to work, we need to time it right. And there are too many bots between here and there.”

“Glimmer doesn’t have time for any more delays. We need to send a team over there," Bow insists.

Angella sighs.“We can’t afford to lose anyone else.”

“Send me then,” Adora suggests. “You won’t let me fight anyway. What’s the harm of letting me go over there?”

Angella looks worn, tired. Adora wonders if it’s due to the loss of her power or Glimmer’s absence or both. “If we do send a team to the Fright Zone, I will consider your role as part of it.”

“That’s all I ask.”

Adora marches out of the tent, exhausted. She doesn’t care about the sword at this point, doesn’t care if she’ll ever turn into She-Ra again. Well, that’s partly true, but Adora has accepted the loss. What Adora cares are about is finding answers. If she’s really back, if Light Hope was lying to her, Adora needs to know, and she needs to know now.

It’s not an easy escape, but with Bow worried about Glimmer and everyone else worrying about repairing Mara’s ship, and with another team sent out to fight the bots in the woods, Adora eventually manages to sneak off into the Whispering Woods.

She makes a run for it.

Five minutes and she doesn't get caught. Ten minutes and her run slows down to a jog. She doesn't have the strength she used to. It's not an easy thing to accept.

But when she finally makes it to the Crystal Castle, Swift Wind is guarding it. He looks at her sadly. “I hoped you wouldn’t try.”

Adora stills. She’s never had to fight Swift Wind, and she doesn’t plan on changing that, but as much as he loves her, he’s stubborn, and it’s not going to go well.

“But you came to guard it anyway.”

Swift Wind nods. “I didn’t know what else to do,” he admits.

Adora doesn't know what to do either. “Swiftie, please... I have to do this. If I don’t speak to Light Hope, I’ll never know for sure if I’m back or not. Don’t you see?”

“I won’t let you go in alone,” he says.

“But you’ll let me enter?” Hope crosses her mind for the first time.

“I think it will help,” Swift Wind says. “If you promise not to touch the sword.”

“I’m not sure I can promise that. She-Ra isn’t a weapon—I—she can’t be. I won’t set anything off that can hurt Etheria."

“You’ve always been powerful,” Swift Wind says. “I don’t think you need She-Ra to be strong.”

“But what about you, what about our bond?”

“It still exists. Can’t you feel it?”

Adora can’t feel anything, not a single trace of magic, no concrete sense of time. The strongest thing Adora feels is fear. She can’t tell if she wants this reality to be real or not. One where Catra was on her side, only now she’s gone. One where Glimmer has both of her parents alive again. One where there are stars in Etheria’s skies.

One where she loses She-Ra to keep everything else.

“This is the only way I can make things right,” Adora says. "I have to try."

“Then we’ll go in together,” Swift Wind says.

It was Glimmer’s idea to pretend to be a hostage, and it backfired. She didn’t expect that Prime would leave Etheria before he had finished conquering it, that he would take both her and Catra with him, that there wouldn’t be magic, out here in space. How could she have known? It never occurred to her that she would leave Etheria against her will—a princess captured—it was like a storybook. But if it were a storybook, she wouldn't have lost her magic.

Bow knew about their plan, but only Bow. Her parents knew nothing. Glimmer’s lost track of how many days they’ve been out here, it’s impossible for time to move in a way that she can understand. There is no day and no night, and every moon the spaceship flies past can’t tell her the hour. But Glimmer imagines Bow would have told her parents what her and Catra's plan was by now. And even if they are aware, what could they do? Mara's spaceship is an ancient, faulty piece of First Ones' tech, a disaster waiting to happen at best. She and Catra are stranded out here together, unsure of when they'll be able to return home.

But in the meantime, Glimmer has learned many things. Prime is ancient, and sees everyone as disposable, even Hordak. Prime is a destroyer of worlds, and the ones he doesn’t destroy, he keeps control over. Glimmer can’t tell the destination Prime is seeking, or if he has to keep moving like a sea creature that would die otherwise.

And Glimmer has also learned what Catra really looks like when she’s scared. She does her best around Prime, Glimmer can tell, but there’s only so much fear she can mask before it slips out. And every day they move further from Etheria, the fear gets worse.

Catra is good at lying. So good that she nearly convinces Glimmer that she was never on her side in the first place, that she’s glad she’s here amongst Horde Prime’s ranks. But she’s not good enough, Glimmer still catches the way her eyes widen, the way her lower lip trembles when Prime isn’t looking at her. And if she

doesn’t keep her act up, neither of them stand a chance out here in space, further from the world they know with each passing day.

*

Catra visits her today, under the pretense of taunting her. She looks convincing, the way she keeps her arms crossed, the way her tail flicks back and forth. “I told you this was a bad idea,” she says, keeping her voice low.

“If I recall correctly, it was your idea to come back to the Fright Zone in the first place.”

Catra gives her a look. “Yes, it was my idea to come back, and deal with Prime *alone*. You could have teleported out of there at any time. Why did you stay?”

Glimmer doesn't have an immediate answer. It happened so fast. One moment they were in the Fright Zone and the next they were on the ship, already out of the Moonstone's range. “What was I supposed to do, Catra? Leave you alone to fend for yourself? Without me disguised as a prisoner, Hordak might not have believed your intentions!”

"In case you haven't noticed, Prime doesn't care about Hordak's opinions. If he did, I'd probably be behind bars, same as you. And it wouldn't matter if I was."

"What do you mean by that?" Glimmer asks, but Catra avoids her eyes. "Catra?" Glimmer asks again, quieter this time.

"We both know it doesn't matter what happens to me out here, Sparkles. What matters is that we figure out a way to get you back. And that you make sure Adora doesn't access the weapon."

Glimmer gapes at her. “Of course it matters what happens to you, Catra. How can you say that?”

“How can I not, after everything I’ve done!” Catra’s voice breaks, and Glimmer presses her hand against the green door, it vibrates against her touch. “We shouldn’t have come back,” Catra says, beginning to panic.

“Hey,” Glimmer says gently. “It’s going to be okay, we’ll figure it out, I promise.”

“How can you stay so calm? I’m the one who suggested we come back, I’m the one who got us into this mess. If I never opened the first portal—none of this would have happened!”

“I don’t think that’s true,” Glimmer says. “Hordak wanted to bring Prime to Etheria, that's what he's been working towards for years, isn't it? And Light Hope—if we never found Mara’s message, and Adora never got stuck—Light Hope would have gotten Adora to balance the planet, and none of us would have thought anything about it. Adora could have destroyed Etheria thinking she was doing something to save it.”

Catra sits, or rather, falls onto the ground, defeated. “Adora never had a choice, did she? And if Adora somehow gets her hand on the sword—we still might have failed her. We might not have an Etheria to get back to.”

“She won’t get the sword, Catra. Bow won’t let her. Neither will anyone else. We are going to get out of here. As far as we know, the Rebellion still has control over Etheria. Prime isn’t victorious, not yet. It’s going to work out.”

“How do you know?”

“Because I believe in our friends, and I believe in Adora. Besides, the Rebellion still has an advantage. *You.*”

“Me?”

“Prime still trusts you. You can learn what Prime’s plans are, learn his weaknesses. If it’s possible we can take him down out here, it will be worth it.”

“But Glimmer—”

“I can do my best too. Prime likes to take me out from time to time. If he keeps talking as much as he does, some of his weaknesses will slip out eventually. If you and I work together, we'll be unstoppable, even in space. Prime doesn’t stand a chance.”

“I want to believe that.”

“Besides, maybe our friends back home will fix Mara's ship, or Entrapta will make a new one, and they'll come find us. Stranger things have happened, right? But it doesn't matter. One way or another we’re going to get out of here, and we’re going to go back home.”

That sentiment actually makes Catra smile.

*

The next day, Prime takes Glimmer out of her prison. To her surprise, he takes her to a table, where Catra is already seated. There’s a feast.

Prime tells them to eat. Glimmer pokes at something gelatinous with her spoon, but Catra digs in. Whether she is genuinely hungry or doing her best to pretend not to be bothered, Glimmer can’t tell.

He shows them images of Etheria at war. Bright Moon is covered with smoke, and bots are fighting their friends. There’s only

flashes of their friends, Glimmer spies her parents, even spies Bow, but she never once catches a glimpse of Adora.

"Where is your She-Ra now?" he asks. "If she were really as powerful as Hordak says, surely she would have emerged to fight me? Or maybe that portal she was stuck in has weakened her. Either way, it matters not. She will be no match for me."

Neither of them have a response for him.

Adora wakes up as She-Ra. She's not sure how she got here. Where was she last? Was it the woods, Bright Moon, the waste? She can't remember.

Someone calls her name. There's a ringing in her ear. And then she realizes that it's two voices. One low and collected, automatic. The other frantic and loud. Light Hope and Swift Wind.

There is strength that comes with She-Ra, there always has been. But something is wrong.

The sword is the key, one voice tells her. *You can't use it*, the other voice says.

The sword is suspended in the air. And has it really been in the Crystal Castle the whole time? Or is it merely another skewed reality? The sword may have been made by the First Ones, same as the castle, but it doesn't belong here. Adora doesn't either.

Their voices blur together and this ringing, this humming, it's coming from the sword. It glows, but not in a way that feels magical. In a way that feels dangerous.

There's a threat to Etheria, a voice reminds her. *It is your duty to stop it.*

The weapon will destroy Etheria, says another.

It grows harder for Adora to differentiate their voices, both of them echoing in her ears.

She doesn’t know if she’s dreaming, she doesn’t know if this is real or not. But it doesn’t matter. The only thing she knows is that she won’t feel better until she takes the sword. It’s heavier than it’s ever been as she lifts it. As soon as her hands touch the sword —a rainbow of colors burst forth from it. There’s power within it, power she’s never wielded before. It scares her.

She starts to understand—the sword has always been her best weapon, but it’s been deceptive. Light Hope has been deceptive. It's a third voice who tells her that—her own.

Adora doesn’t know why she knows that she must destroy the sword, but it's there within her. Instinct, maybe, or self preservation she didn't know she had. It happens suddenly—the sword rises on its own, stronger than her mighty She-Ra strength as she tries to lower it. It is no easy thing to resist.

When the sword breaks, Adora can't even process it at first. The colors dissipate, leaving her in complete darkness. Adora is back as Adora, and doesn't even realize it until she tries to see through her bangs that have fallen onto her forehead, sweaty and displaced.

Light Hope thanks her, but Adora doesn’t understand what she's thanking her for. Didn't Light Hope want her to use the sword? Light Hope vanishes as Adora blinks, just like a dream. Is that what this is?

Swift Wind goes to her side, tucks her underneath one of his wings.

Adora cries. She doesn't know why. This reality might not even be real. The sword was the key, wasn't it? If this was real, can she ever go back home? Can she ever be She-Ra again? Who is she, without her?

*

Adora wakes up and with each new morning that passes, the weight of this world crushes her. Some days, she feels as though she's waking up fully. Other days, like today, she feels like she's been gone for so long, she's spent more time in this reality than she ever has in a single portal reality.

But how could this be real? Their situation feels too terrible to be true. She-Ra is gone. Catra is gone. Glimmer is gone. And the Rebellion loses more territory to Prime and the bots every day.

The good news is, she’s permitted to fight Prime’s bots. The bad news is, she’s still too reliant on She-Ra’s strength, and they keep losing ground.

It wasn't always like this, Adora knows. Before princesses and portals, back when her routine was set for her in the Fright Zone, Adora was a good fighter on her own. She knew how to balance on her feet, knew her own strength, and how to use others' weaknesses against them. Now, she overestimates her strength. She reaches for a sword that no longer rests on her back. She starts to call for the honor of something she still isn't clear on.

And it doesn’t matter anyway, not at all. They finally get to the Fright Zone, and neither Catra or Glimmer are there. Neither are Prime or Hordak. There’s no one living there.

“What do we do?” Bow asks.

“We won’t stop until we find them,” Adora says.

*

A week later it's Entrapta who finds out that Catra and Glimmer are out in space, somewhere far away.

And it's Entrapta who fixes the ship, who continues to track Prime’s location.

And then it's time for their mission.

Adora’s actually permitted to go on it, this time. Maybe now that the threat of Light Hope is gone, they’re not worried Adora can make things worse. Maybe now they believe she can be useful. Or maybe now they’re too desperate to care. It doesn’t matter. As long as they can get Catra and Glimmer back to them, Adora is willing to risk everything.

One day Catra comes back with a generous slice of cake, looking very grim for someone holding a piece of cake. It could almost be comical, if their situation weren’t so dire. “I figured something out,” she says, handing the cake to Glimmer. “I’ll come back for you later, but we're going to get off this ship. Today. You have to trust me on this okay?”

It's the best news Glimmer could hope for. “What’s going on?”

“You were right about Mara's ship. They fixed it somehow. Adora, Bow, and Entrapta, probably, they’re on their way right towards us.”

“But that’s great, isn’t it? We have a chance to go home!”

But Catra doesn't share her enthusiasm, she looks more scared than Glimmer's ever seen her. “We’ve gotta get you out of this

room before they get close. Adora can’t enter this ship, Glimmer, no matter what.”

“Okay,” Glimmer agrees. “I trust you. If you think there’s a way out, we have to take it."

"The next time you see me, it'll be time. Brace yourself."

Glimmer nods, her heart racing. This is it. Glimmer didn't know how long she and Catra would be stuck here, but she thought it would be longer. The relief that their friends are coming is so strong it nearly brings her to tears.

*

“Catra?” asks Adora from the intercom. *“What’s going on?”*

“I’m sending Glimmer to you,” she says.

And it’s only as the door closes that Glimmer realizes Catra doesn’t plan on coming with her. It's why Catra was so serious earlier. And it isn't right. “Catra, get over here while you still can! I’m not going without you!”

Catra shakes her head. “I’ve got to make sure you make it out. This function isn’t going to work automatically.” There's banging on the door and shouting. The clones are trying to make their way in. The two of them had a head start, but Prime has eyes everywhere. “And besides, I can’t let them interfere with this.”

“Catra,” Glimmer says, horrified. But she’s powerless from where she stands.

“Get ready,” Catra says.

And this isn’t how it’s supposed to go. It was supposed to be the two of them escaping together. But Glimmer realizes Catra is right, the technology won’t work if neither one is there to command it. The last thing Glimmer sees is Catra fighting off Prime’s clones. And then she’s gone.

*

It's Bow who catches her, and Glimmer doesn’t want to leave the safety of his arms.

*

"What happened?" Adora asks.

And Glimmer fights the urge to cry. Her tears are of no use here, and they won't be any good for Adora. "Catra saved me," she says, watching Adora's expression carefully. Adora merely nods, accepting Glimmer's words.

Adora fidgets with her hands. S"o what do we do now? We can't go back to Etheria, I can't, I won't... I can't leave her there."

“I know. I didn’t expect you to,” Glimmer replies. “We’re going to go back for her.” That’s the only thing that seems to calm Adora down for now.

*

“Adora still isn’t sure what's real or not,” Bow tells Glimmer later that night. Adora pointed out one of the spare bedrooms, but Glimmer didn’t take it, and Bow didn’t question it when she showed up in his room. “I don’t know. I was hoping that even under the circumstances, once she destroyed the sword, or once we left Etheria, she’d know for sure, somehow.”

“It’s going to take time for her to accept it,” Glimmer says, still trying to process everything Bow had told her about how Adora snuck into the Crystal Castle. How Swift Wind went with her, and Bow found her sobbing under his wing. How the sword was gone, and Light Hope too. “She might just not want to admit it. Especially if Light Hope wasn't the ally she thought she was.”

“Are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” she replies. “I mean, I’ll be better once we get Catra back and defeat Prime, but you know. For now I'll be okay.”

“One step at a time,” says Bow.

“Yeah." Glimmer pauses. There's been so much to process ever since she got on this somehow still functional spaceship. “Is it true what Adora said about not having She-Ra? That she's really gone?”

Bow nods slowly.

"Poor Adora," Glimmer eventually says.

"And Catra? She really saved you?"

"She did, but I think it was more for Adora than it was for me."

“We'll get her back,” Bow affirms. "And we're all going back home together." He kisses her goodnight. She sleeps better than she has in ages.

Space is cold and confusing. When Adora wakes, her eyes land on stars in every direction. They're beautiful and impossibly far away. Could the portal be working with memories she had as a baby? The portal knows—knew—everything. Could it take her to places she never once imagined, never even knew existed?

Adora's tried to pay more attention to smaller things. The way her hair has been growing longer. Her nails too—though she keeps biting them to the quick. Did this not happen in the portal? Or did she just not notice, too distracted by everything else to measure every change in her body?

Glimmer has returned to them unscathed, but Catra might not be so lucky. The Catra in this reality, anyway. This Catra who cared for her and regretted what she had done, this Catra who had tried to take back what she said before, this Catra who risked everything to get her out of the portal.

This Catra who Adora would have to risk everything to save, simulation or not. What else can Adora do? Etheria is being attacked, and Catra is gone. Trapped on an incomprehensibly large enemy ship without a single friend or even an ally.

She has waves of it: realizations that this all must be real. Realizations that this is too horrible to real. Will she ever be sure one way or another? And at this point, does it matter?

Adora falls asleep and wakes up with a backdrop of stars each day. There is no difference between night and day anymore, the same way she can't tell the difference between the realities before her eyes.

It's only as Adora holds up a collapsing cave that she feels awake in a way she hasn't before the portal was set off—She-Ra is within her. The feeling is fleeting, she disappears almost as soon as she reappears. And it's strange, there's no sword here to set this off. Was it a glitch in the portal? But Adora can't quite shake it off, the

presence of She-Ra, her focus on the present. Something in her heart is telling her that it’s not impossible for this to be real, for this worst-case situation she finds herself in to be real. Can she move forward? Is she brave enough to do this? But it doesn't matter. Brave or not, she has to move forward.

*

The fear Adora feels is real. Facing Prime—Adora isn’t sure how the portal could make him up. His cool green-eyed gaze, the way he moves more like a machine than a person. The slow way he speaks, like he has all the time in the world. And maybe he does.

And there's Catra—her eyes are Prime green and terrible—could the portal make this up? Could any simulation be as terrible as this? Could it really take Catra away like this?

But she’s still in there. Adora sees the way her eyes flash to yellow and blue, the way she’s still fighting against Prime. Adora will have to fight just as strong, just as brave. She doesn’t have any other choice.

When Catra falls, Adora jumps after her. It’s all she knows. Real or not real, Adora would do this in any reality. And it's comforting to know that in this reality, this Catra would do the same for her.

And after she hits the ground, Adora holds Catra close. Her breathing ceases, and it’s after Catra’s last breath that Adora knows this is real. She’s back, and Catra is gone.

She-Ra returns not long after. A simulation can’t be killed, a simulation can’t bring back She-Ra. Apparently, neither can a sword.

Magic courses through her veins, and when Catra breathes again, Adora feels like she understands now. She is back in her world.

Out on Mara's ship far away from the planet she loves, Adora knows this is real. And Catra is alive.

"Hey, Adora," Catra says weakly.

Adora holds her close, and finds she can't stop crying. But it's not the bad kind.

*

A day has passed since they got away from Prime. Adora wants to give Catra her space, but she also doesn't want to be too far from her. Not after everything. Adora paces in the hallway outside the door where Catra rests. They're headed back towards Etheria. They'll get there one of these days. She and Catra will figure everything out one of these days.

Adora returns to the middle of the ship, with the hopes of not disturbing Catra with her frequent pacing.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asks.

"I think so," Adora says. She stares at Glimmer, really taking in the new way she's parted her hair, the new clothes she wears. A solitary white sleeve. White for mourning. White for her. "Glimmer?"

"Yeah?"

"It really is you, isn't it?"

Glimmer beams at her—warm and dazzling and real. "Yeah, it's me."

Adora hugs her and Glimmer clings to her tight.

Bow walks in and stares at them. "What's going on?"

“Adora’s back!”

“Uh, I know that,” Bow says, confused.

“I *mean*,” Glimmer intones, “*she* knows she’s back!”

Bow’s face lights up as he runs towards them, hugging both of them. Adora finds that she’s crying all over again. They all are.

“I missed you both so much,” she says. “I’m sorry for not believing I was back sooner.”

“It’s okay," says Glimmer wobbly in a way that makes Adora want to cry harder.

“Glimmer, I took a swing at you!”

“It’s kind of funny in retrospect.” They all laugh at that.

“I’m back,” Adora says again.

“You are,” both Glimmer and Bow affirm.

It’s all relief, now. Sure, the circumstances aren't great and Adora wishes that Prime wasn’t in the process of conquering Etheria, and it would be preferred if they weren't so far away from Etheria, but at the same time, Catra left the Horde. Together, they’re going to be unstoppable. Of this, Adora is certain.

*

Adora knocks on Catra’s door after a while. “Can I come in?”

There’s a quiet response, but it’s a yes.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora says.

“Hey, Adora.”

They stay silent for a moment. “Are you feeling okay?” Adora asks, which seems like a strange thing to ask to someone who died and came back, whose body was taken over and then set free.

“Yeah, I’m okay. Are you?”

“I think so,” Adora says, nervous now, for some reason. Everything she’s said in the past few weeks, everything she’s done, everything she’s seen, it was real. Even if Catra has no memory of those other realities, they will always feel real to Adora. Every good moment and every bad moment.

Being around Catra, *this* Catra, knowing that this is the same girl she grew up with and missed and fought against, she doesn’t know how to react around her now. Catra chose to switch sides. Catra had missed her, Catra had *mourned* her, Catra had switched sides for her before she even returned to this world. Adora never thought she would really see the day.

Catra seems to notice something is different about her. “You’re back,” she says, eyes wide. "You know you're back."

“Yeah, I do. How can you tell?”

“You’re not looking at me as if I’m a ghost anymore.”

Adora rubs the back of her neck. “Was I really that bad?”

“It’s understandable. I might as well have been a ghost to you, after everything that’s happened.” There’s a pause. “How did you figure it out?”

“You died, back there. I didn’t, I don’t know. That felt real. And She-Ra came back after. I think she came back to bring you back. And that’s when I could tell. I was never able to transform into She-Ra in the portal, I couldn't without the sword. And then when

I had the sword again, I still wasn't convinced it was real, especially once it broke, But I’m sure now.”

“You’ll have to thank She-Ra, for me, then,” Catra says after a minute.

“Catra." She takes a moment to take in the raw expression on her face. It's different now. But maybe it's a good thing. Maybe Adora loves her. Maybe she's never not loved her. And maybe Catra loves her too.

"Have you slept at all? Since Prime?"

The question catches Adora off guard. Now that she thinks about it, she can't recall. She doesn't want to sleep. "I don't want to," she says.

"Try again."

"Seriously?"

"Seriously. You look exhausted. And I'm... I'm exhausted too."

"If I sleep, can I stay with you?"

"On this?" Catra gestures towards her twin size cot.

It's the same size as the cots they slept on in the Fright Zone. They can make it work. "We can both fit."

"You sure?"

Catra slides over, makes room. They both fit. Adora falls asleep in under thirty seconds.

And when she wakes up in the morning, with Catra pressed against her, she no longer has any doubts that this is real.

It goes like this: Catra wakes up at an undetermined time to find Adora staring and smiling at her, like they're kids having a sleepover back in the Fright Zone, not two people who nearly got themselves killed two days ago.

"What are you so happy about, weirdo?" Catra asks, but she's smiling too as the question escapes her. She can't help it. Adora's smile is contagious. It always has been. And after everything, Adora is still by her side. If Catra thinks about it too hard she might start crying, and she doesn't want that.

"I don't know. I'm just... relieved that things are finally going to be okay again."

"The war's far from over," Catra points out, but Adora's expression doesn't change.

"Yeah," Adora agrees. "I know. But we're going to win."

"How do you know?"

"Because I know," Adora says with that annoying confidence of hers. Her smile has turned into a full out grin. And oh, that grin. Catra didn't think she'd ever see it pointed her way again. Not like this. Catra's whole heart swells. "Because I'm *back*, Catra. You helped save me from the portal, and now She-Ra's back. She's part of me again."

It sounds so simple, when Adora says it. Catra only hopes that it's enough.

"And y*ou're* back, by my side. That has to mean something."

"Yeah, I think it does."

Adora practically jumps out of bed with as much energy as ever. "Come one, let's go grab breakfast."

Part of Catra wants to protest, to insist she just wants to go back to sleep. She is still exhausted, but she wants to spend time with Adora even more than her desire to sleep. So Adora wins this one. But Adora winning no longer feels like a bad thing. Catra nearly tells her so. But she doesn't. She'll tell her one day.

*

It goes like this: Catra tests the waters to figure out the space between them. Adora tries to summon She-Ra back, and Catra sits on her lap. Adora feigns annoyance, but doesn't try to move her off. They sit next to each other at every meal, they share a bed every night.

Glimmer asks her about it one morning, when Adora and Bow are given a lecture by Entrapta about Darla's controls. "So, what's going on between you and Adora?" she asks, with a smirk. Catra wants to hit her.

"Nothing. We're just... existing next to each other."

"Existing next to each other," Glimmer repeats, unimpressed.

"Yes," Catra insists.

But Glimmer doesn't buy it. "And what does that mean, exactly?"

"It means we're figuring it out. She just accepted that she's really back in our reality. I can't ask for anything else."

"But you want to ask for something else."

"That's not what I meant."

"Isn't it?"

"What's happening with you and Bow?" Catra asks, changing the subject.

Glimmer flushes, and tries to teleport, and then complains about not being able to teleport in space before marching off to somewhere else on the spaceship.

*

It goes like this: Catra doesn't think twice before she puts herself between Adora and the creature that's been following them. If after everything that's happened, Catra gets killed by a monster that turns invisible, it's worth it. Adora will make it out. Catra got her second chance, there was never any telling how long it would last.

But it doesn't come to that. There is a connection she has with this creature. Catra knows what it's like to be afraid and alone. There were many times in her childhood she wished she could become invisible.

And as grateful as Catra is for her new companion, Melog complicates things slightly. If Catra is across the room from Adora, Melog sits by Adora’s side. If Catra spends too much time staring at Adora, Melog gives her a knowing look.

Tonight, the five of them are gathered on the ship, sitting in a circle. Melog rubs against Entrapta's knee and then curls up in Adora's lap.

Adora grins. "Wow, I can't believe I'm their favorite."

Catra's face warms, but Bow and Glimmer laugh in agreement. Entrapta comes up with possible species' names for Melog, but Catra tunes out everyone else, paying attention to the way Adora laughs. It occurs to Catra that both Adora and Melog are made of

magic, and being near them makes her feel like she's made of magic, too. Maybe she is.

*

And it goes like this: it’s almost as if they were never enemies in the first place. As if that was never their reality. Inside jokes emerge, getting puzzled faces from Glimmer and Bow and Entrapta, and full out snorts from Adora who can’t contain her laughter. Catra can’t believe Adora still remembers moments that Catra herself had forgotten. Like when Catra trimmed her left hand's nails too short and she spent half a day convincing Adora that they were retractable. Or the time Catra told Adora she should get bangs as a joke but Adora took her seriously and made a grave mistake.

“Once Catra made me an entire cake out of gray ration bars,” Adora announces, a sappy smile on her face. But she meets Catra’s eyes, and Catra realizes she must be grimacing, because Adora’s face falls. “That wasn’t real was it?” she asks, pained.

“It was, but it wasn’t. That happened in the first portal.”

"But you do remember?"

"I do. It was my idea after all. How else were we supposed to celebrate your promotion to Force Captain?"

Adora blinks, trying to piece it together. But then her smile returns. No, worse. It's a smirk. "I can't believe you liked me that much."

Catra doesn't have a retort for her. Catra liked her that much in every reality, there's no denying it.

That night, Catra asks Glimmer if she can help her make a cake with the ingredients still left behind from Mara’s time. Wrong Hordak helps. Somehow, it actually tastes sweet.

“Better than the ration bars,” Adora jokes, after grabbing a piece with her bare hands and taking a bite. Glimmer was telling the truth back on Prime’s ship, Adora doesn’t use a fork to eat her cake slice.

“That’s not saying much,” Catra points out. “*Everything* is better than ration bars.”

“Still true, though,” replies Adora, eagerly helping herself to another bite. There's frosting stuck on her upper lip.

Of course, Catra finds it cute. "You eat your cake like a weirdo," she says, deflecting her thoughts.

"She's right," Glimmer agrees.

"I think you're both full of it."

"Brothers, what is the correct way to eat cake?" Wrong Hordak asks earnestly.

The question sends Adora into a laughing fit.

*

It goes like this. Sometimes Catra almost feels like she's the one who entered a new reality, one as lovely as this. One where Adora is by her side, laughing every day. One where Catra has friends beyond Adora, and laughs alongside them as if she always belonged. One where in spite of the war waiting for them back home on Etheria, Catra's life feels good in a way it never has before. It's lighter, somehow. And maybe that's enough.

EPILOGUE

"What do you think it's going to be like back home?" Catra asks. Adora, Bow, and Entrapta had filled her on Bright Moon getting taken over, but that was weeks ago.

Adora frowns. "Different. Who knows what other territories the Rebellion will have lost. As strong as we are, we're outnumbered. And with the clones, Prime is able to keep a close eye even from space." Then her face softens. "But it will be different in a good way, too. There are stars everywhere, Catra. More moons, too. I can't wait for you to see it. We'll have some sightseeing to do after the war."

"You're that sure we're going to win?"

"What is it going to take for me to convince you?"

Catra shrugs. She knows Adora's strength, with or without She-Ra's help, but Prime still frightens her. That's when Adora leans forward, and kisses her, as if she’s kissed her a hundred times before. Catra's too stunned to kiss her back.

Without pause, Adora pulls away. “Besides, Prime is off Etheria for now, which gives us plenty of time to find out his weaknesses. Glimmer says magic is one of them. And we have the advantage of space travel, we didn't have that two weeks ago.”

“You’re really just going to kiss me for the first time and then go back to talking about Prime?”

Adora flushes red. Catra's not sure she's ever seen her so flustered, delighting in the sight. "Did I really? I'm sorry."

“Don't be,” Catra says. "Kiss me again." So Adora does, properly this time.

And then Adora pulls away with a giggle.

Catra raises a brow, feeling self conscious. "What's so funny?"

"I don't know if this makes sense, but if I still had doubts about whether or not this is real, kissing you would have confirmed that it is."

"What do you mean by that?" Catra asks, voice hushed.

“In every other reality, other versions of you just went for it. But *you* hesitated.”

"Portal versions of me tried to kiss you?" That concept had never occurred to her. It makes her sad in a way she can't quite place.

"Not all of them. But some of them."

"Oh." Catra sits with that. "I'm sorry. I don't want to make things even more confusing for you."

“I know,” Adora tells her. “But you’re not. And you don't have to keep apologizing."

“But you didn't really hear me apologize before. I know you’ll hear me now.”

“I do.” Adora kisses her again.

The stars outside shine brilliantly and far away. Is it possible they’re really softer now?

“So now what?” Catra asks.

“We’ll take care of Etheria. We’ll get ourselves back home.” Adora squeezes her hand.

Catra smiles. Because the Fright Zone was never home, and even Etheria wasn't what Catra ever considered home. Because Adora was always what felt like home, and out here surrounded by stars, Catra knows that they will both be okay. They have each other.

Out in deep space, impossibly far from the Whispering Woods, the world is now just beginning, she can feel it.

Chapter End Notes

wow. WOW. thank you for all the support and patience <33333 i cannot believe it has been two years since i updated this fic (and unfortunately left y'all hanging with one chapter left). i am so sorry for the wait, it wasn't my intention to leave it alone for so long. and of course once i returned to this chapter, it was daunting realizing that this was it. so truly, i hope it was worth the wait. endings are HARD.

anyway, to me, save the cat always felt like the real finale of the series, as it's the moment catra and adora come back together. since this fic is canon divergent, i wanted it to end at a point i felt was true to this specific telling. there wasn't anything i particularly wanted to add to the second half of season five, and i wanted to avoid repeating canon. i hope you find this ending gratifying!!

for anyone who has read my other wips (calypso + youtube exes au) i promise i have not forgotten them, but i don't currently have an idea of when they'll be updated. one day soon, hopefully, but i work full time and have a novel i've been working on, which is insane. however i do have more upcoming catradora fics i want to post in the next few months, i promise!

i ended up going through a lot of loss in real life while working on this fic and am grateful i had this story as an outlet and that y'all were open to reading it. i am also grateful for how much i have grown as a writer during this process, catradora really is just that powerful. where is the she-ra movie tho :(

thank you sam for hyping me up being so encouraging <3 thank you nbc22 and jthawky your comments are always so

kind and mean a lot to me <3 and sincerely thank you everyone for being on this journey <333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!